Silent Tears

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/36179974.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warnings:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence, Rape/Non-Con

Categories:
F/F, Gen

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Castaspella (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Melog (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Past Rape/Non-con, Rape Recovery, Discussion of Abortion, Abortion, Safe and Legal, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner's A+ Parenting, Tampering with contraceptive device, Mentioned Horde Prime (She-Ra), Therapy Cat Melog (She-Ra), Angst with a Happy Ending, Angst and Hurt/Comfort, Catra Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Poor Catra (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, Catra Gets a Hug (She-Ra), Castaspella is a good Aunt, Suicidal Thoughts, Medical Procedures, accurate medical procedures, Hiding Medical Issues, Unplanned Pregnancy, Forced Pregnancy, Safe Legal and Accessible, Angst and Fluff and Smut, Eventual Smut

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English

Series:
Part 3 of Stories Never Shared, Part 6 of Tell Me Everything

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by Paganaidd

Summary

A few weeks after the defeat of Horde Prime, Catra discovers that many of the experiences she believed to be mere hallucinations are all too real.

This begins right after Casting Out Shadows ends.

Notes

This story is rated Mature and could be upsetting. Go back and read the tags. Explicit discussions of sexual assault and healthcare for people with uteruses.

This is an explicitly Pro-choice story. If you are in favor of forced pregnancy and birth go find something else to read. I don't want to hear about it.

The Obvious Questions

Chapter Summary

Castaspella asks the right questions.

Chapter Notes

Go back and read the tags.

This chapter features discussions of past rape and other trauma.

“What?” The word came out as an involuntary squeak. “Seriously? Why would you even *ask* that?” Sounding both offended and shaken, Catra whispered, as if she feared someone might overhear.

If the sorceress was not aware of Catra’s history, the attitude would have annoyed her. People came to Mystacor for healing; privacy was paramount. The walls and doors of all the rooms were thick enough to prevent sound from carrying. They sat in Castaspella's personal office, which was as soundproof as stone and magic could make it. Even the window, open to allow the morning breeze, had been enchanted to allow sound in, not out. As it was, Castaspella took it as another confirmation that no one had ever been particularly respectful of the girl’s privacy. Then Castaspella chided herself; she wasn't sure whether Catra or Adora had ever been allowed to be children.

The young woman had come to Castaspella that morning for a routine examination of her almost-healed wound. When the sorceress asked how she felt, Catra said offhandedly, “A little tired.”

Melog, lounging on the floor next to the sofa where Catra sat, got to their feet and gently nipped at Catra’s hand, adding a reproving yowl.

Catra rolled her eyes. “Yeah, okay.” She crossed her arms and her tail flicked the leg of the sofa. “So, I guess I mean I'm *a lot* tired,” she admitted. “I’ve been having this deep, irresistible need to power-nap every afternoon for a couple of hours. I can’t stay awake. But, isn’t that just normal when you’re healing from a bad infection?” The last was directed more at Melog than Castaspella.

“It can be.”

Again Melog growled at Catra. She growled back at him, adding a hiss, but then she straightened up. “So, Melog says I should also mention I’m still having these weird bouts of nausea in the morning.”

“How often?”

“Not every day.” She thought for a second. “Maybe a few times a week? It’s got to be the new food. I don’t know. I’m fine if I eat something like a ration bar when I first get up. Then, I’m okay. By the time breakfast shows up it’s gone.”

While Castaspella processed that, Catra leaned in and muttered, “And, this is just weird. I really don’t know what the fuck is wrong with these.” She gestured towards her breasts. “They’re...I don’t know...bigger than they usually are. And they hurt.”

That was not nearly enough information to make a diagnosis but certainly enough to suggest a common condition. The question earned the astonished reaction from the former soldier who still gaped at her.

Castaspella leaned forward. "Are you sure?” the sorceress asked in the gentlest voice she could muster. “The most common cause for this particular constellation of symptoms is pregnancy.”

At the word “pregnancy,” Catra inhaled sharply, her ears going back. Cheeks red, she shook her head, but Melog shoved at her with their nose, trilling questioningly.

“What? No!” She hissed at them, the fur standing up on her neck, tail lashing. "I told you. It wasn't. It couldn’t be."

Not convinced, they put their paws on her thigh, and stood on their hind legs, mewing and chittering.

Whatever Melog said struck a nerve. Catra went entirely still. The pupils of her eyes contracted to slits, and she looked down at her fists clenched in her lap, her attention turned inward as though doing a series of rapid mental calculations.

"Catra?” Castaspella said softly. “It’s all right. I won’t judge. Whatever happened.” She hoped Catra could believe that as she reiterated her question. “Is there any chance you could be pregnant?”

"No!" One shaking hand drifted up towards Catra’s neck. Her eyes darted towards the motion, and she jerked as if she’d startled herself. Growling, she clenched her fist and dropped it to rest on Melog’s back.

A horrible suspicion formed in Castaspella’s mind.

Melog meowed softly at Catra, stretching up to lick her face. Her ears dropped, and her eyes shimmered with tears. She sucked in a breath and let it out in a long sigh. “Okay, yeah. Maybe," she agreed in a soft monotone, not looking at either Castaspella or Melog. But then she rallied, going on in a stronger voice, meeting Melog’s eyes, “but I told you! That couldn’t happen.”

They answered back, chirruping, then they growled and gently rubbed their face into her jaw before sitting back on their haunches with their head tilted questioningly.

“What?” Her ears pinned back against her head. “No, it never occurred to me. ” Slowly, she lifted her right hand and pressed her thumb into her left bicep with great deliberation. “I mean, why would he? Look, it’s…Oh.” She stopped speaking and all the blood drained out of her face, leaving her ashen. She stuck out her arm, ruffled her short fur, seeming to look for something underneath

the skin. “Oh. No,” she quietly hissed. “Ohno. Nononono." Her movements grew more agitated as she ran her thumb from armpit to elbow before she seemed to give up, dropping her shaking hands to her lap. Staring into the distance, her expression was haunted, and her tail lashed. "It’s...not there anymore."

“What’s not there?” Castaspella asked, trying to make sense of her words and the peculiar action.”I don’t understand.”

Catra met the older woman’s gaze with an effort, and she shifted uncomfortably, crossing and uncrossing her arms. “Uh...you know...the um…” she made a vague gesture towards her upper arm as if that explained everything. “Y’know.”

“I actually don’t know,” Castaspella said gently.

Catra looked away, slumping her shoulders and choosing to stare unseeingly out of the window. “The implant.” She spat the word out in a mortified whisper. “You know...it stops people bleeding all over the damned place once a month or going into heat. It’s also supposed to keep you from...ugh...” The sentence trailed off into a noise of disgust as if continuing was too excruciating. Dislodging Melog’s head from her lap, the young woman pulled her legs up onto the couch and wrapped her arms and tail tightly around herself.

“Getting pregnant?” Castaspella supplied gently. The sorceress noted that yet again, Hordak’s former second flinched from the word. "This is common in the Horde?"

Catra nodded miserably. Melog shrank down to the size of a large dog and leaped up to sit beside her. She put one arm around her protector, took a deep breath, and spoke rapidly, still not looking at Castaspella. “We all get them. As soon as we’re old enough. You can’t have soldiers just running around randomly reproducing, can you? And…" her voice sank to a barely audible murmur, and she covered her mouth with her free hand as though she divulged a terrible secret. "People like me..well, I’ve heard our heats are...pretty bad.”

There was a lot to unpack there, but one particular word jumped out at the older woman. “I beg your pardon?” She said it more loudly than she meant to, unable to cover her shock at the idea. “Did you say heats?”

Eyes narrowed, Catra raised her eyebrows as if she thought Castaspella was unexpectedly obtuse. “Well, yeah,” she muttered. “Obviously.” The magicat gestured sharply at herself to indicate her pinned back ears and lashing tail, then went back to hugging her legs. “Duh.” She whispered into her knees.

“Ah.” Castaspella couldn’t think of a way to address that. That the Horde’s education in sexual matters was lacking was no surprise, but this went far beyond expectations. However, addressing those sorts of myths would have to wait. She shook herself and returned to the problem at hand. “Just to be clear: this implant was a contraceptive device? It prevents pregnancy?”

Wincing, Catra nodded.

“And it was removed against your will?”

Another nod.

Her heart sinking, Castaspella took a deep breath to steel herself before she asked the crucial question. "Catra?” She kept her voice low and even, betraying none of her rising anger and horror. “Were you raped while you were a prisoner?”

The terror and fury that flashed across Catra’s face was answer enough. A low inarticulate moan was the only sound she made as she curled further in on herself and buried her face in her arms, her silently shaking shoulders more alarming than a howl. Melog pressed into her side, growing larger until it was as large as she, wrapping itself protectively around her on the expansive sofa.

Worried by Catra’s withdrawal, the sorceress reached out her hand. Before she could open her mouth to speak, Melog growled, snarling and showing their teeth. Their eyes and mane shifted to a red so dark it was almost black.

Slowly Castaspella drew back, holding up both hands palms out in a gesture of surrender, trusting that the magical guardian knew better than she what their ward needed. Their mane smoothed and lightened to a calm blue. She still needed to ask, but perhaps it would be better to ask them. Not daring even to whisper, knowing how sensitive Catra's ears were, she made eye contact with Melog, made a questioning face, pointed at Catra, and mouthed her question soundlessly. "Is she all right?"

They nodded, snuggling more firmly onto the sofa, giving the impression that they felt confident that this shutdown was temporary and within normal limits for Catra.

Castaspella pointed to herself and then the door. Should I leave? she meant.

The creature shook its head, reaching out a giant paw to gently pat the ground. Stay.

After a moment, the sorceress mouthed, "Adora?" The other young woman had gone to Bright Moon to help Glimmer with one of the rebuilding projects, but Castaspella knew she would drop everything to come to Catra's side.

Melog nuzzled at Catra's tense, unmoving form as they protectively curled around it. They looked back and slowly shook their head.

The creature spoke no words but an idea floated into Castaspella's head, and the sorceress understood; Catra needed a safe presence, a validating witness to hear this before she could tell her mate. Someone who would be calm through the inevitable storm and shock. Someone who would not jump in to try to fix it, to fix *her*. Someone who would not need their own grief and rage managed.

Nodding, Castaspella settled back to wait, pulling out the knitting project that she kept in her desk drawer. This was a role she'd taken many times before, as a healer.

After a much shorter time than Castaspella would have expected, Catra came out of her huddle. “Aunt Casta?”

“Yes?” Castaspella looked up from her knitting. The magicat’s gold and blue eyes gleamed out of the shadows in the dim corner of the office, her expression young and vulnerable.

“What you asked a minute ago? I-I-I think so? Maybe?” The tentative and fragile admission was so faint the sorceress could have missed it. ”I thought it was all...I can’t...I can’t tell what was real.” The last word ended on a high-pitched little squeak.

“That’s all right. It’s fine if you don’t,” Castaspella said softly, “we can figure that out later. Thank you for trusting me with this.” She paused and then thought it would be better if they started tackling the practicalities. “We should do a pregnancy test first. We can do it as soon as you’re ready.”

That seemed to be the right tactic. Catra’s mouth firmed to a grim line. She swiped impatiently at the wetness on her face. “All right.” She rose to her feet. In one motion, the frightened child became the hardened veteran. “So. Let’s do this. What do you need to do? Take blood or something? Or is it a spell?”

Castaspella stood too, laying her knitting aside. She crossed the room to the drawer where she kept the tests and took one out. “I don’t need any blood. Or magic.” She held the little narrow packet out to Catra, who merely stared at it.

“What do I do with it?”

“You break the seal.” Castaspella pointed. “There’s a stick inside with instructions, but essentially, you urinate on it. You wait three minutes. If it glows, you’re pregnant. If it doesn’t, you’re not.”

“That’s it?”

Castaspella nodded. “You can use my bathroom, or you can take it with you to your room if that’s more comfortable for you.”

“I’ll just…” Catra made a jerky little motion with her head towards the bathroom door. Reaching out, she closed her hand around the package, careful to avoid scratching Castaspella’s hand with the claws that her anxiety wouldn’t allow to retract. Then she disappeared into the bathroom, closing the door behind her with a soft click.

Melog curled back up on the couch and exchanged worried looks with Castaspella.

The wait wasn’t long. After five minutes, Catra emerged from the bathroom as pale as death. “Is that test ever wrong?” She demanded, voice shaking. In her hand, the end of the test stick glowed a steady, certain blue.

“Not usually,” Castaspella replied, standing to take it from her. “But, you can retake it to be sure, if you want.”

For a split second, Castaspella thought Catra was going to take her up on it. That had happened before; sometimes, people needed to do that for their own peace of mind. But then, her ears and tail dropped in defeat. “No. No, that’s okay.”

“Do you want…”

Before Castaspella could finish her sentence, Catra backed away from her. “So...um...Thank you,” she said, her voice unnaturally high-pitched. “For figuring it out, I mean. I’ll just…” She backed towards the door as if Castaspella was a danger she didn’t dare take her eyes off of. The young woman yanked the door open behind her, finally turning to run. Melog leaped across the room to join her.

“Catra! Wait!” Castaspella called out after her. Both of them vanished as she spoke. It was likely that Melog had hidden Catra because she was too angry and afraid to be thinking clearly, and Castaspella couldn't blame her. For now, the sorceress was willing to entrust Catra's safety to the guardian. Later, when she’d calmed down, they could discuss options.

The Problem At Hand

Chapter Summary

Catra begins to process and plan

Mystacor was still unfamiliar to Catra. She didn't have any hiding places scoped out, but somehow she did seem to remember a route to a secret exit. Her mind and body ablaze with adrenalin, she raced down the first set of stairs she came to, plunging headlong.

She rounded a landing and continued racing down on all fours, narrowly missing two people walking up. Ignoring their confused exclamations as she squeezed between them, she kept going; no thought in her head other than she had to get out.

At last, Catra found the long staircase that ended in a shadowed basement that she had never been in. Still, it felt familiar. One magical lantern near the landing lit the long corridor. The gloom didn't bother her, it made her feel safer. Diving into the darkness, Catra only stopped her four-footed flight and staggered upright when she found a mural that she knew hid the door leading to one of the secret entrances of Mystacor. She stood up, panting, her fists and teeth clenched. She needed to get out,

The smooth plaster was without line or seam. She looked for a hidden trigger for a second or two before it came to her that the door's mechanism activated by magic. Of *course*, it did.

Growling, she lashed out at the wall with her claws, leaving deep gashes. She clawed the wall until all the plaster that hid the door coated the floor with white dust, and she slashed into raw living stone. Glowing seams appeared, showing the door's outline, but the rock would not give. Pastel blue (to Catra's eyes at least) and harder than metal, the stone oozed a shining liquid from the deeper scratches and claw marks. It flowed out and hardened to crystal, leaving the surface unmarred, erasing every sign of

damage. The glassy surface seemed to mock her. The thought crossed her mind that Prime would always be with her, oozing out of the cracks in her soul until she became that perfectly smooth, perfectly docile, perfectly numb Little Sister that he had created. Once again, to be imprisoned in her own body as his spawn bloated her belly.

She swung harder, tears blurring her vision. If she couldn't break the door, she at least wanted to leave a mark, to see the beautiful stone scarred by her hands, to show that she had existed.

Her hand caught; the thick liquid hardened around her claws, and she tried to snatch her hand away. All but one claw came out of the newly formed crystal. She pushed and pulled it to unhook the nail, then wriggled it up and to the side, trying to yank it free.

Something popped. Agony lit up her nerves and grayed out her vision. "Fuck!" she shrieked. When the spots cleared from her eyes, she saw dots of blood-spattered onto the floor and walls. Warm liquid dripped down her fist as she tucked it into her stomach and raised her good hand.

"Stop." Melog's growl broke through Catra's anguish. They were still with her. The fact felt like a revelation. She had forgotten they existed. "Of course, I am here. I would not leave you." They were settled down on their haunches a little way down the corridor to wait until she had worked out her fury enough to hear them. Now they moved forward, their glowing eyes level with hers, coming between her and the door.

She dropped her upraised hand. "What am I going to do?" Her voice broke into a soft wail on the last word. Without bothering to look, she used the front of her shirt to press against the base of the freely bleeding claw. The adrenaline drained out of her all at once, leaving her sick and cold. Her finger hurt like she'd tried to cut it off at the first knuckle. She crossed her feet under her and dropped down to sit on the floor while she cradled her bloody hand.

The great cat didn’t reply, just curled around her like she was their kitten. They would keep her safe. It floated through Catra’s mind that she knew where the secret door was because Melog had been exploring the place. The stone floor she sat on felt oddly warm, and she shifted around to pillow her head on her friend’s flank—their presence offering her solace and protection even from her own impulses.

Melog’s purr and solid bulk calmed Catra. Every so often, her thoughts would speed up towards panic, but Melog would purr more loudly and shift around so they could lick her ears. No one else was down here, and it reminded her of the secret passages in the Fright Zone where she’d spent her childhood hiding.

“The Sorceress is looking for you,” Melog said eventually.

Catra's guts contorted into a cold ball of dread. Nausea like that that had gripped her in the morning for weeks returned in full force. “We should go. Can you open that door? We can find Adora, and then…” she trailed off. What the fuck was she going to say? *Hey, Adora. Do you remember those nightmares I’ve been having? Yeah. It turns out most of that shit actually happened, and now I’m infested with Prime’s Parasite Thing.* That would go over well.

Melog sat up so they could look at her. “I can open the door. I can also find your mate and take you to her if you wish. But, why do you flee the Sorceress?”

Sometimes Catra was struck by how *alien* Melog was. "Because this is bad.”

“Why?”

Hardly knowing how to answer that, she sputtered out a question. “Well, how is she feeling right now?"

Her friend seemed to consider the question.“She is angry," they said at last.

Catra would have jumped up, but Melog draped themself across her. Rather than making her feel trapped, their weight felt calming.

”It is not you who angers her.” Melog couldn’t read minds, but they understood feelings. "The sorceress has been trustworthy thus far.” They licked Catras' ear.”Why does this change things?"

“B-because…” Catra tried to formulate a way to talk about it, but the words wouldn’t come out. No one talked openly about reproduction in the Horde. The casual way Aunt Casta had thrown around the word “pregnant” shocked Catra to the core. Officially in the Horde, it was called Gestational Leave and commonly people called it “making a new soldier”. Medics could talk clinically about “conception” and “gestation.” Cadets would snicker over words like “breed,” but Catra could count on the fingers of one hand the times she’d heard the “p-word” said out loud. At least one of those times had resulted in multiple injuries to the person who said it. The only time the word ever appeared with any regularity was in certain contraband publications passed around darkened bunk rooms and hidden under mattresses.

“Surely this has happened before?” Melog asked.

From anyone else, the question would have made Catra scream, but Melog really didn’t understand. “No, look. I just don’t know how to explain it.” she waved her hand vaguely, “You can look for yourself.” They were the exact opposite of Prime; they moved quietly and sought permission before opening any door. They never even asked, only getting into her head that way when *she* suggested it.

Her heartbeat slowed, and she let her thoughts drift, reflecting the problem at hand. Melog’s calm spirit ruffled the surface of her mind.

A vivid memory floated to the top of Catra’s thoughts in response to Melog’s gentle probing. She was eleven, maybe twelve when she’d been summoned alone to Shadow Weaver's office. It was

standard procedure that a commander gave “The Talk" to their cadets before they got their implants.

Reading from the health class textbook, Shadow Weaver gave the speech about the gruesome results of uncontrolled reproductive urges and how grateful Horde citizens were to be free of that. But then, she snapped the book closed and stepped forward. “When the Princesses capture someone, the first thing they do is take out the implant, you know.” She spoke hypnotically, hissing like a venomous snake that mesmerized its prey with the force of its gaze. “They leave you at the mercy of your hormones just to create more chaos in the world.”

She turned her back and tilted her mask up just enough to take a long swig from whatever she was drinking. When she spoke again, she slurred just the slightest bit, but it made her sound even scarier. “You’re lucky the Horde took you in. Your kind go mad during their heats. No higher thought at all. Just pure animal instinct driving them to *rut* until they conceive whole litters. Of course, I’ve had only limited success civilizing you.”

The young girl stood stiffly at parade rest, biting her lip, knowing that Shadow Weaver was winding herself up to enumerate every one of her failings and resolving that she would not show the old witch how much it hurt her. Fortunately, a knock on the door saved Catra from that particular trial.

“Dismissed, Cadet.” Shadow Weaver snapped. “Report to the medics tomorrow morning. It will hurt. Do not embarrass me by crying out.”

Catra left Shadow Weaver’s workroom, angry and shaken, but relieved to hear that the actual medics were going to take care of this. An older cadet waited in the hall. “Is she in a good mood?” asked the girl.

Before she could reply (or even laugh bitterly at the idea of the hag ever having a good mood), Shadow Weaver called the girl in, closing the door.

That was unusual; Shadow Weaver seldom dealt with cadets outside of their little squad except to punish them, and that usually took place in the presence of their commanders, not her office. Curious about what the old witch was up to, Catra parked herself in the dark space under a storage shelf in the corridor outside Shadow Weaver's door, listening.

After the initial niceties, the conversation had turned to the cadet's problem. The details were murky to Catra, but Melog poked at the memory, amplifying the recollection. Now, she understood what they were talking about. It did not differ much from the scene just now in Aunt Casta's office. Shadow Weaver finally said in a voice dripping with false compassion, "I'm afraid, my dear, that the test is positive."

The girl started to sob. The crack of a hand hitting the girl's cheek signaled the end of Shadow Weaver's compassion. The cadet cried out in pain.

"Stop that, or I'll give you something to cry about." Shadow Weaver hissed. "You're of decent genetic stock, even if you're resistant to the implant. Be grateful for that."

The sobs quieted; it sounded like a hand was over the girl's mouth, but whether it was the girl's or Shadow Weaver's Catra couldn't tell. A gulping swallow smothered the need to weep. After a few moments, the girl spoke, sounding broken and desperate. "Please, Shadow Weaver, some of the girls said that sometimes you...That you can fix it. That's why I came to you."

"Is that what they say?" Shadow Weaver sounded amused.

"Y-yes." The cadet was starting to come apart. Catra could hear it in the tremor in her voice, and the scent of fear was strong, even through the metal door. That was the worst thing that could happen in front of Shadow Weaver. The woman had an unerring instinct for rooting out every weakness and turning to her advantage. "Please, Shadow Weaver, I'll do anything."

Even at that young age, Catra knew that being in Shadow Weaver's debt was a terrible idea. The woman reminded Catra and Adora every day how the Horde had taken them in. How much they owed to her. Catra could picture the old woman's assessing stare; the one that always made everyone feel like a specimen under glass.

"Oh, my poor child, look at you. So distraught. Perhaps I can help you, after all." Shadow Weaver's voice was dangerously gentle. The cadet squeaked; an involuntary sound of alarm, quickly stifled. Catra knew that sound and she fled.

When she was a little older, Catra heard it whispered (no one ever seemed to realize just how good her hearing was, but that was mostly because she took pains to hide it) that there were others who were willing to fix an implant failure. No one was ever clear on how it was done, and everyone agreed that the price was very high. But the price for unauthorized reproduction was much higher.

Melog's purring grew louder and they licked her face, grounding her in the here-and-now, preventing Catra from spiraling into her bad memories. "I think it may be different here," they said.

"Yeah. Sure." Catra grunted, but a treacherous sliver of hope arose in her heart at Melog's words. Calmer now, she could see that Aunt Casta was not going to have her summarily executed because she was of "inferior genetic stock."

But that might just be because they don't have the stomach for it, supplied the grim voice in her head that always pointed out the flaws in her plans. *Banishment is much more their style.*

Unfortunately, that voice was often accurate. Even here illicit reproduction couldn't be looked upon favorably. She needed a plan for if this went to shit. If Mystacor was out, Bright Moon would be too. She couldn't go back to the Fright Zone, she was too recognizable. The Crimson Waste would probably be her best

bet. Someone there would know a medic who could "correct implant failures."

Can you find someone competent? asked the voice. *You've heard the stories.*

Some of the stories were just cadet nonsense, calculated to scare the shit out of each other, but Catra had heard a few conversations between grown soldiers that made her fur stand up. Stories of infection or hemorrhage. Worse yet were the soldiers who would just throw themselves at a random Princess in the hopes that if they got wounded badly enough, that would take care of the problem.

You'll have to go alone. Now the voice in her head sounded like Shadow Weaver. *You know Adora will never go along with it.*

Catra's heart froze. Pure, heroic, unselfish, *idiotic* Adora would never agree to it. Adora would probably see the Parasite Thing as a "symbol of healing" or some such shit. She would tell Catra that no one would care how the Thing originated, they'd just know it as their child. She'd look at Catra with that stupid hopeful grin, and she would declare that she could love the Thing because it was part of Catra. The Hero of Etheria would be concerned, protective, and so fucking helpful. She'd talk about finding hope in unlikely places and about how love would fix everything. And Catra would break into a million pieces because she wasn't as strong as Adora.

No, the former soldier decided, she was already broken and it was doubtful anything could fix her.

Catra could still feel Prime's hands on her. The metal-tipped talons as they stroked her. The feel of his lips as they brushed hers, the sound of his voice in his ears. For all these weeks, she lied to herself, comforting herself that it wasn't real. But it was. Every awful terror-soaked recollection was real. That was not the worst: the worst were the moments of pleasure as she purred under Prime's ministrations. Those were real too.

“The Sorceress is using magic to search for you.” Melog’s voice broke through Catra’s panicky haze. “Should I let her find you? I believe she wants to help you."

She couldn't just hide down here forever. “Go ahead,” Catra whispered. She knew she could ask Melog to take her to Adora, but there seemed little point. If she took her chances with Aunt Casta now, she could gauge how bad the rest of this was going to break.

In a few minutes, a small white light bobbed in the darkness, coming from the direction of the stairs. Catra sat up slowly.

“Is that my Catra?” Cataspella called out unnecessarily when she was close enough to see her.

The endearment caught Catra off guard. For a second, she couldn’t speak around an inexplicable lump in her throat. She coughed and said, “I’m here.”

The sorceress's face changed as she drew near enough to see them, her eyes going wide, darting from Catra to the floor and then to the wall behind her, taking in the damage Catra had done and the mess she’d made.

Shit. “I...I’m sorry.” Catra jumped to her feet, horrified at her stupidity. She should have known that Aunt Casta would not be impressed. She just did not *think* . “Please...I didn’t mean to. I mean...”

"What happened?” Castaspella didn’t spare another glance at the ruined door. Instead, she sent her little witch light to float up over her head so she could grab Catra by the shoulders, sweeping her gaze down to her feet and up again. “Is this blood all over you?"

At the sudden contact, Catra froze, holding her breath, waiting for the sharp crackle of magic to arc through her. Waiting for the shadows that surrounded them to become solid enough to suffocate her, unable to process the meaning of Castaspella’s questions. “Huh?”

The hands grabbing her arms relaxed their hold, petting down her arms, smoothing her fluffed-up fur, then letting go as the woman stepped back to give her space. “Catra.” Aunt Casta's dark eyes caught and held hers. “You have blood all over you.” She spoke slowly. “What. Happened?”

“Oh.” Catra caught up to what the woman was asking. “Yeah.” Glancing down at herself, she realized that she looked like she’d been in a knife fight. “It was an accident. I guess I snagged a claw and I tore the cuticle.” She held up the digit and gestured with her other hand at the crystal door. “That always makes a mess.”

Aunt Casta took hold of the proffered finger to bring it close enough for her to examine. "I'm sorry. I didn't mean to startle you.” The little light came to hover next to the sorceress. “I just saw all the red, and I worried.”

It did look bad, Catra realized; dark spots dotted the floor and the wall. A palm-sized circle marked the front of her shirt, and the fur on her hand and wrist were black with streaks of dried blood. A snagged claw and torn cuticle always hurt like hell; she’d done that before. It was always messy, but this was a *lot* more messy than usual. Now she saw that the claw was snapped in half, right through the quick, and still oozed sluggishly. “Wow,” was all she could think to say, “that’s never happened before.” No wonder it hurt so much. “Will that grow back?” she asked, worried that she’d blunted it forever.

“Yes, of course,” Aunt Casta said, her tone reassuring. The light floated closer to the claw, and she turned it gently to look at it.. “How did you do this?"

Feeling her cheeks warm Catra shrugged and pointed again at the crystal door. The tip of her claw was suspended in the crystal

The older woman shook her head in amazement. “That stone is about the only material I can think of that could break a magicat’s claws.” Aunt Casta raised her eyes to meet Catra’s. “May I?”

“I guess?" Standing rigidly at attention, Catra set her teeth, expecting the magic to hurt, as she always did. Melog leaned their body against her, supporting her, lending her their strength.

The sorceress drew a minor sigil in the air with her forefinger and then sent it over towards Catra’s hand with a flick. The sensation of soothing warmth settled over her hand, and the oozing stopped. Aunt Casta let go of Catra’s hand. “Is that better?” she asked softly.

“Yeah.” The relief was immediate, the throbbing reduced to a dull ache. “Thank you.”

“You’re welcome.” Aunt Casta’s smile didn’t quite reach her eyes, and Catra felt herself stiffen. That kind of look never boded well. “I wanted to talk to you before Adora got back. I wasn’t sure what you wanted to tell her.”

“What’s there to tell?” Catra’s stomach clenched. The whole surreal thing came crashing down on her head again. “I don’t even know where to start.” Feeling dizzy, she backed up until she leaned against the wall.

“If you want, we can call her back, now.”

“No!” Catra exclaimed. “I mean, can we just wait? To tell her? For a little bit? Please?”

“Of course.” Aunt Casta came to stand beside her, copying her posture and leaning her back against the wall. She clasped her hands behind her and looked down. Catra was grateful. It was easier to talk like this without having to meet the older woman’s eyes. “You don’t have to tell Adora, or anyone, about this until you’re ready.”

“Really?” Catra squeaked, surprised. She figured she would get the Castaspella version of Perfuma’s “The Importance of Honesty” lecture.

Gravely, the woman nodded without looking up. “Yes. With something like this, it’s natural that you might feel apprehensive about how she’ll react.”

Apprehensive was a good word. Totally fucking terrified was closer to the truth. “Uh-huh,” was the reply that slipped past Catra’s lips.

Aunt Casta turned her head to look at Catra. "You should know, all the sorcerers here, including me, have taken vows of secrecy when it comes to those who come here for healing or to study. I promise, no one will hear anything about you from us.”

The unexpected courtesy made Catra’s eyes sting. “Thank you.”

“If you're worried about what to say to Adora, that’s certainly fair. If you want to tell her and just don’t feel like you can find the words, I could help you figure out what to say. I could even come with you to tell her if that would help.”

“Yeah. It might.” Catra’s lips quirked up into the involuntary, nervous smirk that almost always got her a beating when she was a kid. “I mean...it’ll be kind of hard to keep from her, eventually.” She mimed smoothing her hand over where she imagined the curve of her belly would be when the Parasite Thing was full-sized. Catra had no intention of letting it get that far, but Aunt Casta didn't need to know that. Asking for advice on how to talk to Adora might keep the sorceress from figuring that out until she was long gone.

A split second of surprise passed across Aunt Casta’s face before smoothing out. All except for a tiny frown line between her eyebrows. “So.” She went back to looking at her feet. “Perhaps before we talk about that, We should talk about your options.”

Catra shrugged. “What options?” *Is throwing myself off one of your towers an option?* Mystacor had many stairs. Perhaps no one would mind if she threw herself down a few flights. She bit the inside of her cheek and took a breath, returning her attention to

Aunt Casta, who seemed to be waiting for Catra to say something else, but Catra had no idea what she wanted.

The frown lines deepened between the woman's eyebrows. "What do you want to do about this pregnancy?"

Gritting her teeth to keep from shouting, Catra growled, "I don't think what I *want* is relevant here." She hugged herself. "Not like that's anything new," she couldn't help adding.

"Catra." Aunt Casta's chin came up again, and she turned her whole body to face the younger woman. Her eyes were wide with shock before they narrowed into determination. "What you want is the *only* thing that's relevant in this. What do you want to do?"

What kind of question was that? It was like one of those obnoxious questions you were just supposed to think about.

Baring her teeth to snarl a retort, she paused when Melog growled, "Granddaughter, stop. Look at her. She is asking a question that she wants you to answer."

Aunt Casta's lips were pressed into a straight line with just the corners turning down, and her eyebrows slightly raised. She leaned her torso forward and clasped her hands in front of her, giving every impression that she was prepared to wait for as long as it took for Catra to find the words to reply. When Melog spoke, the sorceress's eyes darted to them involuntarily, then snapped to look at Catra's face as though studying her expression.

Confused, Catra snapped her mouth shut. She swallowed. "I don't understand," she admitted in a tremulous voice. "Why are you asking me that?" Melog pressed into her leg, steadying her.

The older woman's eyebrows crept up towards her hairline and she covered her mouth with one hand with the air of someone who has just discovered a terrible truth about the world. Then her hand slowly dropped and her face sank into sadness. "I believe we've been talking at cross-purposes." Aunt Casta said softly. She

looked around at the darkened tunnel and shivered. “Would it be all right if we went back upstairs? I’m cold down here.”

“She is right, Granddaughter.” Melog chirruped, giving Catra's elbow a nudge. “We should go back.”

They were both right, but it felt insurmountable to leave the cool dimness of the basement hallway. Catra glanced down at herself. “Uh, you better hide us then,” she told Melog dryly, “otherwise Mystacor’s guard is going to assume I murdered someone down here.”

“I'll tell them I was dabbling in necromancy, and you were assisting me.” Aunt Casta replied in the same tone.

It took Catra a second to put together what Aunt Casta was saying, then she remembered what the sorceress had said about reanimating Shadow Weaver just so she could murder her properly. She turned her head to look at the woman; One corner of Aunt Casta’s mouth turned upwards into a sly little smile.

Catra involuntarily huffed a surprised chuckle. “Anytime,” she drawled. The dark humor thawed the cold ball of anxiety in her chest enough that she was able to get her feet to move forward, slowly walking the long spiral upwards towards the light.

Examining the Options

Chapter Summary

Aunt Casta introduces Catra to a friend.

Chapter Notes

CW: Discussion and description of medical procedures. PTSD

Go back and read the tags.

“Is it all right if I clean you up?” Aunt Casta said as they walked. “It will be quicker than stopping to change.”

“I guess?” Catra didn’t like how uncertain she sounded, but it made sense. She stopped to let Aunt Casta do her thing.

The sorceress drew another sigil in the air. This time, the magic felt like a warm puff of air that fluffed up Catra's clothes and fur, leaving them clean and dry. “Oh. Um. Thanks.” Catra muttered, feeling stupid for getting so freaked out by a bit of magic.

“You’re welcome,” Aunt Casta said, apparently not noticing Catra’s discomfort. “I took the liberty of talking to one of the midwives, and she’s expecting us.

“Midwives?” Catra wasn’t familiar with the word and wasn’t comfortable just waiting for context clues. “They’re...what? Like healers that specialize in this?” she gestured at her stomach. “She wants to see me right now?”

“Yes. She’s an old friend of mine. I…” Aunt Casta hesitated for a few long seconds and then took a breath before saying, “I didn’t quite realize how different things were in the Horde. Regarding pregnancy, I mean.”

The word made Catra flinch again, but Aunt Casta didn't notice. Instead, the sorceress shook her head ruefully. "I'm sorry." She paused and stood silently to let a group of people move past their invisible forms.

Neither woman spoke again until they stood outside one of the doors on the ground floor. Aunt Casta knocked, and a voice called out, "Come in."

The little room was much smaller than Aunt Casta's office. Thick, intricately patterned carpets cushioned Catra's feet. A small, beautifully carved wooden desk was situated perpendicular to the wall with two soft chairs in front of it. Under the window was a little couch with a blanket neatly folded on the end. Shelves stacked with books and little trinkets lined the back wall, giving the impression of cozy chaos rather than Aunt Casta's soft minimalism.

The woman who sat behind the desk was thin, with big doe eyes and delicate antlers springing from her brow. She stood to greet them as they came in. Startled, Catra realized she would rival Scorpia's height, although she probably weighed less than one of Scorpia's arms.

"Hello." The woman's voice was warm, and her smile genuine. "You're Catra?"

The sensation of a lump of ice was back in Catra's chest, freezing her throat. Unable to say anything, she nodded and stiffly sat in one of the chairs.

Aunt Casta hovered in the doorway for a second, then she asked, "Would you prefer me to stay or go?"

Catra glanced at Melog, who nodded. "Stay. Please?" Catra asked the sorceress very quietly, speaking around the ice with difficulty.

"Yes, of course." Aunt Casta came fully into the room, closing the door behind her and sitting down in the other chair.

“Castaspella tells me that you have had an unintended conception?” The midwife’s tone was serious but so calm she could have been talking about the weather.

Catra nodded, flattened her ears, and looked away.

“Do you have any idea how far along you might be?”

Catra shook her head, not sure how you even measured that.

The sorceress cleared her throat. “If what I understand of the timing is correct, then no more than about 12 to 14 weeks,” she said.

“All right.” The woman’s soft eyes met Catra’s. “And I understand this was the result of an assault?” Her voice held neither judgment nor pity.

Catra still could not make the words come out of her mouth, so she nodded.

Aunt Casta broke in, sounding a little sheepish, “Muriel, you were right. Catra needs you to explain things in detail. The options, I mean.” She glanced at Catra. “I don’t think I quite understood what you meant when we talked earlier.”

“Yes, of course.” The woman sat back in her chair. “Well, there are essentially three options for you.” She held out her hand and counted them off on her fingers. “You can continue this gestation and keep the baby.”

The cold in Catra’s chest spread a numb, false sense of calm through her. She felt like this when she was waiting for Hordak to sentence her to death, and she had sent Scorpia away. This was the calm that came over her when she had decided to send Glimmer to Adora. The details of the room seemed to come into sharper focus. She watched as Muriel touched the index finger of her right hand to the fingers of her left, counting. The woman’s nails were short and the same dark brown as her antlers. Her arms were covered in thin, light brown hair that darkened on the

underside. She had the longest, most delicate hands Catra had ever seen.

“You can continue and find an adoptive placement.”

The thought of carrying Prime’s Parasite Thing made her want to cut the organ housing it out of her belly. Her claws could do it if she was quick. She could sharpen them to a point where they would cut her flesh so cleanly, she wouldn’t notice the pain until the thing was done.

Muriel was still talking. “Or you could terminate the condition now.”

Catra nodded in acknowledgment without really listening; she already knew what she was going to do, and she wanted the woman to stop talking. Adora wouldn’t understand, but Catra needed the Parasite Thing gone, and it didn’t matter how. With that decision made, the paralysis that gripped her vocal cords abated. “Look, I…” she began, not even sure of what she was going to say.

She broke off, belatedly processing that the antlered woman had mentioned a third option. There was no way Catra had heard that right. “Wait,” she rasped, her ears going forward. “What was that last thing you said?” “

“I said that you could terminate...”

“Terminate? Like, as in ‘end?’” Catra demanded, standing. She put her hands on the desk to lean over it and stare into the midwife’s face. “As in ‘kill it’?”

“Yes,” Muriel said quietly, not even flinching. Of course, Catra standing up only put her at eye level with the midwife as she sat.

“You just...end it?!” Catra blurted. “You do that here? “

The midwife nodded. “Yes. If that’s what you want.”

Catra ran one trembling hand through her short hair and sank back down to her chair. It seemed far too good to be true. “What? You’ll just magic it out of me or something?”

A small smile played at the edge of Muriel’s lips. “I’m no sorceress,” she said. “I can catch babies and take care of a lot of common problems people might have with their reproductive organs. I also know how to perform abortions. But I don’t use magic.”

“What...what do you do?” Catra looked at Melog. Their mane was blue, and they looked calmly up at her, not giving Catra any sign that Muriel alarmed them.

“The process is fairly simple.” Muriel took a box from a drawer in her desk. “How much do you remember from your mandatory reproductive health class?” Her voice became sharp, reminiscent of a cadet instructor about to give a pop quiz.

“Uhh...some?” It was a single credit class, and no one paid much attention.

Muriel rolled her eyes. “Do I have to review the anatomy?” she snapped. “I can if I must.”

Aunt Casta started to speak, but Muriel shot her a look, and she shut her mouth.

“No, ma’am,” Catra replied, reflexively straightening up to answer.

Opening the box, Muriel took out several metal instruments and an oversized spiral-bound book. She flipped open to a diagram of a uterus. Catra was surprised to see it was the exact instructor’s book she remembered from the long-ago health class. Only Muriel had opened it to one of the illustrations at the back that the instructors never used when teaching cadet classes.

“So, here is the uterus.” Muriel propped the detailed illustration up and met Catra’s eyes to ensure she was paying attention. “You

know how the uterine lining, when not blocked by magic or tech, builds up to prepare for conception, right?"

Catra nodded, uncomfortable.

"And here we see the zygote burrowing into the uterine lining." She pointed to a lump of cells in the picture. "And here is the fetus." She flipped through a bunch of pages that showed a vaguely baby-shaped creature getting bigger and more like a baby within the confines of the uterus.

Oh. That's why they never show this part to the kids. It was pure nightmare fuel. Catra shrank into her seat, forcing herself to breathe slowly.

"This is the fetus at 14 weeks," the midwife continued, talking as if the whole situation was perfectly ordinary. "I'll start out by giving you a normal reproductive exam." She held up the metal instrument that Catra recognized from past exams. "When was the last time you had one?"

Catra winced. "It's been about three years," she admitted, embarrassed. She hadn't gotten one since the last one she'd had as a cadet.

The woman nodded. "That's fine." Her voice gentled. "You'll need a physical even if you decide to continue to term. I'd recommend testing for sexually transmitted infections at the very least, given what's happened."

Oh, fuck. Catra hadn't even considered the possibility of contracting space clap. "Yes, ma'am."

"This is a speculum." Muriel held the metal instrument up again. "I use this so I can see your cervix." she asserted as she flipped to a diagram of a side view of the female anatomy and demonstrated how she would slide it into the vagina.

"Then, I'll grasp the edge of the cervix with a long forceps-like tool called a tenaculum. I'll use an instrument like this to dilate

your cervix." She showed a long, blunt-tipped metal rod with a bend at each end. "I push this into the opening of the cervix to widen it. I'll use progressively larger ones to dilate the cervix. When I've dilated the cervix enough, I'll use this," she held up a narrow pipe, "which is attached to a suction machine to remove the fetal tissue." She put down the thin tube and picked up a different instrument that looked vaguely like a long-handled spoon with a tiny bowl end. "I'll use this to remove any tissue that you may have retained."

"And then what happens?" Catra asked in a low voice.

"You'll have some bleeding and cramping for a couple of weeks."

"That-that's it?" The stories Catra had heard made it seem horrendous. This didn't sound too bad at all. At least compared to the prospect of letting the Parasite Thing consume her from the inside. "I mean…"

Muriel seemed to understand Catra's implicit question. "You've heard stories?"

Catra nodded.

The midwife made a little sound of disgust deep in her throat. "Yes. Well. People who have to have illicit surgeries in the back of transports aren't going to receive the best care, now are they? Dirty hands, unskilled medics, dirty instruments--it's just a recipe for disaster." Muriel tilted her head to the side. "But, I've done many of these here, and we have had very few complications. I have clean instruments, a clean room, sufficient time, and good training. There are far fewer risks to this than we see in full-term births, actually."

"Oh." Catra digested that for a second. "Does it hurt a lot?" Pain figured prominently in the stories.

"Yes." The midwife spoke matter-of-factly. "It's sort of a kicked-in-the-gut type of pain. Probably not the worst you've ever felt, but close to it." Catra could tell that Muriel was trying to be straight

with her, and she appreciated it. “It’s certainly not fun. Most people opt for some sort of pain control.”

Aunt Casta finally spoke. “We can give you the same kind of potion I gave you when I was cleaning that wound, or I can even put…” she stopped, her eyebrows drawing together in a frown. “I mean, I can use a sleep spell on you if you want.”

The thought of the woozy peace the drugs gave her was tempting, but it reminded Catra a little too much of the peace she felt in Prime’s Light. Unless they were absolutely necessary, she’d prefer to do without. “How long does it take?”

“I’ll do a normal pelvic exam first. So that’s maybe five minutes. The surgery itself is ten minutes if you really are fourteen weeks. Less if you’re not that far along”.

“Can I just skip the pain potions?”

“Oh, but…” Aunt Casta began. Muriel shot her another look.

“Of course. If that’s what you want.” Muriel said evenly. “A lot of people do just fine with no painkillers at all.”

“But..why do you want to?” Aunt Casta asked softly, looking both horrified and perplexed. “There’s no reason you should….”

Catra couldn’t explain it, so she just shrugged and looked away.

“Because pain is real.” Muriel gritted, rubbing the back of her neck as she spoke.

Catra winced, recognizing the gesture. “You were chipped,” she breathed softly.

For the first time since they had come into her office, Muriel looked less than completely confident. Her eyes dropped to the desk, and she clasped her hands together. “Most of the residents of Mysticor were chipped. We didn’t think to question it when Micah….” She stopped.

Aunt Casta reached out across the narrow desktop to cover Muriel's hands with hers. The midwife was silent for a second before she cleared her throat. She turned her hands over to squeeze Aunt Casta's and then let go. Raising her eyes to return her attention to Catra, the midwife's slight smile was wry. "Anyway...I understand you might feel strongly about it."

"You don't need to decide right this second," Aunt Casta said, turning to Catra. "You can take some time to think about it. I imagine you'll want to talk to Adora. I'm sure she would want to be with you."

Catra felt her hackles and tail puff up as she growled, "I don't need to *think* about this. And I definitely don't need to talk to Adora. She doesn't need to know about it."

Melog lifted their head off Catra's lap and hissed at her, their mane darkening and becoming jagged.

"What?" she hissed back.

"You should talk to your mate," they said. "You give her too little credit."

"No, look, you don't get it," Catra told them. "She…She would never agree to this. They used to
tell us the Princesses killed babies." Although Catra always scoffed, the stories gave Adora nightmares. "Anyway, how can you be okay with this?" Catra asked the two older women, mainly aiming the question at the sorceress. "I mean, this thing is...technically...a baby, isn't it?"

"Well, it is a *potential* baby, but…." Aunt Casta started to say.

Muriel cut her off again with a sharp gesture of her hand. "Even if it was murder like you were taught, would that make a difference?"

After a moment's hesitation, because she felt she was walking into a trap, Catra shook her head.

The midwife nodded. “One of the hardest things for a healer of any kind to learn is that you can’t save everyone. If you have two patients and limited resources, you save the one with the best chance of survival. This…” she waved in the general direction of Catra’s stomach, “isn’t even able to live on its own yet. Given how ill Castaspella said you were last week, I’m stunned your body didn’t spontaneously abort it. The condition itself is not something to be undertaken casually. It changes your body permanently. Even with the best medical care, the complications can cripple or kill you. You, and you alone, bear the entire physical risk. If it’s murder, it is murder in self-defense.”

“Catra?” Aunt Casta said, her voice soft, reaching out a hand to Catra but then pulling back as though uncertain. “I really think it would be a good idea to tell Adora what’s going on.”

Crossing her arms over her chest, Catra hunched in the chair. “No. I just...I know Adora would never agree,” she muttered, wondering why Aunt Casta was pushing this. A horrible thought crossed the former Horde soldier’s mind, and she sat up. “Wait...Adora and me... we’re Official. Do I need her to sign off on this or something?”

“What?” Aunt Casta gasped. “No, of course not. This is your decision.”

Catra felt herself relax minutely.

“However, you will have to tell her something. You’ll have some bleeding and cramping for a couple of weeks. You won’t be able to hide the physical effects.”

Shit. Catra hadn’t considered that. Her stomach turned over. Adora was oblivious, but she would definitely notice blood. They had been taking it slow in the bedroom, but privacy between them had never been a thing. She’d been able to hide the wounds in her neck (until one got infected) because the deep puncture wounds never bled much, and her fur and the high collared shirts

Entrapta made for her hid a lot. She put her head in her hands and tried to slow her breathing.

“What the fuck am I going to tell Adora?” she hissed into her hands.

Muriel cut off that spiral before it started. “If you want to do this and don’t want to involve your wife, that’s up to you.” The woman’s voice was brisk. “Tell her how Prime took out your implant. That could actually cause many of the symptoms you’ve been suffering. It’s not uncommon to have significant bleeding and cramping as your hormones readjust. Tell her the surgery was to remove built-up tissue.”

That could work. The bright, treacherous spark of hope that lit in her chest earlier became a tiny flame. Perhaps...perhaps Prime didn’t get his way. Maybe the happy ending she’d envisioned for herself and Adora was not out of reach.

“So...so when can we do this?” Catra rasped, sitting up slowly. “I want to do this as soon as I can. Please.” Catra heard the pleading note in her own voice, laced with an edge of desperation, and she did not care. “What do I need to do?” Catra knew that she would either figuratively or literally lick Muriel’s boots clean if that’s what it took. She wondered what that cadet had to do for Shadow Weaver in exchange for fixing her problem.

“When did you last eat?” Muriel asked apropos of nothing, as far as Catra could see.

“Uh, this morning. Why?”

“Because I don’t like getting puked on,” Muriel growled. “Do you think it’s been at least four hours?”

"I don't know." Catra had no idea what the time even was.

Aunt Casta nodded. “Oh yes. Catra, Adora, and Glimmer had breakfast with me this morning. If she hasn’t eaten since then, it’s at least four hours.”

“Are you saying we could do this...now?” That couldn’t be what they were saying, could it? This was too easy.

Standing up, Muriel crossed over to the door beside the desk and opened it. “Come this way.” She jerked her head, indicating Catra should follow her.

Aunt Casta touched Catra’s shoulder. “I’ve assisted Muriel before. If you want to keep this absolutely discreet, I can assist her now,” the sorceress said, “if you’re comfortable with that.”

The ice was back in Catra’s chest, and her mouth was too dry to utter a sound, so she nodded slightly. She couldn’t move. Maybe...maybe the last few weeks were just another one of Prime’s false realities. How could it not be? People never cared about her like this. Adora would never come back for her. And this Parasite Thing scenario; Prime was just trying to show her that even if he was *dead,* she could never rid herself of him. He would make her his vessel, one way or another. Her neck itched, and she just knew the world was going to splinter apart into his blinding Light and cruel laughter.

Melog bumped against Catra’s knees. “Granddaughter. The Destroyer is dead. This is real.” Right. That’s what Prime’s shadows always said.

“Force Captain!” Muriel barked like a drill instructor. "Pull yourself together." The midwife’s voice penetrated the green and white fog in Catra’s brain. “If you want me to patch you up, I suggest you follow me.” The woman waited another few seconds for Catra to move, then rolled her eyes irritably. “*Today* would be nice, Force Captain.”

“Yeah. Okay.” Mechanically, she stood. Melog disappeared, but Catra felt them nuzzle her hip to let her know they were still with her, helping get her feet to move. Muriel ushered her through the door, and Aunt Casta followed behind.

The room was set up exactly like those Catra remembered from her yearly physicals. The same weird half bed, covered with clean linen. The same sharp smells of disinfectants, the same covered instrument trays. A half-open door on the other side seemed to be a supply room or maybe a changing room.

The familiarity was oddly comforting. Catra's experiences with medics were usually pretty good. Once or twice, she'd hurt herself badly enough to see them, and they were always preferable to Shadow Weaver. The old bat always let the medics handle Catra's physicals, too. However, she always insisted on doing all of Adora's medical care herself. Standing in line with other cadets, everyone in their underwear, waiting to get a physical was a yearly ritual that most kids looked forward to. They got out of class, and the medics liked to bribe the kids with contraband treats, distracting them when it was time to get shots or have uncomfortable exams.

Muriel pulled a folded piece of fabric from a stack in the corner and handed it over. "Strip off," she ordered, but not unkindly. "Everything off the bottom. Put this on. It closes in the back. Take a seat on the table. We'll be right back." Muriel turned on her heel and walked into the supply room.

Castaspella smiled, although the expression was pinched with anxiety. "We'll just go and change,"

Procedure

Chapter Summary

Muriel is good at her job.

Chapter Notes

CW:
Accurate portrayal of medical procedures.

PTSD

Discussion of past rape and abuse.

Scroll to the bottom note for more specific (and spoiler-y warning)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Do you have to be so brusque?” Castaspella asked in a furious whisper after closing the door.

Muriel bent over the sink, washing her hands. “Yes.” Infuriatingly, the midwife seemed to find the question amusing if the quirk of her lips meant anything.

Castaspella had never seen Muriel deal so roughly with a patient before. “If you can’t put aside your personal biases, you should have said something,” the sorceress growled. “I thought you, of all people, would be sympathetic. Can’t you even try to understand what she’s been through?”

The midwife rinsed her hands and carefully dried them. She put the towel down next to the sink and braced herself against the counter. Tightly shutting her eyes, she grimaced as if with pain. “I know exactly what she’s been through.” She sucked in a harsh breath before turning her head to look a thousand yards past Castaspella’s right shoulder. “We all know what she’s been

through. Prime couldn't forget about our dear Little Sister." Her voice sank to a murmur before she seemed to shake herself, and she focused on the sorceress.

Castaspella hung up her cape and shrugged on the healer's smock that hung on the hook, then took her turn to wash her hands. "I'm sorry, Muriel," the sorceress said, subdued. "I wasn't thinking about that. I just...I think she reminds me of Glimmer. I want to protect her."

"She's been a soldier all her life," Muriel went on as she donned her own smock. "If I were too soft with her, she'd read it as pity. At best, it would insult her; at worst, she'd think I was hiding things from her." Done changing, the woman crossed her arms over her chest, leaning sideways against the counter as she waited for Castaspella to finish.

"I feel like she needs some softness after what she's been through."

"Yes, probably, but not from me. From me, she needs competence and respect. And that means I may indeed seem a little brusque by Mystacore's standards." The midwife smiled wryly again. "The other midwives would have her thinking she was on death's door by being too kind and understanding. I'm glad you thought to bring her to me." The tall woman straightened up. "Well, come along. The sooner we do this, the better." Muriel knocked on the door that led back into the exam room.

"Come in. I'm set," called Catra. She sat on the table in the gown Muriel had handed her, her expression tense, and although Castaspella didn't see Melog, she could feel the creature's magical signature in the room.

Before she had met with Catra, Muriel had anticipated that whatever Catra decided, she'd want to act on it right away; The midwife had already set up the instruments she needed.

“All right,” Muriel said quietly, sounding more like Castaspella was accustomed to, but her tone was still clipped and matter of fact. If Muriel had not explained herself, Castaspella might even have read it as cold. “I’m going to start with a regular pelvic exam. Just like normal. Is that okay?” She waited for Catra’s grunt of acknowledgment before continuing. “I won’t do anything without telling you first. I will need you to hold still during the procedure itself. If you need me to, I can stop and give you a break right up until I start removing the uterine contents.” She nodded at Castaspella and started putting on her gloves. “If I stop then, it’s not going to help. It’s just prolonging the pain.”

“Yeah. That makes sense.”

“Go ahead and lay back, Catra,” Castaspella told her as she took her place next to the exam table. “I’m right here.”

The young woman did as she was asked and scooted down the table and put her feet in the stirrups, apparently not unused to this type of exam.

“Would you like to hold my hand?” During this particular procedure, the assistant’s main job was to watch the patient. Most of the time, people took some form of painkiller for this or else opted for a sleep spell to make them completely unconscious. This meant they needed someone to monitor them. Patients who weren’t fully anesthetized generally needed emotional support as well.

A nervous smile tugged at the corner of Catra’s mouth. She cleared her throat and muttered, “I’d just cut you up.” Anxiety had her sinking her claws into the cushioning of the table under her.

“How about this?” Both Castaspella and Muriel had treated magicat patients before; a wide roll of bandage for just this purpose sat on one of the instrument trays. Castaspella took Catra’s fingers and wrapped them around it, and then wrapped her own around the back of Catra’s hand, tucking her fingers into

her palm between the bandage roll and Catra's skin. This way, Catra wouldn't accidentally cut either one of them.

Muriel dragged the wheeled stool that she used when performing procedures over, but she did not sit down. She stood at the end of the table and put her hand on Catra's bent knee. "Do you want a sheet to put over your legs, or are you more comfortable like this?"

Again Catra cleared her throat before she spoke, and the words were barely audible. "This is better." Her stony eyes focused on the ceiling. Melog reappeared. Their form was as small as an ordinary house cat and curled up at Catra's shoulder.

The midwife nodded and took her place at the end of the table. "You'll feel me touching you. I'm going to put my fingers inside your vagina and my hand on your belly so I can feel the size of your uterus."

"I'm ready," Catra screwed her eyes shut. Castaspella nodded at Muriel in case she hadn't heard Catra's whisper.

Catra didn't make a sound through the exam, although tears leaked slowly from her eyes.

"It feels about ten weeks. Smaller than what we thought," Muriel told Catra. "I'm also taking some samples to check for sexually transmitted infections, but from what I can see here, everything looks normal."

"Good. That's good," Catra murmured.

"Have you had any bleeding or unusual discharges?"

"No."

"You'll feel the speculum now," Muriel said. "Is this okay?

"As okay as it's going to get."

“I’m going to put some numbing medication in your cervix. This helps with some of the pain and won't make you feel odd. You’ll feel a pinch or a sting, and then I’ll grab it with the tenaculum to keep it in place.”

After a second, a tiny squeak fought its way past Catra’s clenched teeth. Muriel looked up. “Do you need a break?” she asked.

Catra shook her head. “No. Please. Keep going. Just… hurry.” The words came out as a high-pitched whine. Castaspella rubbed her shoulder with her free hand, wishing that Catra had at least accepted something to take the edge off.

“I’m dilating your cervix. You’ll feel some hard cramping.” Muriel said about two minutes later. “I’ll need you to stay still. I won’t be able to stop, but it won’t take long.”

Catra nodded, her eyes still tightly shut. Castaspella saw Muriel pick up the smallest dilator. Knowing what was coming next, she put both hands around Catra’s.

The young woman gasped. Her teeth sank into her lower lip. She made no sound, but she slowly shook her head from side to side as if trying to reject the pain signals her body gave her. Her tears went from a leak to a flood.

Muriel put down the first dilator and picked up another. Castaspella watched Catra’s face to gauge her tolerance for it. Other than shaking her head, Catra stayed completely still and silent.

Moving with her usual efficiency, Muriel quickly worked through the different-sized rods, glancing up every couple of seconds to silently communicate with Castaspella. Every time, the sorceress nodded, so that the midwife would know the patient was tolerating the procedure. At last, she came to the largest one and inserted it.

Mismatched eyes flew open, Catra's wide pupils locking onto Castaspella’s. The sorceress tightened her hold on the younger

woman's hand.

“Oh. *Fuck.*” Catra broke into a sweat and pressed Castaspella’s hand to the side of her face.

Carefully, the older woman rubbed the underside of Catra’s jaw with the back of her hand, knowing the scent mark would comfort her. “It’s all right. It’ll be over soon.” Castaspella whispered. Freeing one hand, she picked up a cloth to wipe the tears that flowed down both sides of Catra’s face.

“You’ll feel some hard cramping. I’ll need you to stay still. I won’t be able to stop, but it won’t take long.” From the end of the table, Muriel shifted around. Metallic clinking accompanied the movement. Catra felt the speculum move slightly as if Muriel were repositioning it. Then the room did a barrel roll as Catra’s lower abdomen seized up with agony.

“Cramp” was inadequate to describe the feeling. An intense twisting, clenching ache radiated down from her lower abdomen to the front of her thighs almost to Catra’s knees and from her belly all the way around to her back. If she had anything in her stomach, it would surely have come up. It did *not* feel like a kick in the gut; it felt like a bot was stepping on her.

Every muscle in her body tensed and her vaginal walls clamped down against the metal instruments; a useless defense. Prime’s talons cut into her. Unbearably hot, the air around her was thick, unbreathable fluid.

I’m still there. I never left. Her throes were another of Prime’s games. She whirled through space. Her back and guts blazed with torment.

But, the thought came to her as if from outside her head, *in his Light there is no pain.*

That was true. The pain only lasted until you accepted Him. And then He erased you. There was no pain, nor pleasure, and not

even the comfort of oblivion. Just the constant noise of the hive mind and the terrible, terrifying numbness.

Open your eyes, granddaughter.

"Oh. Fuck." Hoping the voice was right, she opened her eyes.

It *wasn't* Him. Aunt Casta's black eyes met hers, and she gripped Catra's fingers, anchoring her in the present. The world still spun, but Aunt Casta was a still point in the center. The ex-soldier's tears were as much from relief as from pain.

The spasms relaxed a little. Catra gasped in the chemical odor of the room, lungs burning from holding her breath.

Another wave came on, wrapping her in agony, locking her limbs. She dug her claws into the surface beneath her and into the roll of bandage in her hand, pulling Aunt Casta's hand to press against her. Tears and sweat ran down the sides of her face.

"It's all right. It'll be over soon," Aunt Casta crooned, rubbing the underside of Catra's jaw and wiping her face with a cloth. Melog pressed into her shoulder and purred.

"Oh. It hurts," Catra muttered. "Please, hurry." Another time she might have been ashamed by her pleading; at this moment, she didn't care.

A mechanical humming filled the room. The smell of blood and salt abruptly filled Catra's nose. She keened in her throat, unable to completely push down the cry as anguish gripped her again. How long had she been doing this? She tried to count the seconds in her head, but the deep visceral pain turned each one into forever.

"All right, Catra," Muriel said faintly, speaking from another world where ceaseless suffering didn't exist, "I'm almost finished."

The keen became a low moan. Catra trembled, wishing she could pass out and cursing herself for not accepting Aunt Casta's offer

of painkillers.

The humming stopped. The agonizing contraction eased, but the blood smell became stronger.

A sob caught in her chest, she breathed raggedly, pressing the back of Aunt Casta's cool hand to her forehead. The dangerous smell of sorcery clung to the woman's hair and clothes but weirdly, she now also smelled… safe?

"Almost done," Muriel repeated. Catra hissed. The woman had said that an eternity ago, but she still kept going. "You'll have some more cramping, but you're through the worst,"

The next cramp was hard, but it only reached around her back, not down to her knees. A hard-to-define scraping sensation accompanied it. The image of scraping snow off the equipment in the Northern Reach came to mind.

Please, stop. Please be done, she begged inside her head. "Please…" The word struggled out of her throat. Miraculously the pain eased off.

A hand touched her knee. "I'm finished, Catra," Muriel said. "I just need Castaspella to check the tissue. Stay where you are for a second."

"Can you let go for just a minute?" Aunt Casta asked softly. Very slowly, Catra loosened her hold, grateful for the roll of bandage that had prevented her from putting her claws through Aunt Casta's hand or her own palm.

Melog bumped their head against Catra's and rubbed their jaw along her shoulder.

"I'll be right back." Aunt Casta patted her shoulder, moved down to the end of the room behind Muriel. The smell of blood became stronger as Aunt Cast shifted something around.

"Muriel? Could you come here?"

The hand on Catra's knee moved. She lifted her head and saw Muriel and Aunt Casta's backs turned. "Mmm," Muriel said. She came back to look at Catra from between her knees. "All right, we're done. Hold on for just a minute while I remove my instruments." She sat down again and the pressure of the speculum abruptly vanished.

A noise like a drawer being opened came from underneath the table and Muriel gently took Catra's feet out of the stirrups, setting them on the little platform she'd pulled out at the end.

Soaking wet with sweat, Catra shivered. "Did you get it all?" Unpleasant wetness oozed from between her legs onto the table and all Catra could smell was blood.

"Yes. I did." Muriel replied. "I'm cleaning you up a bit, so stay put."

Limp and in pain, Catra couldn't have moved if she wanted to. Muriel's hands were both efficient and gentle as she slid wet linens out from under her.

"Scoot back a bit."

The young woman did as she was told, surprised that her nerveless legs actually followed her instructions. Muriel picked up her feet, slid the little shelf back into the table, and slowly lowered Catra's feet so that they dangled from the end.

"Let's sit you up." Aunt Casta put her arm under Catra's shoulders, slowly lifting her upright. Weak as a kitten, Catra leaned into Aunt Casta's shoulder. "Don't move yet," the sorceress advised. "You need to sit a minute before you can stand up."

Muriel was pulling some things out of the cupboard. She returned with a thick bandage-like pad and a pair of mesh underwear. The older woman pulled a little step out of the bottom of the table so Catra could rest her feet, slipped the shorts around her ankles, and left them there. "Do you feel you can stand up?" Muriel asked.

“I think so?”

“Put your hands on my shoulders and take your time.” In a well-practiced movement, the midwife slipped Catra’s arms around her shoulders, helping her stand while at the same time slipping the pad into her crotch and then pulling the shorts onto Catra’s body. It helped that Catra was standing on the step since the midwife was so tall.

“You’ll see quite a bit of blood, when you change that,” the midwife told her. “Don’t panic about it, unless you bleed through two of those in an hour.”

Catra’s ears pinned back in embarrassment. Muriel kept going as though bleeding from one’s reproductive organs was perfectly natural. “You’ll bleed for about two weeks. You might see clots, especially after you’ve been lying down for a while.”

Catra nodded and leaned heavily on the midwife, feeling dizzy and sick.

“All right, just step down towards me.”

Aunt Casta was right beside her and put her arm around Catra’s waist. “You did well. If you just lean on me, we’ll have you lie down on the couch in the other room. When you feel up to it, I’ll take you to your room, all right?” The woman hesitated then seemed to come to a decision. “Would you like something for pain now?”

“Please?” whispered Catra, not caring how broken she sounded. Her eyes wouldn’t stop running. It was only a few steps to Muriel’s outer office and the couch under the window. Melog grew large enough to support her from the other side.

Aunt Casta helped her sit on the couch. Catra drew her legs up until she was curled into a ball with her tail wrapped around her. She was so cold and the tears would not stop.

Chapter End Notes

This chapter portrays a surgical abortion without the use of anesthetic, or sedative-hypnotics as performed about 25 years ago. Painful, but not dangerous.

Some mention of blood and vaginal bleeding.

Fortunately, Muriel knows what she's doing and abortion in Mystacore is safe and legal.

A Rough Day

Chapter Summary

Melog summons Adora

Glimmer understands too well

Hey Adora

You should get sparkles to bring you home soon

I'm having kind of a rough day

Look for me in muriel's office

Adora stared at the text. Catra never texted her, but that could be because since the war ended, they almost never spent any time apart. She would have come today, but Adora (with Melog's help) made her promise to tell Aunt Casta about the sleep attacks she had every afternoon and the other weird symptoms she'd had.

They were pretty much winding up for the day already, and Catra knew Adora would be back around dinner time, so the message seemed strangely redundant. And, *kind of a rough day?* That's what she'd say when she staggered back to the bunkroom after an especially harsh reprimand from Shadow Weaver. Worried about the implications, Adora nervously started bouncing her leg, unable to keep her mind on anything but what the words in the text might mean. She caught Glimmer's eye and made a little "wrap it up" gesture.

"Any other business we need to take care of today?" Glimmer asked the meeting at large, "if not, I'd like to adjourn for the afternoon." It was a good hour before their usual stopping time, but the Queen said, "I think we all could use the break.

The small group of representatives from Alwyn, having presented their requests to the Queen, shook their heads, looking grateful for a chance to cut the meeting short. Adora nearly cheered.

“Glimmer? Who’s Muriel?” Adora demanded as soon as the last one left. She got up and crossed over to sit next to Glimmer and Bow. She put the tracker pad down on the table to show them the text.

“Muriel?” Glimmer asked, sounding puzzled and perhaps slightly alarmed, “she’s one of the midwives. Why do you….” She stopped when she read Catra’s text. Her eyebrows knitted. “She’s in Muriel’s office?”

“What’s a midwife?” Adora asked.

“Midwives are like healers who specialize in taking care of reproductive issues,” Bow told Adora patiently when it seemed like Glimmer hadn’t heard the question. “Why?”

“Catra’s seeing one, I guess,” Adora told him, feeling confused.

Bow went very still. Glimmer put her hand over her mouth as she stared at the text some more as if she could somehow divine additional meaning from the few words on the screen. She looked panicked. “I’ll be right back.” She blinked out.

A knock at Muriel’s door roused Catra from a shallow sleep. Covered in warm blankets, with Melog curled around her, she still felt cold. The cold, dragging ache in her lower abdomen still radiated down her thighs.

The midwife sat at her desk, writing. "A moment, please," she called out to whoever knocked. She glanced at Catra, stood, and pulled a tapestry Catra had taken for decoration away from the wall; the thick fabric was suspended on a wooden frame on tiny wheels. Muriel pulled it over, so it was between Catra and the door.

The door must have opened silently because Catra didn't hear it. "Ah. Your Majesty. Is there something I can help you with?" Muriel's voice asked. Oddly, Catra could not hear the answer.

"I'm so sorry, Your Majesty, I have a patient at the moment. Perhaps you'd like to make an appointment with me?" Muriel said. The acoustics in the place were really strange. Catra wondered if it were some sort of magical sound dampening, possibly designed to foil hearing like hers.

Your Majesty, the midwife had said. Why the hell would Sparkles be here? That was the only person Catra had heard called that.

'I'm afraid I don't know who you mean," Another pause as someone spoke. Hearing only one side of the conversation was so frustrating. "Really? Hmm. Perhaps I have the wrong name. Often people give me a name different from what they use normally. For privacy, you understand."

A longer pause. The midwife laughed gently. "Oh, that wouldn't matter. Sometimes people do use high-profile names. You have no idea how many Queen Glimmers I have seen." And then, "I see. Let me ask."

The midwife came around the screen. "The Queen of Bright Moon is here," she told Catra with one raised eyebrow, "she tells me that you texted that you were here."

"I did not," Catra hissed, indignant.

"Be that as it may," Muriel said, "she says she believes you're my patient. Would you like me to send her on her way, or would you like to talk to her?"

Catra growled. No one knew she was here, except for Muriel, Aunt Casta, and… "You jerk!" she hissed at Melog.

The magical guardian, curled around Catra to help keep her warm, turned their head and hissed back, "I have taken no vows of secrecy." They waited for a beat, then said more quietly, "You

need not tell your mate and your friends the whole truth, but you must at least tell them something."

The last thing Catra wanted to do was talk to anyone about this. But…Melog was right, unfortunately.

"Is it just her?" Catra asked.

"Yes."

Weird. Adora was probably caught up in something. Catra thought for a minute. It might actually be easier to talk to Sparkles first. She wouldn't be upset like Adora would be. Come to think of it, maybe that was why Sparkles *was* alone. Maybe they wanted to see what the deal was before they broke it to Adora. "Okay, then."

Muriel nodded. "If you want me to get rid of her, just say you're tired, and I'll be happy to throw her out."

"You'd throw the Queen out?" Catra couldn't stop herself from asking skeptically.

"She's not the queen of my office."

Catra felt the corner of her mouth curl up into a smile. "Thanks."

The midwife nodded and stepped back around the screen. "You may speak with her. But, just for a minute," she said.

"...ank you." Glimmer's voice suddenly cut in in the middle of her sentence. Her face peeked around the screen. "Catra?"

"Hey, Sparkles." Catra tried to go for a nonchalant tone but missed entirely, going by the shock on Glimmer's face.

"What's going on?" Glimmer stepped closer to the couch. "You texted Adora. You said you were having a rough day."

"Uhh, yeah… " said Catra, trying to think fast, but her head was fuzzy with whatever Muriel had given her.

The lack of response seemed to scare Glimmer; her face paled as she tiptoed closer. “Are you…all right?” Her voice dropped to a murmur. “Catra? Was it something *He* did?”

At the mention of Him, Catra’s stomach dropped. As Glimmer took another step forward, Catra shrank back. No, no, no. They were NOT going to talk about this. She thought she was ready for this, but, no, there was no way. Absolutely not. Even though the fuzziness of the pain potions, Catra felt the beginnings of panic. She fisted her hands in the blanket draped across her so Glimmer wouldn’t see them shake. Desperately trying to calm down, she took a couple of deep breaths. No, she could not do this right now.

Floundering, trying to find something that she could say without getting into what had happened to her today. Or last month, or the month before. Fuck, she couldn’t even figure out *when* it happened exactly. If she talked about it, the memories would crowd in like waking nightmares. She wanted to sink her claws deeply into the back of her neck and pull the chip out. To make sure it was gone.

“Catra?” Glimmer asked cautiously, like she wasn’t sure if Catra was going to answer.

She needed to say something, so she settled on, “I’m fine.”

“You don’t look fine,” Glimmer retorted. “You look like you were run over by a tank.”

Still trying to slow her breathing, Catra nodded. “Yeah. I’m kinda feeling that way,” she allowed. Her ears were pinned back, and the room suddenly felt far too small. If she felt better, she might have bolted out of the door. As it was, she knew she wouldn’t get far, especially as she felt a subtle pressure from Melog’s direction at the thought. They were definitely not going to help her run anywhere this time; she could feel the concern rolling off of them and the wordless knowledge that they would not allow her to hurt herself.

That reminded her of the alien cat's little stunt. It would be a good distraction. "I didn't send that text, by the way, " Catra told Glimmer. "This idiot did." She jerked her thumb at Melog. "They… ah… thought that Adora ought to know. That I was here, I mean. You can tell her it's not anything she needs to worry about. I'll see her later. Once Muriel says I can leave."

Exactly what she was going to say, she would have to figure out later. Her mind was spinning around in little circles, and she could not think. She glanced at the midwife who was pretending to write, and she could see Muriel giving her the side-eye. Grasping at any chance of rescue from this conversation, Catra added, "I'm just really tired."

Muriel had been listening. The tall woman stood up from the desk and swept over. "All right, Your Majesty. You see, she is well enough. I can't release her for a little while yet, but I'm sure she'll let you know when I do." The midwife's voice had turned almost cloying in its sweetness. She smiled at Glimmer, standing just a little too close so that the Queen needed to back up to look the taller woman in the eye.

"Oh, but…" Glimmer began.

Serenely, Muriel smiled, taking a step forward and gently putting her hand on Glimmer's arm. "Your Majesty. I need to think about my patient. She needs rest." She turned to stand side by side with Glimmer, and in the same movement, she turned Glimmer around to face the door. Muriel spread her arm out to indicate where she wanted to lead the shorter woman. "Why don't you go wait for her in your Aunt's office? I know Castaspella was heading that way." She took another step, and they were hidden by the screen. "Or better yet, perhaps you could let her rest this evening and see her tomorrow. I'm sure she'll be much more interested in your company then."

"Catra?" Glimmer seemed to realize she was being herded out of the room and teleported back to Catra's side, still sounding scared.

Muriel growled so quietly that Catra was certain she was the only one who heard it, and the woman's scent signals took on the unmistakable edge of anger. The first whiff of it that Catra had gotten from the woman. Muriel stalked over to interpose herself protectively in front of her patient. She stood at her full height, her shoulders tense and her back straight. Although her heavy robes obscured her legs, Catra could see that she'd put one foot a little forward and her back foot's heel firmly planted for stability. It looked completely involuntary--the leftover reflexes of a former soldier.

"Your Majesty." Surprisingly, the anger was entirely missing from the midwife's tone. What came through was more gentle exasperation. "While Catra is in my office, she is under my care. She has indeed had a rough day. I'm sure she'll tell you all about it later. Until I decide to release her, she is going to rest." The elegant woman crossed her arms, staring down at Glimmer. "Now, Your Majesty, I suggest you wait until she calls you." Her tone became slightly challenging, and a little of the anger leaked out. "Unless you think you know better than I do how to care for my patients?"

Glimmer deflated; her cheeks went red, and she looked abashed. "Of course not. I'm sorry."

Melog growled at Catra, their ears pinned back. They didn't use words, but Catra knew they thought she was being unreasonable.

"All right, all right," she muttered to Melog. They were right; it was only going to get worse the longer she put it off. More loudly, she said, "Muriel? It's okay. I'll talk to her for a minute." She moved her gaze to Glimmer. "I just can't…" she tucked the blanket more tightly around herself, although her shivering had nothing to do with being cold. "Please," she met Glimmer's eyes. "I can't talk about Him. Not...not right now. Okay?"

"We don't have to talk about anything you don't want to," Glimmer assured her gently. "I just wanted to make sure you're okay."

Muriel gave a curt nod and moved out of the way. "Do not upset my patient," she warned. She grabbed one of the soft chairs and pushed it over. "Here, Your Majesty. Please, sit down."

Even though the chair was for Glimmer's benefit, Catra appreciated that the other woman wouldn't be looming over her while they talked.

Glimmer sat on the edge of the soft chair, and reached out her hand to cover Catra's hand still fisted in the blanket. "So, what happened?"

For some reason, Catra's treacherous hand turned over and grasped the Queen's tightly. Her mouth opened, but once again, the ice prevented Catra from speaking. She closed her eyes and shook her head, although she didn't withdraw her hand.

Muriel came to her rescue again. "Catra? Would you like me to explain it to her? I mean, about the symptoms you've been suffering because of the…" she paused significantly, "implant removal?"

Relieved at the reprieve, Catra opened her eyes and found that she could speak again. "Yeah. If you don't mind," she murmured. "I'm not sure I uh...understood all that medic speak enough to explain." Every time she tried to speak of this, the ice stopped her throat, threatening to choke her.

"Wait," Glimmer said as if suddenly remembering something. "I should get Adora." The Queen blushed. "I kind of freaked out and teleported over here to check on you by myself because I was so worried. Adora's probably having a meltdown at Bow. I better go."

"Worried?" Catra blinked at her, confused. "Worried about what?"

Glimmer's eyes narrowed. "About you, dumbass," she growled. "I was afraid that…." Looking away, she bit off whatever she was about to say.

It was a minute before she turned back, her expression a little haunted although she tried to smile. "Never mind. I'll just go get Adora." Glimmer stopped, her face becoming very serious, and she squeezed Catra's hand as if holding it were the most natural thing in the world. "I mean, is that okay with you? I can also just tell her that Muriel is running off your visitors if you want some time to yourself. But I'll have to tell her something about what's going on. *Do* you want me to bring Adora?"

Suddenly the *only* thing Catra wanted was Adora. "Yes." To her shame, tears started down her cheeks, and she let go of Sparkles' hand to brush them away. "Would you go get her? Please."

Kindly, Glimmer pretended not to notice. "Is it okay to bring Bow? He's worried too, but he'll get it if you'd rather him not."

Adora might need both their moral support, Catra reflected. Even the highly edited version of today's events was going to make her lose her mind. "Yeah, bring Arrow Boy too." She sighed and put her head back against Melog's flank. "It's not like you won't run straight over to tell him."

Glimmer gave her a little smile, then vanished.

Glimmer reappeared at last. The look on her face did nothing to reassure Adora-she had an entirely un-Glimmer-like pallor and tears clung to her eyelashes although they didn't fall.

"What's going on?" Adora demanded. "What was that about?"

"Is she okay?" Bow asked more quietly.

"She's okay." Glimmer wrapped her arms around herself and shuddered. "I thought… I'm sorry. I don't know what I thought."

"But, she's okay?" Bow asked again, tensely. He took Glimmer's hand.

"Yeah, but," Glimmer shared yet another significant look with him, "I'm pretty sure you're right."

"Fuck." That was the first time Adora had ever heard Bow swear like that, and her jaw dropped. His expression was hard to decipher—some combination of anger and sadness.

"What? Can you let me in on whatever the big secret is?" The answer was going to be terrible, but she needed to know.

"We're pretty sure that…." Bow took a deep breath and, instead of going on, shut his mouth and looked at Glimmer.

"We're pretty sure Prime raped Catra." Glimmer finished for him.

A deep chill settled into Adora. She knew this. She knew it in her heart the first time she saw Catra's hands shake when she talked about him. She knew from the way Catra hurt herself because sometimes she couldn't tell what was real (Adora understood from experience that it was sometimes hard to tell a dream from reality). Adora knew it when Catra explained that Prime could see her through the chip. From the way, she described it: *When he was using me.*

Glimmer sat down at the table, spreading her hands out flat on the surface. Bow walked over to put his hand on her shoulder.

"Glimmer?" Adora asked cautiously, realizing she was missing something significant.

The Queen blew out her breath in a long-drawn-out sigh. "Prime never actually…but I'm certain the only things that stopped him was the fact that he knew I was part of the Heart of Etheria weapon and his weird thing about my rank." She shifted uncomfortably. "But, you know how much he liked to hear himself talk. He liked to threaten me and sometimes it got… specific. Well, you talked to him. You saw how he acted. But, he never actually *did* anything to me."

"Glimmer…" Bow said in the tone he usually reserved for Adora when she was insisting she was "just fine."

"Anyway," the Queen said, pointedly ignoring Bow, "I think she's seeing the midwife for something related to what happened with Prime."

"B-but, She Ra… " Adora stuttered out. "What could he have done that She Ra didn't heal?"

Glimmer turned her head slowly to look up at Adora. "I-I'm not sure. And just so you know, she doesn't look well, okay?"

"But, what happened?" Adora almost wailed.

"I'm not sure. " Glimmer repeated slowly. She went on, seemingly choosing her words carefully. "I think maybe the midwife did something about those odd symptoms she's been having."

The hesitation made Adora's heart sink. It wasn't that she suspected Glimmer of lying to her, but it seemed like she wasn't saying everything she knew.

"I just want you to know that whatever happens, we're there for *both* of you, okay?" It was not an unusual thing for Glimmer to say, but today she spoke the words with the strength of a solemn vow. "But she's asking for you. We should go." She stood and held her hands out to Adora and Bow.

A Moment of Reflection

Chapter Summary

Catra has a minute to think

"When did you leave the Horde?" Catra asked Muriel after Sparkles disappeared. She didn't usually ask personal questions, but she was curious. Perhaps the pain medication had something to do with it; the world was slightly out-of-focus. "It's okay if you don't want to answer," she added, realizing it might be a sensitive topic.

If Catra's quiet query bothered the midwife, she didn't show it. "A long time ago." She finished whatever she was writing and put her pen down. The slight smile she gave Catra was encouraging. "I was about the age you are now. It was during the first Princess Alliance. I was a battlefield medic."

Catra winced. That was a horrible job. "Is that why you left?"

The midwife nodded. "It was too hard to patch soldiers up only to have Hordak throw them back into battle only half-healed."

Soberly Catra nodded. "Yeah." She wanted to say more, but anything she could think of seemed either condescending, clueless, or rude.

A knock at the door made Catra flinch. Were they here already?

Muriel raised an eyebrow but didn't comment. "A moment," she called out, disappearing behind the screen to answer the door.

Once again, Catra could only hear the midwife's voice, not the person at the door.

"Ah. Perfect. Thank you. I have a patient, so I'll take it from here." Wheels rolled across the hardwood floor. They went silent when Muriel wheeled a cart around the screen onto the rug.

“Castaspella tells me that chicken soup is your favorite.” She uncovered the tureen and ladled some into a bowl.

“Yes.” The fact that Aunt Casta remembered made Catra’s chest warm.

She took the deep, half-filled bowl from the midwife along with the spoon. “Thank you,” Catra said sincerely, meaning more than the soup. The woman still had the bearing of a Horde officer and was treating Catra with the respect due to an officer; Catra felt she should return the favor. She especially appreciated that Muriel wasn’t treating her like she was weak.

Muriel nodded her acknowledgment. She sat down in the chair Glimmer used and leaned forward resting her elbows on her knees and her chin on her hands. “Before the Queen comes back, why don’t you tell me what you’re comfortable divulging to your wife and friends.”

Catra chanced a look at Melog who was currently lying across her feet. They returned the look with one raised eyebrow and a lashing tail. She already knew their opinion.

Taking a few spoonfuls of soup from the bowl as she turned the question over in her head. “What do you think I should tell her?” Catra asked quietly.

“That is not my decision to make.” Muriel shrugged and tilted her head thoughtfully. “I *have* found that secrets are often problematic over the long term. What do you think she would do with this information?”

“I… don’t know,” Catra admitted. “I mean…come on, she’d probably think….” a dozen scenarios flashed through Catra’s brain. “She’d probably think I was selfish.”

“Adora’s been here a while. She’s had time to become accustomed to how different things are.” Muriel crossed her arms over her chest and sat back in her chair. “Do you know how much

paperwork a person has to submit in Mystacor or Brightmoon in order to get permission to reproduce?"

Catra shook her head, imagining forms that came in inch-thick stacks, in triplicate and naturally with gold ink on silver paper.

Muriel met Catra's eyes. "None. Everywhere but the Horde, reproduction is considered a private decision. As is the decision *not* to reproduce."

Gobsmacked, Catra stared at the woman. "That-that's crazy. That would be…"

"Chaos?" Muriel smirked a little. "Doesn't the Horde teach that all the Princesses ever wanted to do was sow chaos?"

That did sound pretty chaotic. "Yeah, but that's not the same thing. Even if Adora's okay with that," Catra could not imagine how she could be, but anything was possible these days. "I don't think she'd approve of this."

"I've never met Adora, so I wouldn't know," Muriel allowed. Her mouth thinned in a grimace and her ears drooped a little. "If it's at all important," the midwife looked away, and her voice grew soft, "you should know that the fetus… wasn't right. It had deformities incompatible with life."

Was that important? Catra didn't know and didn't care. She didn't think Adora would either; the fact was that Catra had decided to do it, even knowing it could have been an actual child. But she would do it again in a heartbeat. "Is it…okay that I don't care?" Catra hunched over her soup bowl.

Muriel shrugged. "You feel what you feel."

Another knock came from the door before Muriel could continue. Catra froze. Muriel noticed her lock up with fear because her eyebrow went up again and she frowned. She poked her head around the screen. "A moment, please!" she called out. She

turned back to Catra. “Do you want another few minutes to think? I can have them wait.”

“Yes. Please. I…” Conflicted, Catra put her soup bowl down on the little side table. “I want to see her, but I….”

“I’ll tell them something if you’re not ready.” Muriel’s eyes were understanding. “It’s normal to feel much more emotional after this procedure, by the way. Go easy on yourself.”

Catra’s hands shook as the door opened. Again she only heard Muriel. “I’ll go ask,” the midwife said, her tone a tiny bit condescending, as if to an uninvited and inconvenient guest. “I wasn’t told whether I could allow She Ra.”

She Ra? What the fuck was She Ra doing here?

Melog caught the thought (one of these days, Catra would have to ask how this psychic bond even worked). Their mane turned darker as they growled, “The Protector fears for you.” Their jagged mane smoothed and they seemed to look at her mournfully. “Your mate loves you. It is cruel to meet love with deceit.”

“I…” Catra couldn’t think of a reply.

“You wish to protect her.” A statement, not a question. Yet again, it seemed Melog knew Catra’s heart before she herself did. Not that she and her heart ever communicated well.

“Yes. That’s part of it, I guess.” Adora was so oblivious that she never caught Catra in a lie, even when Catra *wanted* her to. She need never find out. What could the truth give her but pain?

“You are afraid.” Melog rumbled.

“Yeah.” Catra was afraid, but it was a different type of fear than before. Now that the Parasite Thing was gone, the storm of terror and rage consuming her backed off, letting her finally think. Of course, she also suspected the painkiller Muriel gave had

something to do with her feeling suddenly so very relaxed. In a small voice, she admitted, “I’m afraid she’ll leave me.”

“If this is to come between you, better to discover that now,” Melog pronounced, somberly. “Do you truly fear she will abandon you over this?”

Did she? Catra was not sure. Trust wasn’t easy for Catra. It never had been. Wasn’t it better just to lie and not have to risk it?

Unbidden, the memory of Thaymor bubbled to the surface. *“Shadow Weaver and Hordak have been* lying *to us,”* Like that was the worst thing they’d ever done.

Muriel came back around the screen, to stand with crossed arms, interrupting Catra’s musing. “So, what would you like her to know?” the midwife asked. “Take all the time you want. We can let them sit out there all day while you decide. I have nowhere else to be.”

The door knocked again and Muriel growled low in her throat. “Just a moment!” she called out. Her shoes clicked loudly as she stomped around the screen with her hands clenched. Catra heard her breathe deeply to compose herself and opened the door, probably ready to tear Adora and her friends a new one.

“Can I help… ah… Yes. I’m sorry, I thought you were… someone else.” The midwife’s voice warmed. “Oh, thank you. Yes, these will be appreciated, I’m sure.” A pause while the other person spoke. “Yes, I will tell her. I think that’s a very good idea.”

The tall woman returned, a bundle of cloth in her hands. “Castaspella brought these. She thought you’d be more comfortable if you could change. She apologizes that the fit is only approximate. She guessed your size and then had to take whatever the tailor had on the rack.”

Catra shook her head, confused. “Tailor?”

“Person who makes clothes.” Muriel handed her the stack. “You were asleep and she didn’t like to go into your room without permission. She said she’ll entertain the rest while we finish here.”

“Oh. Okay.” Catra looked down at the small pile in her lap. She picked up the first thing; a loose shirt, new and soft. She pressed the sweet-smelling cloth to her face. It looked too loose to allow her to run four-footed or to fight in. It came to her that she could choose clothing for the first time in her life because she liked how it looked or felt, rather than its utility in a fight. She put that thought away for examination later.

A pair of loose drawstring trousers were underneath the shirt and Catra was relieved Aunt Casta hadn’t come back with sorcerer’s robes or something.

The stack also included underwear and some thick stirrup socks that would only reach her knees, but that made sense if she was wearing them with long pants. They even had the soft leather half-sole sewn onto the bottom to protect the tender parts of her feet.

“Ah. I wondered what was taking her so long. She must have had them finish those while she waited,” Muriel said, looking over as Catra examined them.

“Huh?”

Muriel nodded at the socks. “Those are Castaspella’s work.”

“She made these?” Catra had seen Aunt Casta working on a project with this yarn just about every time they were together this past week. Thicker and warmer than what Catra usually wore, but her feet were so cold that she put them on right away.

“Would you like to get dressed before I let the family in?” The midwife asked, gently. “It might make you feel better.”

Catra nodded. “Yeah.” The suggestion was a good one; she probably would feel better if she didn’t have to meet them

wearing little else than an exam gown, underwear, and a blanket.

Muriel put her hand out to pull Catra to her feet. "There's the bathroom." She pointed to the door opposite the door of the exam room. "There's more pads in there for the bleeding. You'll want to change it frequently. Probably every couple of hours at first. Toss the dirty stuff into the linen hamper and I'll have them launder and return your things."

"Yeah, got it." Catra shuffled over to the bathroom with the stack of new clothes, still wondering what she was going to say.

Melog felt she should tell Adora everything. Without a doubt, the magical creature had Catra's best interests at heart, but Catra wasn't sure they understood the situation, being an alien.

On the other hand, Aunt Casta agreed with them. That thought invited a closer look. The sorceress had known Adora for three years and she thought Catra should tell her. However, while the sorceress had *urged and advised*, at no point had she ordered Catra to tell or threatened to tell Adora herself. She had even told Catra she would straight-up lie to Adora if Catra wanted her to. Since their conversation this morning, Aunt Casta had been very clear that everything was about what Catra wanted. Even when Aunt Casta obviously disagreed with Catra's choice to not accept painkillers, she had not argued. She had held Catra's hand and wiped her tears without comment. What had the sorceress said? *What you want is the only thing that matters right now.*

As Catra changed, she realized how thoughtful Aunt Casta was in her choice of clothing. The shirt was long enough that it could be tucked in and the loose trousers hid the thick pad. She pulled up the cuffs of her pants and admired the socks, running her fingers over the cabled pattern. For whatever reason, Aunt Casta had spent hours creating something just for her. And then she had taken the time to hunt up some clean clothes for Catra for no reason except to make her comfortable. The idea made the former soldier's eyes sting.

In Catra's experience, nothing was ever freely given. She had always assumed that she'd have to fight for every inch of ground, every shred of autonomy, every good thing in her life. But here..?

A sob rose from Catra's throat before she could stop it and then another quickly followed. She leaned on her hands over the sink and choked the sound down. In the mirror, her reflection looked back at her, tears dripping down her face, eyes swollen after spending all day crying. Her gut hurt and she thought longingly of the soft bed she shared with Adora. She wanted to curl up with her wife in the warm sanctuary of their blankets and let the whole day go. In order for that to happen, she had to face Adora and tell her *something.*

She washed the sweat and tears from her face. There was nothing she could do about her swollen eyes. The sobs she just pushed down until they turned to concrete in her chest.

A terrible idea formed in her mind. It was reckless and stupid, and it was probably going to ruin her life, but maybe it was what needed to happen? She promised Adora *she'd try.* Is this what trying looked like?

Dressed, Catra stumbled out of the bathroom, back to sit on the couch. She pressed herself into Melog's side and buried her head into their mane, soaking in their weird ticklish scent for a moment. Although she didn't speak, Melog understood her intention and purred soft approval at her decision.

Finally, Catra lifted up her head to talk to Muriel. "I'll just…." Her throat seemed to close up around the sounds, and she took a long breath before trying again. The voice that came out of her mouth didn't seem like her own. "I'll just tell her everything, see how bad she takes it, and go from there." She squinted up at the other woman, hoping she would understand. "You'll probably have to help with some of this. I…" Catra didn't know how to explain that sometimes the words wouldn't come. "It's really hard for me," she admitted, cringing at how weak it must sound.

"Yes, of course." Once again, Muriel's voice held neither judgment nor pity. "Would you like me to have only your wife come in or do you want to see all of them?"

"Let them all come in. I already told Sparkles that I would." Also, Catra reasoned that Adora might be less likely to have a meltdown if her friends were here. "And...if Aunt Casta is still out there… would you see if she wouldn't mind…?"

Muriel gave a gracious nod.

To Melog, Catra grumbled, "if this goes to shit, I am blaming you."

Melog leaned forward to lick her ear. "If this goes as badly as you fear, she was never worthy of your love."

Yeah, right.

A cup of something hot sat on the little table by the couch, replacing the empty bowl of soup. She wrapped her hands around it and took a drink. It was sweet with honey and full of cream.

"You can let She Ra in; or Adora. Whichever. I want to see her." Catra muttered, hunching over the tea she held in her hands. She wanted to see Adora *so much*, but the image of Adora looking across the battlefield at her, showing nothing but anger and disdain, wouldn't go away. She didn't know if she could survive that again, but if Adora couldn't understand why Catra had to do this, then maybe it *was* better to find out now.

Muriel pushed the screen against the wall to where it had originally been so that Catra had a direct line of sight to the door as she opened it. "You can co…."

The tall woman's words were cut off when Adora darted around her to cross the floor in three strides, sinking to one knee on the thick carpet right in front of Catra.

"Hey," Catra whispered as Adora's expression went from concerned to alarmed to outright scared. Catra had to admit,

she’d be just as freaked out, especially as this would be the second time in maybe three weeks.

“What happened?” The blonde woman whispered as she gently and carefully took the steaming cup out of Catra’s hands, setting it down on the table with a quiet click. Adora stroked Catra’s cheek, leaning in to touch their foreheads together.

Something in Catra’s chest loosened, and she felt like she could breathe again. Needing more, Catra tugged on Adora’s hand and the other woman understood, sitting beside Catra to pull her into her arms. Trembling as she leaned into Adora, Catra couldn’t answer and she didn’t need to. For a moment the whole world stood silent and it was just them.

The Truth Comes Out

Chapter Summary

More than one truth gets told.

If not for Bow and Glimmer’s presence, She Ra would already have torn Muriel's office door from its hinges. Adora was so anxious that she spontaneously transformed when Glimmer teleported. She’d knocked on the door as She Ra, only to have the midwife turn them away.

Her resentment of the tall, high-handed woman rising, Adora paced the hallway. Aunt Casta had shown up and given the woman a bundle of something. Now the sorceress, Glimmer, and Bow huddled in the hallway talking. Adora tuned out the conversation completely when Aunt Casta refused to give them any information.

The door opened, and *finally*, Adora could see her. Wan and pale, with deep circles under her eyes and pain lines around her mouth, she sat cross-legged on a comfortable couch with Melog settled under one elbow while in her two hands she held a cup of something that steamed.

Unable to wait for another second, Adora dodged around the midwife mid-sentence, ducking under Muriel’s arm so she could dash over to her wife, dropping to one knee in front of her.

“Hey,” Catra breathed, hunching over her cup, her eyes wide and her ears back, dressed in unfamiliar clothes that hung loosely on her slight frame. They must have come from Aunt Casta; they were the gray and blue colors the sorceress favored.

With great care, Adora took the hot mug away from Catra and put it on the little table beside the couch. “What happened?” She took one hand in hers and stroked her wife's cheek with the other.

No answer came yet. A tremor rattled Catra’s bones even as she pressed Adora's hand against her jaw and tugged a little, a silent request to sit on the couch and gather her wife up to her chest. Catra began to purr, but the sound did nothing to reassure Adora. It was the purr she used when one of them was hurt.

"It's all right. I'm here." Adora soothed before backing off to look into her face, asking more urgently. "But, what's going on? You look like…"

"I look like shit." Catra finished, her voice low and hoarse.

A little sheepishly, Adora nodded. "You kinda do."

"I kind of feel that way.” Catra leaned in to settle under Adora's chin and went limp in her arms.

"So… ah… what happened?" Adora asked again, unable to keep a plaintive note from her voice.

Under Adora's hands, the muscles in Catra's back tensed, and her tired purr faded. Taking a long breath, Catra sat up, extricating herself from Adora’s arms, and scooted back towards Melog. "This...this isn't easy." She pulled up her knees and wrapped her arms and tail around them.

"Catra?" Aunt Casta said softly, making Adora jump. She’d forgotten anyone else was here.

The blonde woman looked around. Bow, Glimmer, and Castaspella stood just inside the open door, apparently unsure if they should come in or not. Aunt Casta spoke in the gentlest voice Adora had ever heard from the sorceress, "Perhaps you both need some privacy. We can…"

"No. It's okay," Catra replied. "I want you here," she clarified."Please? I think it might help.”

The tall woman swept over to the three, ushering them inside. "Come in. Don’t stand there with the door open." She spoke to

the Queen of Bright Moon and the Head Sorceress of Mystacor as if she were scolding ill-mannered children. “Sit down. No one wants people looming over them.”

While the three settled into their chairs, Catra unfurled from her defensive posture, planting her feet solidly on the floor. She leaned forward, putting her elbows on her knees, and looked down at her hands, flexing her claws in and out. "So… uh… yeah, " she began. "You know those nightmares I've been having?" She didn't wait for the answer but went on immediately. “Yeah. It turns out most of that was real,” she whispered, clasping her hands and hanging her head.

“Real?” Adora asked. She wished that Catra would sit up and look at her, but it seemed she needed the space. "What do you mean?"

“Prime, he…ah…he… r-r…." The words came out in a strangled whisper, and it appeared Catra couldn’t continue. Taking her hands away from her face, she grabbed onto the couch cushions she sat on and sank her claws into the fabric. Her eyes were screwed shut, and her shoulders hunched. Every muscle in her body seemed clenched to its utmost tension. Instead of speech, a hiss emerged from her throat.

This happened when they were kids. Catra described it as the words getting stuck; they were in her head but wouldn't come out of her mouth. Adora’s problem was always the opposite; her mouth kept going when her mind had no idea what she was supposed to say.

“Whatever it is, it’s over now. He’s gone,” Adora whispered. “I love you. Nothing he did can change that.”

Like someone underwater for too long, Catra took a deep, loud breath. She blew it out and slowly opened her eyes. “Prime…he r-raped me." The words tumbled out quickly as if she could only utter them if she kept the momentum."That was real. I didn’t want it to be. But it was."

Roaring filled Adora’s ears as the universe shrank down to Catra’s hunched figure. Even with Glimmer’s warning (which Adora would be forever grateful for), the words burned. “Catra. I…" The blonde woman reached out to her wife.

“No, don’t.” Catra shrank back, her fur fluffing up. The pupils of her yellow and blue eyes were wide, and one ear twitched.

Remembering how Catra winced away from contact when they first rescued her, Adora pulled her hand back. "Sorry."

“No, it's not you. Let me finish first." Catra put her hand on Melog's back and looked away. "You might not want to do that by the time I'm done. It...gets worse."

How can it be worse?

“So, you know those weird-ass symptoms I’ve been having?” Catra asked after a short silence.

Not seeing how that was involved, Adora nodded tentatively.

“Yeah. I got…” The smaller woman’s face twisted with disgust. “He made me… “ Again, the words just wouldn’t come, and she dropped her head back into her hands.

Hoping to soothe her, Adora reached out and rubbed her back.

“You’re pregnant,” murmured Glimmer. “Aren’t you?”

At the word, Adora gasped; she couldn’t help it. Even after all this time, she had never gotten over the way Glimmer and Bow would just casually talk about reproduction.

“She can’t be. That’s impossible.” Adora said quickly, pressing down gently on Catra’s shoulder, relieved that the muscles under her hand were not bunching in preparation for a leap, knowing she would have to intervene if Catra decided to go after Glimmer. The former Horde officer had been here for so little time that she

might not recognize that Glimmer wasn't trying to be insulting. "I told you about that. We all have these implants that... "

"It's not impossible." The flat, quiet statement rang out like a shout as Catra lifted her head, weary eyes turning to meet Adora's."He took it out."

Adora snatched her hand back to cover her mouth. The very idea made her want to vomit.

If she noticed the movement, Catra gave no sign; she just continued in a bleak, tired voice. "And… and yeah. He…did what Sparkles just said he did." She looked down at her hands again.

The roaring got louder. It filled Adora's ears, making everything sound far away.

"That's why Aunt Casta brought you to see Muriel?" Glimmer's voice was low, sympathetic.

Catra's head jerked up to stare at Glimmer, her ears going up, questioningly.

"Muriel is one of the midwives who specialize in caring for assault survivors. That's why I sort of freaked out when we got Melog's text." The Queen paused and then added very quietly, "I've been… um… seeing her myself. For... for counseling."

"Wait…." Catra hissed.

"Oh," Aunt Casta breathed. Her face was composed but she put her hand to her chest, as though her heart hurt.

A tidal wave of loathing and impotent fury rose up from Adora's belly, threatening to drown her. Invisible sparks of magic began to prickle on her skin as She Ra tried to surface, wanting to protect everyone. No one was looking at her, so hopefully, they wouldn't notice before she could push it back.

Adora closed her eyes and held her breath to the count of four, going through the meditation exercises Perfuma recommended when Adora had gone to her trying to find out why She Ra had become so inconsistent.

It didn't work. As soon as Adora closed her eyes, the memory of her encounter with Prime on his ship crowded to the forefront of her mind. The way Prime's darkly attractive voice elicited a ghost of excitement from her gut- just a visceral instinct of course but she squirmed in shame that she was attracted to any part of him. She remembered the way he'd offered Catra as a bribe. "If you want her," he had said with a dismissive sneer. His repellent touch and elegant manner made her feel like she was somehow contaminated and she spent an hour or more in the shower on Darla as soon as she could. She remembered how both Glimmer and Catra had similarly stressed Darla's water recycling capacity.

The magic pushed at Adora even more insistently. The urge to reach out, take the Sword and strike someone down in righteous vengeance rushed across her, an icy blue river of power; Prime was dead, but there were others of his ilk that She Ra could find and destroy.

A long growl that was more inside Adora's head than outside made her eyes open. Melog stared at her. They spoke, but not to Adora and she couldn't quite catch what they said. The magic that was gathering seemed to understand Melog and gently dissipated into the aether. No one else in the room caught their interaction.

"You know how he liked to talk," Glimmer was still talking. She shifted her chair closer to Catra and leaned in. "And how often he liked to 'entertain' me. He... " Glimmer stopped. "He never… I mean, not really. He only put his hands on me once or twice. It was more… mental."

"You never told me," Catra whispered, her ears pinning back with distress and her tail caressing the back of Glimmer's hand.

“At the time, I thought you knew. Afterward," Glimmer shrugged jerkily as if to dismiss the whole subject, "we were too involved with what was going on here. It-it wasn't that bad."

"Glimmer…" Bow said.

"Could we just get through one crisis at a time, please?" Glimmer snapped at Bow. “We can talk about it later,” she told her aunt in a more peaceable voice. She went back to Catra. "What are you going to do?” she asked.

Trembling again, Catra rubbed her palms on her thighs and then wrapped her arms around herself. “It-it’s already done. Muriel… she…."

Still reeling from both revelations, but without the added pressure of She Ra trying to show up, Adora found her voice. "So…so this means you’re going to have a baby?" she interrupted, her voice too loud and bright. Clamping down hard on her revulsion, she rushed to reassure her wife. "Listen, it'll be okay." She tried for a smile and took Catra’s hand. “We’ll get through this. It's not a crime here.”

Those gold and blue eyes began to shimmer. Frightened by the depths of pain in Catra's face, Adora hurried on, saying the first things that came to her. "No. Listen. It'll be okay. People just do it when they feel like it and nobody cares. We can fix this." Adora remembered her shock at seeing obviously gravid women walking openly in the first few months after her defection. “I promise, nobody will care. We don't have to tell anyone what happened. Nobody has to know that… " Adora was talking so fast that she had to take a big gulp of air. "Nobody has to know where it came from. We could just tell people that with the end of the war, we decided it was a good time to…"

At that, Catra flinched, snatching her hand back. "You can just shut up, now," she snarled around tears. She made a noise like a sob and hissed at Melog, "I told you what she'd say."

Adora's breath sped up, and she felt a hideous distance spring up between the two of them. Struggling to make sense of what she said wrong, Adora tried again, reaching out to stroke her wife's shoulder. "Catra, no. I didn't mean…" Catra shook her off and Adora pulled back, at a complete loss.

"Adora. Stop." Aunt Casta moved to sit next to the blonde woman. "Calm down." The sorceress' dark eyes were understanding, but her voice was firm. She put her arm around Adora as she often did with Glimmer. "Let her finish."

Melog edged closer to Catra, shrinking so they could nose their way into her lap, and began a deep calming purr. They spoke to her for a minute, until she raised her hand to pet their ear.

"Yeah? You think so?" she croaked in a barely-audible, tear-soaked voice. She sighed and appeared to consider whatever Melog said. "Okay, fine." Her voice was flat, hopeless, but she said, "I'll try." She paused and then, "I'm still fucking blaming you." It sounded like she was going for snark, but it came out as despair.

"Catra. Please tell me what's going on," Adora begged.

After several seconds of silence, Catra turned to look at the midwife. "Muriel? Could…could you?"

Muriel stood up from her desk. "Yes, of course. You'd like me to go over everything?"

Catra nodded vigorously. "Please."

The midwife dragged her desk chair over and sat. "Catra was referred to me for a consultation for the unintended conception. She requested I perform a termination." The tall woman squinted at her as if making sure Adora followed.

Adora did not follow. Blinking in confusion, knowing she was two steps behind everyone else, feeling the familiar sense of panic

wriggle around in her belly, she scrambled to figure it out. “I don’t understand. Terminate? How do you terminate it?"

"In this case, I was able to do a vacuum extraction of the uterine contents."

"You sound like you mean… Oh.” A terrible wave of comprehension washed over her. “You killed it,” Adora said slowly. "Is that…” Hoping she was mistaken she turned to Glimmer. “Is that what she means? And that is *allowed*?”

The Queen of Brightmoon nodded soberly, but her eyebrows came together in confusion. "Of course.”

Bow leaned forward, frowning. “You mean it isn’t in the Horde?”

Muriel made a little noise in her throat. “No,” she said. “The Horde requires permission for any reproductive decision.”

“What?” Bow’s mouth dropped open. “You can’t be serious.”

“We were all raised to believe that we belonged to the Horde. We were all raised to believe Hordak and Shadow Weaver were the ultimate arbiters of our lives or deaths," Muriel told him. Her words took on the cadence of the Horde Citizen's Oath: 'We affirm anew the order and unity of the Horde, The individual submits to the Horde. The minority submits to the majority. The lower rank submits to the higher rank. The Horde submits to Hordak.” The woman smiled bitterly. “We said that in school, every day before lessons."

I…didn't know…people really did that." Adora swallowed hard and ignored Bow and Muriel's side conversation. "I mean… I heard stories.” One of Shadow Weaver's favorite bedtime stories was how Princesses killed unborn babies. It was right up there with the stories about Princesses weeping blood and stealing souls. She had heard also heard the rumors of implant failures (mostly from Catra). “But I didn’t think that was real.”

Muriel nodded her head. “Yes. I can explain it more fully another time. In this case, the fetus was not viable anyway.”

“Viable?”

“It wouldn’t have lived if it was born. It stopped growing about four weeks ago. I doubt Prime actually meant it to become a child. I believe his intention was to harvest fresh genetic material." The woman wrapped her arms around herself as if feeling a sudden chill, although the room was warm. "It probably would have died before it was born, anyway."

“What would happen then?” Adora looked from the midwife to where Catra sat curled up with Melog, avoiding eye contact with anyone.

The woman grimaced. “If the fetus dies, and the body doesn't expel it right away, it needs to be removed. Otherwise, the patient often dies of infection or hemorrhage."

“Catra could have died?” Again, Adora felt it absolutely necessary to check her understanding.

“Yes. That is one possibility.”

“And…and the baby would not have lived, regardless?”

“No.”

The midwife kept talking but Adora did not hear anything beyond those two bald statements. The blonde woman flashed on the green-eyed husk she had fought and then on Catra's shattered body, gasping painfully for each shallow breath, lying on the cold deck.

Abruptly, Adora realized that Muriel had finished. Everyone looked at her expectantly and eyed each other uneasily. Except for Catra who bared her fangs at how long Adora was taking to speak.

“Well, say something,” she seethed, perched on the couch with her feet under her, arms wrapped around her knees, holding herself like a coiled spring. Her tail lashed behind her and her ears pinned back. "Tell me how selfish I am or whatever." She ducked to rest her chin on her bent knees.

Selfish? Another flash and the first words Catra spoke when the chip was damaged, the first words Catra spoke when she was able to fight herself free of Prime’s control for an instant, reverberated in Adora’s head. *Why did you come back? We both know I don’t matter.*

“Catra?” Adora hardly recognized her own voice. "Please. Look at me."

Reluctantly, Catra lifted her head, her expression guarded.

"Why…why didn't you call me?" The aching lump in her throat made Adora’s voice crack.

Castaspella tightened her arm around Adora’s shoulders and said softly, “I’m afraid part of that was my fault. I was concerned that Catra’s condition would deteriorate dangerously if we waited."

A wet chuckle emerged from Catra. “Thanks, Aunt Casta, but you don’t have to be nice about it.” She sniffed and cleared her throat. “What she means is that I was in the basement, losing my shit, okay?” Her voice rose a little. “Then Muriel said she could get rid of it.” The words were accompanied by an irritable shrug as Catra looked away. “I wasn’t going to wait around.”

"You could have told me," Adora tried to keep her voice even, but fear increased the volume and pitch. "Last week you wouldn't even let me know you were sick. And then today you still can't call me? We're Official. You're my wife! You're supposed to tell me these things."

"Yeah, okay, whatever,” Catra sneered. Instead of looking at Adora, she studied her nails.

The familiar, dismissive tone set Adora’s teeth on edge. “Catra!” This was the same thing that always happened. “You should have told me!” The blonde woman’s heart started to race. It had been like this since they were kids. Always the same. Catra had no respect for anyone. She always had to do things her own way. She never considered the consequences of her actions or how her decisions affected anyone else. She just always acted on whatever impulse crossed her mind no matter what anyone else had to say about it. She would never listen. “Why do you always have to…”

"Adora." Muriel's low, calm voice cut across Adora's panicky internal diatribe before she could really build up her outrage. “She’s telling you now."

A little silence followed that pronouncement. Bow and Glimmer held their breath. Melog growled at Adora, their ears pinned back and their mane and tail became jagged and spikey, in contrast to Catra’s disdainful smirk as she studied the unsheathed claws on her right hand. The claw on Catra’s ring finger no longer curved to a point and she was fingering the blunt edge with her thumb. She’d broken the tip off somehow. How had she done that?

“Look,” Catra finally said, still not looking into Adora’s face. “If you want, I can pack up my shit and get out of your way.”

"No, Catra." Castaspella's soft voice brooked no argument. "You aren't going anywhere, not right now.” She flicked her eyes towards Glimmer, who nodded. “If you feel you want some time by yourself, Adora can certainly go back to Bright Moon to stay with Glimmer.” She smiled lopsidedly. “When you feel better, you can, of course, go anywhere you like, but please, don’t ever think that your welcome here is contingent on your relationship with Adora.”

That broke through Catra’s stony facade. She momentarily froze, only her eyes moving to look at Castaspella. Her ears rose in surprise and her cheeks reddened. “Yeah, okay.” she conceded hoarsely while Melog leaped from her side onto the floor,

enlarging to their full size to rub their face against the sorceress's shoulder.

Feeling a headache starting, Adora wondered when this discussion had spun out of control. “No, I don’t want to leave! I don’t want *you* to leave!” she almost wailed. “I *want* you to talk to me!”

Catra’s ears dropped and her hand floated up to touch the back of her neck, yet again reassuring herself that the chip was gone. Her mouth twisted sideways and she sniffled. Melog whisked around, returning to nose at her face and she leaned her forehead into theirs, her eyes screwed shut.

Wordlessly, Muriel stood, walking to her desk and returning to press something white into Catra’s hand which the former soldier used to mop her wet face.

Oh.

The calm that she had only ever experienced on the battlefield descended on Adora. How could she have forgotten the signs of a Catra waiting for punishment? The twist of Catra's mouth wasn't contempt, but the effort of holding back tears. The dismissive voice was what came out when she tried to cover up fear. And nothing ever good came from meeting Shadow Weaver's gaze.

Fuck.

All the choking rage, hurt, and confusion drained out of her, leaving her clear-eyed and determined. Prime didn’t get to wreck them, and neither did Shadow Weaver. Adora herself could have an emotional breakdown over the ethical dilemmas later. Right now, she needed to pull her shit together. Her wife was sick, in pain, and so, so scared.

Keeping her movements slow, Adora reached out to take Catra’s hand away from her neck. The smaller woman sat up, her normally slit pupils blown out and her hands shaking as they always did when Prime's name came up, but Catra allowed the touch and didn’t flinch.

"I’m sorry." Adora held her wife’s hand in both of hers. It was cold, so she rubbed it. “This is a lot. I’m kind of freaked out. But I don’t want to leave you.” She brought Catra’s hand to her cheek, a wordless invitation.

“Are you sure?” Catra's fragile, uncertain voice wrung Adora’s heart. Now that she knew to look for it, she saw how swollen Catra's eyes were. Her irises were large enough that they hid the irritation on the whites but the corners and the rims were red and inflamed.

Trying to smile encouragingly, Adora nodded. “Yeah. We can talk about it all later. Okay?”

Catra studied Adora for a long moment before she shuffled closer. “I’m so tired,” she whispered. “I want to go home.” She tucked her head into Adora’s shoulder and wrapped her arms around her back. Adora imagined the phantom sting of claws going through her jacket, but Catra was careful to keep them sheathed.

“I’ll take you there,” Adora whispered back. “I love you,” That was the important thing. Everything else could wait.

The Other Side of Truth

Chapter Summary

Catra discovers the consequences of speaking the truth.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Melog had refused to believe it, but Catra was pretty confident there was no way Adora would want to touch her again after hearing all this.

Predictably, horror flashed across her wife's face when Catra said Prime had raped her. When Catra got to the part about being infested with the Parasite Thing, the blonde woman snatched her hand back in disgust, but she immediately went into fix-it mode. Babbling on about doing the right thing until Aunt Casta made her stop.

When Muriel explained that Catra had the midwife kill it, Adora went unnaturally still. When Catra couldn't stand the silence anymore, she demanded Adora say something.

"We're Official. You're my wife! You're supposed to tell me these things!"

Catra shrank into herself. This was exactly why telling Adora was a terrible idea. She didn't need to hear how much of a fuck up she was. How she should have waited for advice. How they could have been parents.

Fortunately, Catra had few illusions about herself. She was selfish, cruel and everything everyone said about her. Yes, she fucking killed babies in the fucking womb, if that's how the great fucking hero wanted to see it. She didn't regret it, and she'd do it again in a heartbeat. She would have thrown herself off of a cliff rather than continue to be a vessel for Prime.

"Yeah." That was all Catra could say around the unuttered sobs she shoved more deeply down into her chest. "Okay." Looking at Adora was too hard. Instead, she studied the broken claw on her hand. "Whatever."

"Catra!" Adora's volume began to rise towards a shout as she gained steam. "You should have told me!"

Grinding her teeth to keep from hissing, Catra kept staring at her claw, watching it blur and sharpen as she blinked away tears, repeating the mantra that got her through meetings with Shadow Weaver and Hordak.

Don't cry. Don't cry. Don't cry.

"Why do you always…?"

"Adora," Muriel coolly interrupted. "She's telling you now."

Into the silence that followed, Catra offered the only thing she could think of to help the situation. "Look," she said with as much dignity as her broken heart would allow her. "If you want, I can pack up my shit and get out of your way." Catra could get Scorpia to dissolve their union once she returned to the Fright Zone.

"No, Catra. You aren't going anywhere, not right now," Aunt Casta decreed, her low voice carrying an edge of steel.

Thrown off balance by the pronouncement, Catra froze, her hackles going up.

"If you feel you want some time by yourself, Adora can certainly go back to Bright Moon to stay with Glimmer."

Oh, right. Aunt Casta probably didn't want Catra to go out and make herself sick again after they had spent so much time patching her up.

"But, please, don't ever think that your welcome here is contingent on your relationship with Adora."

That was… That was *exactly* what Catra had thought.

Still frozen, Catra lifted her eyes from studying her broken claw to the sorceress's face. Aunt Casta smiled at her, gentle black eyes reflecting an emotion Catra didn't recognize. No one ever looked at Catra like that.

Except… Maybe they had? An almost memory played on the edge of her mind, just a vague impression of kneading tiny claws into warm, silky fur, a gentle hand on her scruff, tender blue and yellow eyes gazing back at her.

Melog leaped off the couch to rub up against Aunt Casta's shoulder, while Catra could only choke out a few words. They weren't the *right* words; Catra didn't *know* the right words for what she was feeling, but she hoped Aunt Casta understood.

Adora was talking. Probably saying she was ready to get Sparkles to take her back to Bright Moon.

Only… only she wasn't. In front of everybody, in that exasperated, exasperating, if-you-listened-to-me-everything-would-be-fine Adora tone, she cried, "I don't want to leave! I don't want you to leave me! I want you to talk to me."

That couldn't be right. This had to be another fantasy.

"Granddaughter." Melog appeared right in front of her, bumping their head into hers before she had time to spiral. "You're here. I am with you. The Destroyer is dead."

Catra's eyes closed, and she leaned her forehead against Melog's. Someone gave her a handkerchief, and Catra wiped her stupid, streaming eyes. Again.

This was ridiculous.

Adora moved closer, not touching, but Catra could feel Adora's warmth. A few minutes ago, Adora's scent had been as thick with fear and anger as any day on the battlefield. Now those notes

were evaporating, leaving warm, familiar signals that made Catra relax almost in spite of herself.

“I’m sorry. This is a lot.” The anger and turmoil in Adora’s voice had become soft and sad. "I'm kind of freaked out,” she admitted.

Catra felt a touch on the back of her neck. Adora’s fingers stroked Catra’s, coaxing her to sheath her claws before they damaged the tender almost-healed flesh. With all the delicacy necessary for handling an armed explosive device, the blonde picked Catra's hand up, guiding it away from the smaller woman's neck, enclosing it with both of hers, and rubbing warmth into it.

“But, I don’t want to leave you," the blonde woman whispered into Catra’s ear like a promise.

Mystified by the gossamer touch and the impassioned tone, Catra sat up slowly, opening her eyes to stare at her wife. *You don’t? What’s wrong with you? Don’t you know what he did to me? Don’t you understand?* Angry, frightened, confused thoughts clamored through Catra’s brain. “Are you sure?” she begged. The pathetic tone made her cringe.

"Yeah. " Blue-gray eyes shimmered with regard so sweet that it took Catra’s breath away. "We can talk about it all later. Okay?” The watery smile Adora gave her left Catra bewildered as she tried to stutter something out that wouldn’t seem dopey or pathetic. Whatever she said must have been the right thing. Adora brought Catra’s hand to her cheek and tugged.

Letting herself be drawn in again, Catra wrapped her arms around Adora’s back, going limp. One sword-callused hand reached up to stroke her hair and the other carefully pulled her across her wife’s lap.

Now Catra gave in to the comfort her body and soul so desperately craved. She tucked her head into the crook of Adora’s neck and let those strong arms encircle her.

Adora whispered, "I love you," and "I'll take you home" and "I'm here," until even Catra's treacherous brain began to believe her. When did she get so weak?

Finally, heat flowed back into Catra’s limbs. Finally, she was no longer flying apart.

Adora was here.

Adora hadn’t left her.

Adora was going to stay.

An involuntary purr rumbled out of her chest and Catra just let it, heedless of their audience, too worn out to keep it back. Someone (it sounded suspiciously like Arrow Boy)made a small noise of delight. For a moment, Catra was tempted to snarl, but it didn’t seem worth the effort. Especially when Melog jumped up to sit on her other side, purring in time with her.

The others spoke quietly to each other. Too tired to care, Catra ignored them in favor of snuggling closer to her wife.

“Can she go yet?” Adora asked anxiously, “I really want her to be able to sleep in her own bed."

Whatever, Catra could stay here all day. Adora’s lap was plenty comfortable enough.

“Catra?” Muriel called. It sounded like the woman had repeated herself a few times.

“Mrrpp?” Catra asked, opening her eyes, lifting her head, and squinting at the midwife. Had she dozed off?

“Would you like me to go over your instructions with your family?” Apparently, the midwife saw that Catra was just done.

“That would be good,” Catra grunted, not bothering to correct Muriel’s words. She dropped her face back down to Adora’s

shoulder.

The midwife explained to the others in the room what amount of bleeding was normal and how long she could expect it to continue. What precautions and what medicines to take for pain and infection. It was oddly comforting to tune out the midwife, knowing that Adora would remember it for her.

"The instructions are written here. " Muriel rustled some papers. It sounded like Glimmer took them because Adora's arms didn't move. "I expect to see her back in two weeks. I've written down the appointment time."

Finally, a question occurred to Catra. "Am I going to be stuck in bed for that long?" She lifted her head and rubbed her eyes

"No. Don't lift anything over twenty pounds, and no swimming. Otherwise, activity as tolerated. If you start to bleed more heavily, or your cramping gets worse, it means you need to relax."

Catra breathed a sigh of relief. She'd been confined to bed for three days for the infection in her neck. That sucked a lot.

"But!" Muriel fixed Catra with a stern glare. "I do not want to see you on the training grounds except to watch until after you see me in two weeks. I know what you soldiers are like. You would have everything under control right up until you face planted in the sand from blood loss."

"Yes, ma'am," Catra murmured, once again grateful that Muriel was not treating her as though she were fragile.

"I do not have time for people who go out and get re-injured when they don't have to."

"No, ma'am."

Muriel's voice gentled. "Go to the beach or something like that."

"Beach? Why would I want to go to a beach?"

Glimmer spoke up. "Oh, I think you'll love it. Adora can take you." She grinned wickedly at the blonde woman.

The arms around Catra tensed, so she pulled back a little to be met with Adora's strained smile. "The beach here is one of the places people go to relax," the blonde woman explained. "I went with Glimmer a couple of times, but it really didn't work for me."

"Wow, something relaxing doesn't work for Adora," Catra deadpanned. "I can't imagine. "

Adora chuckled at the joke and the tension left her arms. Catra's chest warmed. "I think you'll like it though. The sand is warm and you can lie in the sun."

Although sprawling in the sun was one of Catra's favorite guilty pleasures, she was not at all sure she liked the sound of this. "Lying down? On sand?" Catra's eyebrow raised skeptically.
 "Yeah, because I want to itch for a week."

Now, Adora's smile was pure mischief. "I promise Mystacor doesn't have those." She looked at Bow and Glimmer. "We did a survival training thing on the shore once. We spent days combing the sand fleas out."

"Fortunately, sand fleas don't live in this kind of sand," Aunt Casta assured them.

"I'll have you and Adora's meetings canceled for the next two weeks," Glimmer put in. "I'll just tell people you both need some more time off. Stress and everything."

"Mmm." Catra put her head down again.

Worn out by the stress of this day, Castaspella longed to crawl into her own bed. But, as a poet once said, she still had miles to go before she slept, and these three motherless girls were breaking her heart.

Glimmer had never even hinted that her experience as a prisoner included sexual assault, but now that Castaspella considered what she had been told, it was obvious. The sorceress was profoundly grateful for Bow's maturity and love for Glimmer. More than likely that he had been the one who encouraged Glimmer to seek out counseling before she reached a crisis. He was going to be a fantastic royal consort.

Catra's assumption that her place was entirely dependent on Adora and would be summarily evicted from Mystacor if her relationship with the other woman went south made the sorceress want to cry.

Just as gutwrenching was how Adora scrabbled to manage every situation; barreling right over other people, convinced that it was her sole responsibility to fix things.

Clearly, it was a well-worn dance, Castaspella was pleased that she and Muriel could interrupt the dynamic before it turned ugly. The damage Shadow Weaver had done to the young women was deeper, more purposeful, and far more grotesque than the damage done to Castaspella and Micah. The hag had many more years and absolute power over these children.

Sorceress.

The strange thought voice drifted into Castaspella's mind, making her start. Not many sorcerers were capable of telepathy and fewer still would risk doing it without a good reason. It took far too much power to play games with it.

Necromancy is still wrong. Melog stared straight at her, a feline *smirk* on their face.

Probably.

They blinked at her slowly before they shifted their attention back to their ward.

Chapter End Notes

It's May 2022 as I write this. I live in the US. Headed to Pro Choice protests this week.

I started this because of the Texas law. I see too few stories that depict abortions accurately. This story contains descriptions of abortions as I have seen them (I used to work at a clinic that provides abortions) and experienced as accurately as my writing allows.

Yes, I had an abortion without sedation. My own choice. For... reasons. Staff thought I was crazy but held my hand and mopped my face.

A real world parallel to this story might be getting pregnant as a result of being raped while drunk or drugged.

I write my stress.

If you live in the US please let your legislators know that outlawing abortion is a terrible idea.

Sandcastles

Chapter Summary

Glimmer and Catra talk

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"You just put the blanket down on the sand, " Glimmer explained. “And then you lie on it.” She took out the smaller blanket she brought in her bag for herself, and then the larger one for Catra and Melog.

"Uh-huh." Catra took the proffered blanket and shook it out. She hadn’t seen any fleas in the sand yet, but she still wasn't sure about this.

Melog, on the other hand, was thrilled by the prospect, delight coming off of them in waves. "To lie on this sand will be very pleasant, Granddaughter," her protector told her. "It stores magic as it stores heat. The sorcerers make their mirrors and lenses from this sand." Melog stretched out on the blanket with a contented groan.

“Okay. If you say so.”

Melog flopped onto their side, inviting Catra to lie with them. She took the invitation and settled herself down. At the very least, napping would feel nice.

The morning light had just started to heat the sand, but already it felt as warm as some of the steam pipes she used to like to curl up on when she was a kid. Lying on her back, looking up at the fluffy clouds in the sky, the fine white sand under the blanket felt oddly soft, like firm pillows. Almost against her will, she relaxed and let herself sink down.

Oh. *Oh.*

Now she understood what Sparkles had been talking about. The heat (or maybe the magic) from the ground radiated up, warming her to the bones, soothing the painful cramps in her belly and her back. Tension and sore spots in muscles she didn't know *existed* oozed out of her, making her feel as though she was nothing more than a warm puddle.

"Aaaah." A long involuntary sigh escaped her throat.

Wind, distant birdcalls, and the sound of waves created a soothing white noise. This beach had no water, but a strange fog (or maybe a cloud?) moved back and forth over the edge of a dropoff, creating the sound. This perpetual mist cooled the air enough that overheating was no danger.

The light was a little bright, making Catra's eyelids feel heavy. Melog stretched out beside her. They'd wake her if there was a problem. She let her eyes sag shut.

"How's she doing?" Arrow Boy asked Glimmer in a whisper, startling Catra since she hadn't heard him walk up.

"You could ask me, you know," Catra said without opening her eyes.

"Okay," he replied, more loudly. "How are you doing?"

"Sleepy," she muttered, turning on her side and snuggling back down. "Don't go around whispering. You'll make people think you're up to something. Talk like a normal person."

Bow laughed. "Fair enough."

Glimmer and Bow chatted for a little bit, but Catra tuned them out since they weren't whispering anymore. Melog added their purr to the sound of the waves.

A figure standing over her, stinking of sorcery, and touching her shoulder woke Catra from a profound sleep. The thick, coppery smell of her own blood hung heavy in the air. Deep pain in her lower back and abdomen made her wonder if Shadow Weaver had beaten her with a truncheon.

Discovering that she was not bound by either shadows or cuffs, Catra's hand shot out before she was fully conscious, aiming a lethal swipe at the owner of the hand and voice, her claws connecting with….

Nothing. The tingle of magic and the sound of tiny wind chimes identified her attacker.

Not Shadow Weaver. Sparkles. Fuck. Was this an interrogation? She *knew* Sparkles had it in her.

The pain in her belly made Catra slow and weak, unable to bounce to her feet. A lassitude gripped her limbs and she remembered someone telling her she'd lost some blood. She covered her face defensively with one arm, slashing blindly with the other; resolute that she would not go down easily.

"Catra? Catra! It's okay. You're in Mystacor. You're safe." The enemy's voice had no business sounding so kind and concerned."It's me. Glimmer."

Wait. Oh. Right. Confused and disoriented, Catra trembled as she sat up, while her half-sleeping mind struggled to remember where she was. She lowered her arm feeling stupid but relieved. The magic she scented was *not* Shadow Weaver. She was *not* in a cell somewhere. The Queen of Bright Moon had *not* taken her prisoner. The pain she was in had nothing to do with captivity.

"I'm sorry. I didn't mean to scare you" Glimmer said from behind her, speaking as if she just hadn't had to teleport out of range of Catra's claws. "You were asleep for a while. You should wake up and drink something. You don't want to get dehydrated."

Melog was no longer beside Catra. That was probably why she lashed out without thinking. Even if she didn't have nightmares, she sometimes woke up on the defensive if they were gone. She rubbed her eyes and ran her hand through her hair, turning around to look at the other woman. "Where is everyone?"

"Adora got back from her run. She sat still for about five minutes before she couldn't take it anymore." Glimmer's mouth quirked up at the corner. "They went to soak in the hot springs. Melog went with them. I was surprised they were interested. I didn't think cats of any kind liked water." Glimmer sat down on the big blanket next to Catra, apparently unphased by her narrow escape from getting her guts torn out. "How are you feeling? You probably need something for your cramps around about now."

The growing pain in her belly definitely contributed to Catra's violent reaction to being woken up. "Yeah. That would be great." The blood smell she could not escape didn't help either. Adora assured her that no one else could smell it, but it was so disgusting.

Glimmer searched the bag she had with her and brought out a small bottle of pills, pouring two into Catra's hand. "It's just a preparation of willow," Glimmer told her. "Do you want the stronger stuff?"

"No. It's not that bad," Catra lied.

The other woman rolled her eyes and grumbled, "I see where Adora gets it from. Well, it's here if you need it. And I brought some drinks." She reached over to a tray that had appeared while Catra slept. Water condensed on the outside of two tall metal cups and they made an odd clinking sound when Glimmer lifted them up.

Catra took the surprisingly cold cup from Glimmer and looked inside. The sound was ice floating in some sort of fruit juice. She swallowed the two pills, chasing them down with a swallow of the sweet drink.

“I’ll be back.” She got up to head to the bathroom just inside the castle door that opened onto the beach. She needed to change her pad every two hours or so. She was glad she’d been warned that she’d pass larger clots after she’d been sleeping, otherwise she’d be very alarmed. This was *so* disgusting.

"Sorry, by the way," she muttered shame-faced at Glimmer when she returned.

“For what?” The other woman looked genuinely confused.

“Oh, I don’t know. For trying to claw your face off?”

“It’s fine. I know people are still pretty twitchy.” Glimmer shrugged, smiling ruefully. "I'm almost as bad. At least to hear Bow tell it.”

"What do you mean?"

"I just get nervous." The Queen wrapped her arms around herself and looked away. “I’ll sometimes just blink home if someone comes up behind me. It’s a little embarrassing if it happens at a diplomatic thing.”

"Yeah?" Catra couldn’t think of anything else to say. She hadn’t seen that, but she tended to avoid the more crowded and boring meetings.

Glimmer nodded, her face pensive. "And I still… I still can't stand to be alone.”

That made a ton of sense. “Me too,” Catra admitted, very quietly.

“I didn’t know that.” Slowly, Glimmer’s head turned, her eyes huge and her expression concerned. “You never said anything.”

“It’s okay.” Catra didn’t look at Glimmer, but out at the waves of mist. “Melog says they don’t mind staying with me.”

“Yeah.” Idly, Glimmer started digging around in the sand with one hand.. “When Bow asked Adora if she wanted to go sit in the hot springs, Melog seemed to really perk up, as if they were interested, but they wouldn’t leave until I said I’d stay with you.”

Shifting around, Catra stretched out to lie on her stomach, propping herself up on her elbows, letting the sand’s heat soothe the cramps. Just as idly, she began piling the damp sand Glimmer dug out of the hole into a little hill.

They met each other's eyes and grinned, but neither spoke. Instead, they began to dig other holes. A few inches beneath the surface, the sand became damp. At about six inches, the holes began to fill with water. They set about turning their little hills of wet sand into towers and fortresses. Catra used her claws to carve fiddly details and Glimmer got up and gathered a pile of shiny rocks to ornament hers.

“So, how are you feeling?” Glimmer finally asked as she patted another sand tower into shape.

“Still kind of shitty. These cramps are miserable. But they’re not as bad as they were last night. And whatever you just gave me is starting to work.”

“Yeah.” Glimmer sighed and seemed to be debating something in her head. When Catra glanced over, the woman’s lips were pursed and her eyebrows knitted. “But, I mean, how are you *feeling* ? Mentally, I mean.”

How to answer that? The former soldier wasn’t used to talking about her feelings and she wasn’t good at it. She chewed her lip, trying to find words.

Perhaps taking Catra’s silence for a rebuff, Glimmer focused her attention on her sand tower. "It's okay if you don't want to talk about it. "

"No. It's not that. I just don't know how to explain." How she was supposed to feel. Sad? Angry? Guilty? Mournful? Regretful? She

felt none of those things. Not about the Parasite Thing.

For a few minutes, Catra carved little windows on the tower she was working on trying to find the words for the weirdly light feeling in her heart. Was she *allowed* to feel happy about terminating a gestation? Was there something wrong with her that she did?

"I'm really… I feel *better* ," Catra said, finally. She did. She felt optimistic. Hopeful. Freed. *Whole* . Whole in a way she had not felt since a clone had snatched off her mask, fisted her hair, and cut it off in chunks. She felt that some fragment of her soul she had not realized was stolen returned to her.

Unable to articulate all that, she went with something easier. "I'm just so glad it's gone."

"I bet."

"I don't know what I would have done if Aunt Casta hadn't helped me." *Grateful* was a feeling. She could talk about that. "I don't know how to thank her. Yesterday was rough. I was… I was really scared." Okay, scared was a feeling she could talk about too. A lump rose up in her throat and her hands began to tremble so Catra pulled them away from her tower and rested her chin on them. "Before Aunt Casta took me to Muriel, I figured I'd have to find someone in the Crimson Waste to deal with it."

"What if you couldn't find someone?" Glimmer asked, curiously.

"That's what claws are for," Catra growled, moving her eyes to meet the other woman's gaze.

The implications of what Catra said took a minute to sink in. Glimmer's face paled, her eyebrows rising. Surprise, then fear passed over her face. It was precisely the same expression she had worn in their last battle as enemies, when Catra lay at Glimmer's feet, asking her to "just do it." The fear was clear in the Queen's voice. "What? You were planning to just cut it out or something?"

“Yeah, pretty much.”

The flat admission stopped Glimmer cold. She went very still and searched Catra’s eyes. “Did you want to die, or was that just a risk you were willing to take?”

“I don’t know.” Catra crossed her arms so she could pillow her head. This conversation was easier if she didn’t have to look at the other woman. Remembering that Glimmer’s hearing was not great, she turned her head to the side, staring out at the mist, so that her words wouldn’t be muffled. “I’m pretty sure Melog wouldn’t let me, y’know, like actually bleed out of anything.”

“That’s not what I meant.” Glimmer blinked out and reappeared, lying down on her side about a foot away from Catra so she could see her face. “Seriously. Were you planning to kill yourself?”

By now used to Glimmer’s sudden teleports, Catra shrugged. “Honestly? I don’t know.” It felt strange to be telling anyone this, but Glimmer had not yet betrayed a confidence or used her words against her. “I think I went into a panic and didn’t think that far.”

Soberly, the Queen nodded. “Okay. I get that.” She propped up her head with her hand and was silent.

“So, what about you?” Catra asked, after a minute. “How are you doing ‘mentally’?”

Glimmer smiled, but it didn’t reach her eyes. “I’m okay.”

“You’re lying,” the magicat asserted. “But, at least you do it better than Adora.”

The other woman’s smile turned crooked and then faded. She rolled onto her stomach and placed a few blue pebbles on top of the closest sand tower. “I’m not great,” she confessed. “ I freak out and teleport home when someone creeps up behind me. I have nightmares. I’m afraid of the dark." At the top of the tallest tower she placed a bright yellow stone. "But, it’s nothing like what you went through.`

“Yeah, that doesn’t matter. It still sucked, didn’t it?”

“Yes,” Glimmer replied, quietly. “You really didn’t suspect?”

"No." For this, Catra did feel guilty. She should have seen it, should have realized what was happening when Adora came back to the bunk room her eyes huge and hollow. The way she’d flinch from every touch.

No, that wasn’t right. Where did that come from? She was talking to Glimmer. "Did it happen a lot?"

Every fucking day, Catra. Every. Fucking. Day. Adora’s desperate voice spoke loud and clear in her head, but for some reason, Catra couldn’t pin down when she heard those words.

"No. He only started it a little before you saved me." Copying Catra’s posture from a few minutes ago, Glimmer pillowed her head on her arms, gazing out at the waves. "I told you, he only put his hands on me a few times. But everything from his ship feels like one long nightmare. "

That was the truth.

“You know how he liked to show off?" Catra asked. "He liked to show me what he'd done to people who defied him. From their point of view. " A full body shudder ran down her spine to her tail. "I guess since he never chipped you, he couldn’t make me experience … Oh.”

Oh, no.

“Hey, are you okay? You look pale all of a sudden.”

A wave of acute, clammy nausea that had nothing to do with her cramps gripped Catra with the force of a hand around her throat. She hauled herself over to the other side of the blanket and dug her claws into the ground, fighting not to puke.

Immediately a hand rubbed between her shoulder blades and another brushed her sweaty bangs off of her face.

"It's all right," Glimmer said soothingly. "Muriel said it might take a few days for the nausea to go away. I'm sorry, I should have brought you something to eat to take that painkiller with. Do you want me to go get you some crackers? I can get you some ginger tea, too."

Catra shook her head as tears flowed freely from her eyes. "N-no. It's not that." She gasped in a breath. "I just realized…" She couldn't say it, not without dry heaving. That's what Spinnerella meant when she said, "I know what Prime did to you." Everyone who was chipped had seen it. *Felt it.*

"Granddaughter?" Abruptly, Melog appeared beside Catra, their tickly scent overlaid with the smell of minerals although they didn't appear to be wet. "You are distressed."

"You think?" Catra hissed. How could she ever show her face in the Fright Zone again? How could she even speak to Scorpia again? And Mystacor! Every sorcerer, healer, and teacher who had been onsite the day Micah came was chipped. They would know. How was she supposed to live with that?

Breath coming too fast, Catra closed her eyes tight and curled up into a ball on the blanket with her hands over her face. Melog curled around her, supporting her, but nothing they did could change the facts. The only thing that she could imagine would possibly help was a hole for her to crawl into. A hole deep enough and dark enough that she could be forgotten forever.

Everyone. Knew.

Everyone.

Tiny wind chimes announced that Sparkles teleported out. Before Catra could begin to wonder where she'd gone, the sound marked her return.

“Catra? It’s okay. We’re here.” Adora knelt down on the blanket beside her, still wet and smelling of mineral salt. Without another word, the taller woman sat cross-legged on the ground so she could pull Catra’s rigid, balled-up form onto her lap.

“Catra?” A small hand stroked her back. “Is it okay if I hug you two?” Glimmer asked.

The magicat had promised herself that part of “being better” was that she wouldn't hurt Adora with her jealousy. Her wife was probably close to her limit with Catra’s freakouts and likely needed their support. At Catra’s jerky nod, the short woman’s arms went around Catra’s shoulders.

“Is this okay?” Bow asked, his hand replacing Glimmer’s on Catra’s back. Another nod. Melog made themselves small enough to sit on Catra’s lap.

Sobs built up in Catra’s chest. She sucked in a breath trying to stamp them down, stifling them to a guttural moan. The effort made her shake.

“I’ve got you.” Adora ran her hand through Catra’s hair. “We’re here.”

“I-I-I can’t… ” stammered Catra through tears, trying to get a handle on herself.

“S’okay,” Bow whispered as he kept rubbing her back. “Let it out. You’ll feel better.” He drew closer, his long arms encompassing all three women.

“He’s right.” Glimmer said and stroked the fur on her arm. “You’re safe with us.”

Melog made a noise of assent.

Somehow, with those assurances, the part of her that normally shrank from this sort of thing was silenced. The scent of Melog’s magic drowned out the odor of sorcery that reminded her a little

too much of Shadow Weaver. Although they were firm, the hands that held her were gentle as they stroked her back and head. They didn't feel scary or overwhelming. They were not trying to restrict her or hold her down. Rather, it felt like they were holding her up. Holding her together.

In the safety of their arms, at last, she gave in to the animal sounds of grief her body demanded, howling and sobbing until she was limp. No one asked why she was crying. No one told her to silence her noise. No one mocked her for it. Even when the storm passed and she was quiet, the three held her as Melog purred in her lap.

Chapter End Notes

> It is some days since Roe v. Wade was overturned. I am devastated. I am heartbroken. I am angry.

Everyone Knows

Chapter Summary

> Everyone. Knows.
> Catra begins to process this.
>
> CW for rape flashbacks. Go back and read the rest of the tags. This one is rough.
>
> If you want to skip the harder stuff, go down to the second line break, to the paragraph that begins, "With the sobs... ".

Light-headed and dry-mouthed, Catra stood at attention at the platform's edge. High up on her back, at the junction where her ribs met her spine, the sensation of a hot blade in her flesh made her long to twist and howl. She was pretty sure there wasn't actually anything there, but her perceptions were not to be trusted-- for all she knew, there was a real knife sticking out of her back. Her skin felt tight, her fur stifling, and her whole body ached. She knew she must be fevered. If she was lucky, some lethal infection was overcoming her.

Oh, please.

She could not pace, or writhe, or scream. She could not even shift on her feet. Prime kept her still and standing. The only evidence of her torment were the silent tears dripping down her face.

Please let me die.

After a certain point, flesh fails even the strongest will. Prime could not stop her shivering or the cold sweat that dripped past her half-closed lids, plastering her hair against her temples and her fur against her neck. He couldn't stop her immune system from giving up.

When she was a kid, during school assemblies, they stood at attention for extended times in the heat of the Fright Zone,

listening to Hordak's long-winded speeches over the classroom telescreen. It was not intended as a punishment but as part of their education. Sometimes they could go on for hours. Knowing where Hordak came from explained a lot.

Once during one of those interminable speeches, Adora fainted. They couldn't have been more than eight or nine. Catra panicked. They weren't allowed to do anything but stand at attention until Hordak was finished, but she'd never seen Adora just collapse like that, and Catra couldn't tell if she was breathing. Frantically, she looked around to see if anyone knew, wondering how much trouble she'd get into if she just dragged Adora out.

To her immense relief, their instructor paced to the end of their line. He gestured with his chin at Adora and then jerked his head sideways in a "bring her here" sort of gesture. Catra thought she understood. To make sure, Catra signed in the hand signals they were learning to use for combat or stealth missions. "Medic? Evac?" Then she pointed to herself and Adora, raising her eyebrows to exaggerate a questioning face.

He smiled broadly. It was a new subject unit, and they had only learned a few words in class, but Catra had been reading ahead. He nodded and signed back, "Medic. Go. Silent."

Catra answered the commander with a thumbs-up. Adora started to come around, so Catra hauled her from the floor and, as quietly as possible, helped her down the hall to the medic's office. They said it was dehydration and impressed on both girls how quickly it could become dangerous.

That evening, Shadow Weaver received a glowing report from the instructor for her quick thinking and use of her classroom knowledge. The medics who treated Adora had sent an equally complimentary report praising her cool-headedness. Catra could hear the smile in the woman's voice. "Good job, Catra. I'm very surprised. I wouldn't have imagined you could please your instructors so much. Perhaps Adora's influence is working." The

woman stroked the dark blonde hair under her ears, and Catra purred happily, leaning her cheek against the old witch's claw.

“Oh, little sister. Such a pitiful display. So hungry for affection. So alone.” Prime whispered as he witnessed Catra’s memory play out in her mind. “I can take that all away.”

“I thought you hated her?” Scorpia had asked about Shadow Weaver years later.

“You wouldn’t understand.” Catra could not explain, but she had lived for those moments of soft attention. Those moments when she believed that Shadow Weaver cared for her.

“Who could care for you, little sister?” Prime’s intrusive voice asked.

“I was hard on you.’ Shadow Weaver admitted once. “I wanted you to be strong.”

And Catra was strong. Strong enough that she held Prime in contempt even as he destroyed her by inches. Holding her as bait was not going to work. As much time as he spent fucking around in her head, he should know that Adora hated her guts. It did not matter how much he tortured Catra. Even Adora’s stupid ass was too smart to come here. He was a joke.

“Do not mock me!” Prime’s anger reduced her to a haze of agonizing sense memories, she could smell nothing but her own blood and burning hair. She could feel nothing but the Black Garnet’s fire running through her veins. Her screams echoed and rang in the enormous room. Over and over, Prime found the most horrible of her memories to show her.

After an eternity, his will left her, and she lay in an untidy heap at his feet. A clone held water to her lips, but she closed them and turned her head away even as the smell of the water was its own torture.

“It appears that her species is sensitive to dehydration, Lord Prime. The fever appears to be the result of an infection in her kidney.”

Good, thought Catra, barely conscious. Those were serious-- they could easily kill you.

Please, oh please, let me die.

A black riptide overtook her mind, pulling her under and out to sea.

“Catra!”

A loud voice startled Catra from a deep sleep. Taking in the dim confines of the room, she registered it was the cell where Glimmer had been held.

The green forcefield became translucent. “Catra! How does this open?” Adora demanded, her gaze darting around the corridor as she ran her hand around the rim of the door, looking for a hidden switch.

What the fuck was Adora doing here?

“It only works for the clones.” Catra sat up, running her hand through her short hair, realizing she was naked on the bare mattress. She licked her lips, surprised to find moisture in her mouth again.

The blonde nodded. “Okay. No problem.” The sword was in her hand, and she spoke the words. A flash of light and She Ra stood in the corridor, unbound hair and cloak flowing as if caught by a breeze (that had to be some magical bullshit- the air in Prime's ship didn’t move like that), swinging her sword back and connecting with the forcefield. With a crash, it shattered.

“What have they done?” Dropping the transformation, Adora’s gray-blue eyes shimmered with tears as she brushed back Catra’s short hair. “Are you injured? Can you get up?”

“How..?” Catra took stock of herself. Her back no longer hurt, and her skin no longer radiated feverish heat. Prime’s medics must have treated her infection and dehydration, pulling her back from the edge. She thought for sure she was too far gone that time. “How did you get in here?” she whispered. “What happened?”

“It’s all right.” Smiling through her tears, Adora sat on the bed next to her. “He’s dead. I killed him. We’re going home now.” She leaned forward. “I’m so glad you’re all right.” The blonde woman put her arm around Catra’s smaller form and pulled her into her lap, their lips meeting in a hungry kiss. The other hand drifted down to the magicat’s bare hip.

Adora pulled back so she could see Catra’s face. “Lie back, beloved,” she said, pushing on Catra’s shoulder, encouraging her to scoot up on the bed so she could straddle her hips. “Close your eyes. Let me show you what I’ve learned in our time apart.” She leaned down, their lips meeting in a bruising kiss.

For a moment, it seemed strange that Adora would want to do this right here and now, but if Prime was dead… if Adora had killed him…

“You are so beautiful,” Adora said when their lips parted, her voice thick with lust. “I want you so much."

Catra froze. This was not Adora.

Hissing, Catra tried to pull away, but the other woman grabbed both wrists in a crushing grip, a smug, cruel grin on her face.

Furious that she had fallen for Prime’s lies again, Catra hawked up as nasty a loogie as she could and spat it into the fake Adora’s face.

Get it over with!

With the speed of a striking snake, Prime let go of her wrist and encircled her neck with one hand. “Little sister…” he snarled as he wiped the spit and phlegm from his cheek.

“Ha.” Catra forced a rough little sound like a chuckle around the restriction. “Still no She Ra, huh?” Hope sparked in her heart. Maybe she only needed to push a little further. Her lips contorted sideways into a smirking grimace. "Loser."

She won’t come for me. Catra kept repeating it in her thoughts, a mantra she hoped Prime heard. *She won’t, no matter what you do to me.*

That hand tightened, and her vision began to gray out. The black tide rose up again. She welcomed it.

Finish it!

Then the hand fell away. Sparks exploded behind her eyelids before she blinked them open, and the world resolved into white and green. A soft smile curved Prime’s lips, and Catra’s stomach dropped.

No. Please.

Let me go.

Please.

“Oh, little sister,” Prime murmured. “You are so very resilient. More than I would have credited. There is another way you can be of use.”

A whimper emerged from her throat.

With the sobs came a torrent of memories that cascaded over Catra. All the imagined rescues and reunions. All the fantasies. All the nightmares.

"She was afraid at the end. And she suffered," Prime had told Adora with Catra's mouth.

Afraid? Fuck, yes, she had been afraid. She had been a creature mad with terror by the end, begging for death. And everyone who was chipped would know how she wept and pleaded. How Prime took her apart, piece by cringing piece.

Adora's hand brushed through Catra's sweaty hair. "Okay," she kept muttering, "We're here. You're safe. It's okay."

Beside her, Glimmer and Bow made gentle sounds of agreement.

At last, the tears stopped, but she felt no real relief. Glimmer's arms and Bow's hand on her back withdrew. Adora started to pull back, but Catra hung on, shaking her head. Mortified, Catra couldn't bring herself to look at any of them. What was happening to her? Since that wound in her neck got infected, and she got so sick, she had had daily breakdowns. Even before that, she knew she had to be coming off as weird and needy. How were they even putting up with her? They did not have to.

Familiar vertigo overcame her. If she looked up, would she see Adora's face twisted with Prime's evil grin? She knew she should look. She should reassure herself that this was real, but she couldn't. When Adora tried to let go, she tightened her hold.

Cradling her wife in her arms, Adora glanced up when the other two pulled away. Experimentally, she tried to pull back herself, but Catra shook her head and tightened her hold. Melog nudged her hip and mewed.

Bow picked up one of the cold drinks that sat on a tray. "Catra?" he said to the unnaturally still woman who buried her face in Adora's shoulder. "You should drink something. Glimmer's gone to get you something to eat."

She nodded into Adora's neck, but the tension in her back and shoulders showed her reluctance to leave her protective huddle. Slowly unfurling her stiff limbs, the smaller woman shifted so that she sat beside Adora instead of on her lap but kept their sides pressed tight, seemingly unwilling to not be in contact. Reaching out her shaking hand to take the cold drink, she grunted her thanks.

Melog became big enough to wrap around both women so that Adora could have some back support and keep an arm around Catra.

Using both hands to hold the cup, Catra drank the whole thing in one long uninterrupted gulp, then wiped her mouth with the back of her hand while she handed the cup back with the other. She licked the errant drops from her hand. Then, in a move Adora had not seen in years, Catra used the damp appendage to groom her ear as she purred softly.

Adora glared at Bow warningly. The delicate gesture was extremely cute. Though the corner of his mouth quirked up, Bow nodded and tactfully turned his back as he searched through Glimmer's bag.

She did it again, smoothing the fur over her ear. The third time Catra repeated the gesture, this time washing her face, she seemed to realize what she was doing. She froze, her cheeks flaring red, her purr stuttering out. Slowly, she dropped her hand and curled into a tight ball with her chin on her knees, focusing her gaze into the middle distance.

Little wind chimes announced Glimmer's return. "Catra? I brought you some crackers."

The magicat shook her head once, still not looking at anyone. Melog's mane was red and jagged. They nudged at Catra again. Alarmingly, she ignored even Melog.

“Do you want to head back to our room?” Adora asked her, feeling at a loss. It used to be that she knew Catra as well as she knew herself, but this was a Catra she did not recognize.

“Yeah, okay.” Catra nodded. She cleared her throat. “I-I’ll meet you back there.”

Adora felt the bunching of muscles where the sides of their bodies met. Shifting forward, Catra reached to put one hand on the sand in front of her, moving to a crouch. "Wait!" Adora shot her hand out to grab Catra’s wrist before her distraught wife could run or disappear. "I'll go with you."

For an instant, all the magicat’s fur stood on end, and she stared in surprise at where Adora’s fingers wrapped around her wrist as if she actually thought they would let her go off alone in this state. A full-body shudder swept over her before she seemed to steel herself. Her ears remained pinned to her head as she finally met Adora’s gaze, hardly even blinking, as if searching for something.

The scrutiny was so intense that Adora felt her cheeks heating. “W-what?” she stammered.

Catra’s ears came forward, and something in her face relaxed. "Nothing. It’s nothing.”

Halfway back to their room, Catra stumbled against the wall so she would not collapse. Or rather so she could make a slow, controlled descent to the floor because her legs became too weak to hold her. “I just need a second,” she tried to say, but she wasn’t sure the words were recognizable. This was what Muriel had been warning her about when she talked about avoiding overexertion. Apparently emotional meltdowns counted as overexertion.

“Catra!” In a move that was becoming exceedingly well practiced, She Ra suddenly held Catra in her arms. Tomorrow Catra would

worry about her recent weakness; right now, she clung to her wife, soaking in the still-novel sensation of safety.

When they reached their door, She Ra growled as she fumbled with the doorknob with one hand. Running out of patience, she lifted one foot to kick it in. Before she could complete the motion, Melog mewed softly, and the door clicked open without property damage.

“Granddaughter.” Melog nosed at Catra’s shoulder. “You should speak to your mate. She fears for you.” They shook their mane out and slow-blinked at her. “I will return soon,” they said before leaving the room, casually kicking the door closed behind them.

The blonde woman’s eyes followed Melog out, then sought Catra’s again. “What’s going on? Where are they going?”

Bereft of Melog’s support, Catra sniffed. “They just… they think we should talk about this. And they figure we don’t need an audience.” She huffed a wet little laugh, realizing she knew where Melog was going.”Plus, they want to go hang out in the hot springs for a bit longer.”

“Okay." Adora bent to place Catra on their couch. Her form shimmered, and piercing blue eyes became soft gray. “Do you want to talk about it?”

“No.” Catra closed her eyes. Her throat felt tight like Prime still had his hand wrapped around it. She coughed to clear it. “But, I guess we should.”

“What do you need from me?” Adora asked softly, taking Catra’s hand. “What can I do to help?”

The question startled Catra out of her spiral, and her eyes popped open. She wasn’t sure why it felt so surprising that Adora would ask her that. Maybe it was because it was not a question anyone generally asked her.

“I… don’t know,” she whispered. “I don’t think anyone can help.”

For a fraction of a second, Adora's eyes widened in alarm, then her mouth firmed with determination. "Do you want to stay here or get into bed? You're supposed to be resting." Falling back on practicalities probably because Catra had turned into such a huge bundle of freaking out.

"I'll get in bed." Catra wiped her swollen eyes with one hand. "I haven't done shit today except lie around, and I'm still so fucking tired." She sighed. "I'm going to go take a shower first." The blood smell was overwhelming again.

"Okay." Adora stood. "Do you want me to start the water, so it's nice and hot?" At Catra's nod, she stood up.

"Wait." This time it was Catra who reached out. "I… " The blonde turned to look at her expectantly. No words came. "Never mind," the magicat finally muttered, letting go of her wife's hand and hugging herself. "We'll talk when I'm not quite so gross." She stood up too. "I'll grab some clean clothes."

Adora nodded and stood, crossing the suite to flip the lock on the door, then heading to the bathroom.

Opening the dresser drawer, Catra stared at the neatly folded stack of new clothes. Aunt Casta had the staff bring them to her this morning, leaving them for her before she even woke up. She shook her head, wondering what she did to make the woman like her-- maybe it was nothing more than their shared dark humor and dislike of Shadow Weaver.

"Hey, Catra? Do you need any help?" Adora stuck her head out of the bathroom, and steam issued through the open door. "The water's hot."

"No. I'll be right there."

Muriel had told them yesterday that Catra needed someone to hang out with her while she showered for the next few days in case she fainted. Normally Catra would have vetoed the very idea that she needed a babysitter, but the truth was that being on her

feet for any amount of time made her decidedly light-headed. Not to mention, she'd gotten lightheaded in the fucking hallway.

It felt weirdly awkward. Weird because being naked never embarrassed her, but bleeding from her crotch definitely did. The midwife said it would slow down in the next few days and would be gone in a couple of weeks. Then Catra needed her hormone implant replaced, or she would be doing this once a month for-fucking-ever.

Tactfully, Adora sat on the counter by the sink and pretended to be engrossed in reading what was probably a report from Glimmer's meetings while Catra shed her clothes and tossed the soiled ones in the hamper.

The hot water felt good on her fur, and she rested her head against the tile. The Fright Zone's showers were never more than tepid. Catra discovered, since leaving the Fright Zone, that she only objected to cold water; hot water was another thing entirely. Once she stopped bleeding, she thought she would probably like these hot springs Melog was so taken with. Even so, she didn't linger, too tired and upset to want to do anything but drag herself into bed (and preferably never come out again).

As Catra crawled into bed, there was a knock at the door. Pulling the blanket over her head, she growled.

"I'll go see who it is." The bed bounced as Adora jumped up, and Catra stayed in a tight ball, trying to disappear into the bed.

"How is Catra feeling?" It was Aunt Casta. She was never chipped, so she only knew what Catra told her. Unless Micah spoke with her about it? That thought made Catra want to throw up all over again.

"She's still feeling sort of rough," Adora replied. "She had… Well, I'm not quite sure what happened." She dropped her voice, although she had to know that Catra could still hear her. "I think Bow called it a panic attack?"

“Glimmer told me,” The sorceress replied quietly, her tone reassuringly serene. “That’s normal after all the stress she’s been under.”

Normal? Maybe if Catra were freaking out over something normal.

“If you or she needs anything, please don’t be afraid to come and find me. I left word with the staff to bring you some dinner in a bit. Is that all right?”

“Yes, that would be great. Thank you. For everything you’ve done for us.”

“You’re welcome.”

The door closed. The bed dipped as Adora sat back down. She pulled the covers back until Catra scowled up at her, hissing at the light.

“It’s only me," Adora said softly. “How are you feeling?”

“I feel like you need to stop asking that question. The answer hasn’t changed in the last twenty minutes.” She didn’t mean for her reply to emerge so harshly, but she was tired of everyone talking to her like she was a wounded kitten.

The blonde sighed. “Listen,” she said. Adora’s voice held an edge of trepidation, but her jaw hardened as she plowed on with typical Adora obstinance. “Muriel gave me some stuff yesterday to read about… Well, about what you… um… What you went through. It talks about how you might be reacting. To what happened,” she rambled. “It says that it’s totally normal to feel… conflicted.”

“Conflicted?” Catra repeated blankly.

“Yeah." Adora reached out and put her hand on Catra’s shoulder. “It seems natural that you’d be sad about it.”

“Sad..?” Catra was feeling many things right now. Sad? Maybe that was part of the hot mess of feelings in her chest.

"So ensnared in rage and grief and pain…." Prime's voice echoed in her head. She clenched her fists to keep from tearing at her hair.

Adora stroked her shoulder, her touch soft and tentative. "It's really okay if you… you know… feel like you need to grieve?"

That phrase had to have come from whatever pamphlet Muriel gave her. No way did Adora come up with it by herself. Catra stared at her trying to parse her meaning. Then it clicked.

"You think I'm upset because Muriel got Prime's Parasite Thing out of me?" Catra sat up, knocking Adora's hand off her shoulder. "How could you even think that?" Heat flooded her limbs, blurred her vision. She jumped up to stand on the bed. "Don't even fucking suggest that I wanted that… that… that thing inside me! That's the best fucking thing that could have happened!"

"Okay, okay!" The blonde held her hands up in surrender, making little calm-down motions. "Catra, it's okay!"

"No! It is not okay! I cannot believe you'd think that!" Adrenaline coursed through her, her claws came out, and her hackles went up.

Adora stood up on the bed, too, her cheeks flushed. "What am I supposed to think?" Her fists were clenched, and her eyes beamed bright blue, although she did not transform. "You won't talk to me! You didn't even tell me what was going on yesterday!" Tears spilled down her cheeks, and she took a great gasping breath.

"I'm just guessing here!" she shouted, putting one hand flat on her chest. "You can't keep stonewalling me like this. I-I want us to be together, but how can we if you keep shutting me out?" Her hand went up to her forehead, and she squinched her eyes as if yelling hurt. In a much quieter voice, she continued. "Why can't you see I'm trying my best?" The last word came out almost as a sob.

Just like that, all of Catra's anger snuffed out, leaving her feeling lost and cold. She sank back down to the bed, hugging herself. Why was she like this? Why did she have to lash out at everybody all the time?

Adora sat down, moving slowly, her eyes still scrunched up against the light.

"I know… I'm… sorry," Catra choked out. "It's just… I just…"

"Just what? Whatever it is, it can't be that bad after all we've been through."

A nervous chuckle emerged from Catra's throat. "It's pretty bad."

Spinnerella's words came back to her. "*I know what Prime did to you.*"

A new thought occurred to her. Did Prime share everything? He could have shared every sordid detail of Catra's life. Secrets she'd buried so deep even she forgot them. "It's... I just realized. Everyone knows"

"Knows what?" Adora said blankly, clearly not understanding.

"Everyone who was chipped," Catra amended. "They know everything. Everything about Prime. Everything about me." She hesitated. "And probably they know everything I know about you."

Fear and Hope

Chapter Summary

A chat with a friend.

Catra had not left their room in two days. Nothing Adora or Melog said made any impression. She curled up on the window seat and looked out over Mystacor’s grounds, not speaking to either of them.

Finally, Melog seemed to have had enough of the silent treatment. They sat by the window seat, refusing to leave, even when Catra pointedly turned her back. They meowed, and she turned to them, her eyes narrow and angry.

“You would not,” she scoffed, her tone hard. It sounded so like Catra during the war that Adora flinched.

Melog growled deep in their throat and grew larger than Adora had seen them before. Moving too fast for Adora to follow, the creature lunged, grabbed Catra’s scruff in their jaw, and gave it a firm tug, pulling her off the window seat.

"Hey! Quit!" Catra half shrieked, outraged, as she landed on her butt. Alarmed, Adora stood up, unsure what to do.

Melog’s growls and chirps sounded exasperated as they leaned over her. Catra went limp, all her sharp edges softened, and she leaned her head on the great cat’s flank. "I don't know,” she told them, sounding tearful.

Another set of chirps and trills, only these sounded coaxing and encouraging.

“Yeah. Okay. Fine," she said, her voice soft and unsteady. “Go ahead, then. You pick someone.” She returned to the window seat, turning her back. Melog whisked around and vanished. The

magicat balled herself up and steadfastly stared out of the window.

"Catra?" Adora began.

"I don't want to talk about it," Catra's voice was flat, and she did not turn around.

Netossa liked to linger in bed when she had the chance and was used to Spinnerella slipping out of bed to write for an hour in the garden. This morning Spinnerella had not even sat down with her notebook and coffee when a giant translucent cat materialized on the bench.

Sitting straight with supreme feline dignity, they stared at her and meowed a greeting.

"Melog, right?" Spinnerella said awkwardly. The cat gave her an unmistakable nod. She knew from having interacted with them during the treaty negotiations that they were fully sentient and somehow bound to Catral. Something about this creature always felt absolutely trustworthy, and it was clear that Adora, Glimmer, and Bow shared the sentiment.

"Is-is there something you need?" The catlike creature blinked slowly and stood up to cross over to her, then their mouth gently closed around her arm and tugged.

"You… want me to come with you?" The startled Princess could only think of one reason Catra's alien guardian spirit would seek her out. "This will take a while, I imagine?" She had heard that Catra had been ill and staying in Mystacor; Scorpia said at their last meeting that the aftereffects of the chip were giving the magicat trouble. "Let me leave a note."

A knock at the door made Catra's ears pin back. Adora took a deep breath and blew it out, collecting herself. The door opened.

“Oh. Oh, hi. What can I do for you, Spinnerella?” Adora said, sounding surprised.

Catra turned to see the Princess, and then she went back to staring out of the window without speaking, her stomach in knots. Yes, she had told Melog that she was ready, but she had been lying, obviously.

“Um… Adora?” Spinnerella said, sounding nervous. “I’m so sorry to bother you so early. Melog seemed to think I should come with them.“

“Oh, yeah. Why don’t you come in?” Adora said, sounding pleased. “Would you like some tea?”

“That would be lovely.”

The door shut, and Catra heard Spinnerella settle on the couch and Adora moving around, making tea, probably. Catra could not bring herself to turn around to look.

“Granddaughter?” Melog came to stand beside Catra. “This Gentle One has tried to speak to you of this before.”

Catra hugged herself. “I changed my mind. I don’t want to,” she muttered. She was being unreasonable, but she had spent years being unreasonable. She was very good at it.

Melog went very still and fixed her with an unreadable gaze. Catra looked away. “Child,” they said finally. “Your heart speaks differently.” They sounded concerned, and indeed, something in her chest twisted as she struggled with competing desires. Catra desperately wanted to talk to someone who was chipped, but she also wanted to flee to the furthest outpost of space and find a hole to hide in until her name was forgotten.

“Granddaughter. You have always chosen courage." Melog’s voice was soft, and they nuzzled her shoulder.

That was ridiculous; Catra always chose *survival*. However, Melog's strange standards were once again deeply comforting and she pressed her head against their flank, feeling dizzy and sick. This was the opposite of courage. Her cramps were so much better that she couldn't blame her nausea on them. No, it was just her fear that made it feel like the air had been sucked out of the room. Just her humiliation that made her feel like she wanted to disappear and never be found. Just her utter mortification that made her want to throw up.

Behind her, Adora exchanged nervous small talk with the Princess, but Catra could feel Spinnerella's eyes on her.

Unfurling herself to stand, Catra slunk over to the tea nook (Why every bedroom in both Mystacor and Bright Moon needed a tea nook Catra had yet to figure out. At least this one didn't have a waterfall) where Adora was putting on the hot water and Melog went to go entertain Spinnerella. "Hey…" Catra began, but her nerves were so tightly strung that nothing came out. She cleared her throat and tried again. "Hey, Adora? Would you mind letting me talk with Spinnerella alone?"

"Yes. of course. No problem." Adora nodded, her smile relieved. "I can just go out for my run early. I'll probably be a while." She offered Catra her hand. "It'll be okay," she whispered. "Spinnerella is really nice."

Perhaps it would be easier if Spinnerella was not so nice. This conversation might go better with the Princess's blunt-speaking wife; it would get the awfulness out of the way quickly. It would merely trade the horrible what-if with the equally horrible what-is, but at least Catra would know what she was dealing with. She squeezed Adora's hand back. "Thanks," she muttered.

"Spinnerella?" Adora said to the Princess, who scratched Melog's ears and cooed at the resulting purrs. "Tea will be ready in a minute, but Catra wanted to…. "

"I wanted to talk with you alone… If that's okay," Catra said, coming up behind Adora. "Um… that's what Melog was trying to ask."

"I thought that's probably what they wanted," Spinnerella replied serenely.

Just to give herself something to do or possibly just to indulge in a few seconds more of procrastination, Catra turned on her heel and went back to the nook to make tea.

Adora's hand landed on her shoulder, and Catra paused to look into her worried grey eyes. The other woman leaned forward to press their foreheads together. "Remember, I love you."

Catra nodded and pressed forward to brush Adora's lips with hers.

"Send Melog for me when you want me to come back," Adora whispered softly, and then she pulled back to stroke Catra's cheek and gave her a smile.

The kettle whistled, and Catra turned away to make the tea, pretending her hands weren't shaking. She heard Adora say a soft goodbye to Spinnerella and the door shut.

Now, Catra was out of excuses. She held out the cup to Spinnerella and then sat down on the couch, turned toward the other woman, not knowing how to start.

"Thank you." Spinnerella accepted the cup with one hand while she kept scratching Melog's ear. "How are you doing?"

"Me..?" Catra's stomach twisted. "I… um… Not… not so good." She couldn't stand to look at the other woman, choosing instead to look at Melog, whose head rested in the Princess's lap. "I've been sick. Sort of…" She closed her eyes. "The chip… it…" Her throat seized up, and she could not force a single word out of her mouth. Why did she think she was ready to do this? More importantly, how was Catra going to get rid of the Princess with

the least amount of aggravation? Both Melog and Adora would throw fits, but there was no way she…

"Catra?" Two warm hands gently freed the claws of one hand from the padded arm of the couch and held it. Catra's eyes popped open to see Spinnerella kneeling in front of her. "Catra. It's all right. Just breathe." Spinnerella's eyes were wide and concerned. "Look at me. You're safe." Melog came over to lean against her other side.

"I…" Sparks danced in her field of vision, and she tugged her hand back.

"It's okay," Spinnerella said, letting go. "You were starting to hyperventilate."

"I can't do this," Catra hissed, unsure if she was talking to Melog, the Princess, or herself.

"It's okay, Catra." The Princess held her hands up, palms out as if to show she did not have a weapon. Not that it mattered much. "I'll sit over here. All right? Take your time." She drew out of touching distance, settling back onto the couch.

Melog plopped their heavy head onto Catra's lap, grounding her with their weight. She sucked in a ragged breath and began again. "So, that night at Spire. You… you said… "

Something that looked like approval lit Spinnerella's eyes. "I'm happy to talk about however much or little you want."

"Um. Okay." Miserably Catra looked at the floor, grateful that the other woman was quick on the uptake. "I-I need to ask, does… does *everyone* know? About what happened to me? Everyone who was chipped, I mean?"

The long silence after the question was all the answer Catra needed, and she covered her face with her hands, unable to face the other woman.

“We… we all know what you did for us,” Spinnerella whispered after a minute.

The confirmation felt infinitely worse than the speculation--Catra fisted her hands against her eyes so she would not bury them in her scalp to pull out her hair and tried to breathe.

“Prime never showed us your face; he made us *feel* what happened.”

That was no consolation. On Melog’s advice, Catra had *told* people she was the first Etherian chipped. When Melog was wrong, they were disastrously, horrifyingly wrong.

“We lived your captivity over and over. You were… “ The Princess paused as she seemed to search for a word.

Catra braced herself, feeling exposed and terrified. Melog probably chose Spinnerella because she was “gentle” (Melog never seemed to use people’s names- just a descriptor and a picture of them in Catra’s head). The woman would try to soften the blow, and she certainly would not be able to come up with anything as bad as what Shadow Weaver called her.

Useless.

Coward.

Disappointing.

Weak.

“Magnificent,” Spinnerella finished.

“What?” Involuntarily, Catra lifted her head. “I-I don’t understand.”

A tiny malicious smile graced Spinnerella’s face. “Making us share your ordeal didn’t work the way he wanted it to. You were so scared, but you had so much contempt for him. Even after he…

broke you… He could hurt you. He could kill you. He could make you fear him, but you did not respect him. He couldn't bear it."

"I was *trying* to get him to kill me," Catra admitted through gritted teeth. "When he let me think, I thought about what a loser he was only because it seemed to piss him off most."

The other woman's voice dropped as though she had divulged a secret. "It ate at him. He wanted to catch Adora because she was the symbol of the Rebellion, but he wanted you worse than he ever wanted her."

Spinnerella leaned forward to catch Catra's gaze. "Your escape started a spiral. When Prime started losing battles, all he could think of was that "little sister" and Adora were somewhere, laughing at him. He could not get the sound of your laughter out of his mind. Instead of just bombing Etheria from orbit, he decided to come here himself. If he had stayed away, or if he had not decided that he needed to have the Heart, we could never have won."

Spinnerella brushed some errant hair behind her ear; eyes narrowed in thought. "Some of us," she said slowly, "started being able to block Prime out. I'm not sure how it worked, but it seemed like if we thought of the laughter, Prime just… blanked us out. Just for a few seconds, but we could remember ourselves when it happened." She smiled ruefully. "I don't think I could have recognized Netossa if that disruption had not happened."

Catra remembered the moment. It was in Erelandia when Netossa was excitedly telling Adora that her wife had recognized her for a second. And then she remembered Perfuma's conviction. " *Scorpia missed on purpose* !"

The woman shook her head. "And the way I remember things from the hive mind… it's weird and fuzzy. A lot of the memories that aren't mine seem to be fading. You know? We only have bits and pieces of it."

Catra nodded dubiously. She put her feet on the floor and her elbows on her knees. "But… everyone knows that Prime ra-..."

Spinnerella cut her off before the sentence finished. "Everyone knows what we owe you."

This was almost the same conversation they'd had at Spire, and Catra felt they were no closer to the point. "Please, don't do that. Don't hide it," she said quietly. "I need you to be straight with me. I need to know what you know."

Spinnerella closed her eyes. "All right." She opened her eyes again. "When I was chipped, it didn't happen quickly because Prime was still trying to be stealthy. Trying to catch as many magic users as possible. Someone stuck the chip on, and it grew into my spine over the course of days. I started to have the strangest dreams. And then… the Light came for me." The woman shivered with a sudden chill.

"Yeah." The Light. The pain. Her thoughts whiting out. The dissolution of everything that made her real. The terrifying numbness. The mind games and the fantasies. Catra's hands shook, and she buried them in Melog's mane.

"He showed me your memories, but he led me to think it was Glimmer because…."

"Because it wouldn't matter if it were me."

The Princess bit her lip, but then she nodded uncertainly. "I think he assumed that it would lose its impact if it were happening to an enemy. I know that Micah was convinced it was Glimmer right up until your trial. And that's what Mermista thought. And it was some of the reason… Well, we never thought… Prime hid that from us too. Even when Glimmer said you saved her on Prime's ship, she never told us you were chipped. And we never asked. We sort of had this idea that you had gotten out of it completely unscathed." Spinnerella looked away. "As soon as we heard you

laugh at us at your trial, we all knew you." Her gaze returned to Catra's eyes. "Scorpia… She said she always knew."

That explained Scorpia's ready forgiveness, at least.

"We know..." Spinnerella's rounded jaw hardened as she leaned forward to whisper. "We know he raped you."

Catra could not keep the questions back, and she took a deep breath to steady herself. "D-did you know he made me… p-p-pregnant?" She stumbled over the word she had never said aloud before.

Spinnerella brought her hands up to cover her mouth as the color drained from her face. "No," she breathed. "Oh. No. I am so, so sorry."

No. They did not know that part. Something in Catra relaxed until she realized what she had just revealed to Spinnerella.

"What are you going to do?" the Princess asked.

Catra rubbed the back of her neck. "I, um, it's done. I took care of it," she muttered, wondering how the older woman would take that. To ensure she wouldn't be misunderstood, Catra said, "I, um, terminated it. I… wondered if… "

The Princess's face was sympathetic and relieved. "I don't think anyone knows that Prime got you pregnant," she said softly, reaching out as if to pat Catra's hand but pulling back uncertainly. "And, even if some of us do remember, we would not try to hurt you with it."

"We?" Catra asked, tilting her head. "What, the Princesses?"

"No. I mean, any of us who were chipped." Spinnerella spoke as though this were a self-evident fact. "Half the planet has been in your head, Catra. Even if we are beginning to forget the specifics, we all remember how you gave us hope."

Valentine's Day

Chapter Summary

Catra has a conversation.

Adora has a surprise.
And then Adora has Catra.

Chapter Notes

Although Etheria would not have a St. Valentine, any other name for the darn holiday sounded far too contrived. So for ease of reading, I just went with it.

This chapter has an explicit sex scene, but it is a nice happy fluffy one although it has some mentions of rape recovery. If you want to skip it, you can stop reading when you get to the line break, and the story will end there.

I haven't written smut before, but consider it a Valentine present for all ya'll.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Invisible, Catra watched from across the hallway as people trickled into the room. Melog leaned against her leg, lending her their strength.

A few people Catra did not know already sat around a table laden with a spread of snacks. Spinnerella had told her that these meetings of the formerly chipped to talk about it among people who would understand. She assured Catra that everyone would be lowkey and non-judgemental. When Catra asked Castaspella what she knew about them, the sorceress said Micah had a conference room in the healer’s section of the palace set up every evening for those who might want to participate. This was the third meeting she had attempted. The first one, she had not even gotten inside the door. The second one she had observed from the safety of

Melog's concealment. The conversation had not been terrifying or anything, but Catra was not sure she was ready to make herself vulnerable like that.

After the meeting, Melog observed that no one unwilling was made to speak, and no one who spoke was mocked.

Catra had faced down Shadow Weaver, led armies against living weapons of mass destruction (aka Princesses), and defied Horde Prime, yet this small group had her shaking in her (non-existent)shoes. She nearly told Melog that they would try again next week, but then Muriel walked past them.

It was the midwife's tense shoulders and her scent thick with anxiety that finally made Catra nod, agreeing to allow Melog to drop the concealment. She felt better knowing that the no-nonsense ex-officer might find these meetings useful.

"I will meet you at home, Granddaughter," the blue-maned creature told her.

"Yeah. Okay," she muttered before squaring her shoulders and walking in. Every eye turned to her."Um. Hey," she said, not turning to run for the door only by force of will.

"Welcome, Ambassador," Micah said. His smile looked genuine, which steadied Catra's nerves. After an agonizing beat, the others at the table also smiled and made sounds of greeting. Muriel scooted her seat over so there was a space between her and Micah. The magicat crossed the room, clenching her fists to hide her shaking hands. Once she sat, everyone turned their attention from her to Micah. Catra was so nervous that she missed most of what he said.

After that, the meeting proceeded like the one she had observed; people at the table took turns talking, and they spoke of experiences not dissimilar to hers, at least the experience they had since being freed. No one seemed to want to talk about what they experienced while connected to the hive mind. They talked

about their too-vivid dreams and their waking nightmares. They shared strategies they used to reassure themselves that what they perceived was real and how to deal with the silence in their heads.

Eventually, the conversation wound down. Micah made a few closing remarks and adjourned the meeting.

"Good to see you here," Muriel said to Catra as people began to stand and move out of the room.

"Yeah. I… wasn't sure what to expect." Catra had not spoken during the meeting; her chest had been so tight that she doubted she could force her voice to obey, but again, she was not alone. A few others had passed when it came around to them. It might be a while before Catra would be able to speak in that group, and that seemed all right. Tonight, it seemed enough that she sat in a room full of the formerly chipped to be reassured that none of them looked at her with the kind of contempt she feared. In fact, no one had treated her differently from anyone else at all.

Muriel smiled. "I hope you come back again." She headed down the corridor in the direction of her office.

"Catra? Can I walk with you?" Micah asked politely after Muriel left. "I'm headed in the same direction."

"Uh. I guess?" Catra said, wrapping her arms around herself. She had known that Micah was currently living at Mystacor, but this was the first time she had been in the same room with him.

"My sister and daughter speak highly of you," Micah told Catra as they walked. "I am sorry our first meeting was under less-than-ideal circumstances."

"You mean at my trial?" Catra said dryly.

"Yes." Micah cleared his throat. "I wanted to apologize for that," he said. "And," he said more quietly, "to give you my thanks for saving my daughter."

Catra shrugged, uncomfortable. “You’re welcome.”

They walked a little way in silence. He seemed to be building up to something, and she wished he’d spit it out. She dug her nails into her palm, nervously waiting for him to bring up the portal and the fact that Catra, directly or indirectly, caused the loss of his wife.

“You and Adora, you were both raised by Shadow Weaver?” Micah finally asked.

That was not the direction she thought the conversation would take. “Yeah. Why?”

“I don’t know if you know this,” Micah said, “but Shadow Weaver raised me until I was almost fourteen.

“Castaspella had told me that Shadow Weaver had taught you two, but she didn’t give me any details,” Catra replied. “How did that work, anyway?”

“Our parents sent my sister and I to learn sorcery here when I was six. When you are sent to Mystacor as a child, they assign you a mentor who is like your parent while you are here. They called her Light Spinner at the time. She was my mentor. She was considered the best at the time. In a few years, she probably would have been offered the position of the head sorceress.”

“Huh.”

Although his demeanor did not change, new adrenaline threaded through Micah’s scent. Shadow Weaver was not a comfortable subject for him either.

“You okay?” asked Catra, glancing at him.

“Yeah.” He rubbed the back of his neck with one hand as he took a few long breaths. “It was so strange to find her in Bright Moon.”

Catra nodded, but she really wanted him to get to the point. "Yeah, well. Imagine my surprise when I found out where she went."

The corner of Micah's mouth curled up in a grim little smile. "You sound like her sometimes."

"You remind me of myself. You always have."

Shadow Weaver's words rolled through Catra's mind, and it was like taking a physical blow. Her claws slid out, and she stopped to face Micah. "I am *nothing* like her," she hissed as she shook with anger and her vision tunneled.

Out of the aether, a great translucent cat appeared in the hallway, their mane almost black, spiked with fury. "Has the Sorcerer harmed you, Granddaughter?" they demanded in a growl so deep Catra felt it in her feet. "I will rip out his throat if he has," they promised her.

Micah backed away and drew a sigil in the air, ready to throw it at Catra's guardian.

"Melog, don't!" Catra snapped, suddenly afraid. She had absolutely no doubt that Melog would do exactly what they said they would. "I'm okay." She ran her hand through her hair. "I just… I just got freaked out for a minute."

Melog turned their head to look at her, their eyes narrow. "I will not allow you to be harmed if I can prevent it," they proclaimed.

Slowly Micah lowered his hand. "I'm sorry," he told her quietly. "I didn't mean to upset you."

"It-it's okay," Catra repeated. She wanted out of this conversation, but some masochistic part of herself needed to hear what the man had to say about their former guardian. "Just get to your point." Melog nosed into her hand and leaned their flank against her leg.

"I understand if you don't want to talk about her, and I… I didn't like to say this in front of the others." He crossed his arms over his chest. "But Prime discovered that I had memories of Shadow Weaver too. He showed me what she did after she left here."

"Oh." Catra started walking again- she couldn't have this conversation if she had to look at him. "That kind of sucks." Whatever he was getting at, he needed to hurry. They were almost there, and Catra was not going to stand in the hallway talking to him all night.

The man sighed as he started walking too. "I… Listen… Light Spinner involved me with a dark spell, but there was worse the woman did. I blamed myself for years… " he broke off and ran his hand through his hair. "We never knew where Light Spinner came from. I suspect she was running from whatever crimes she had committed there…." He trailed off again, and Catra wanted to snarl in frustration. He cleared his throat and soldiered on. "You should know that Shadow Weaver had a history of… of child molestation even before she joined the Horde."

If Micah expected his words to get a big reaction, he was disappointed; Catra could not see why he was telling her this.

And then a mostly forgotten memory floated through her mind. It felt like part of the one Glimmer shook loose the other day.

It was already past lights out when Adora came back from Shadow Weaver's. She had gone straight to the showers. Hearing the shower restart for the fifth time, Catra got up to check on her. That much water wastage could get them all in trouble.

"Adora? What the fuck?" Catra called.

"I'm fine!" Adora choked and started to cry as the timer turned the water off. She turned the tap back on to get another five minutes. Her lips and fingernails were dusky. She had been running only the cold water, over and over.

"What happened?"

"N-nothing."

Catra shook her head- It almost felt like something she imagined, but Melog stared at her with their head tilted and their eyebrows drawn together.

Snippets of a different long-ago conversation floated through Catra's mind.

"Do you really think I'd let Shadow Weaver erase your memory?"

"I don't know. Maybe? Can you blame me?"

"Not really."

She had been angry at Adora for not having any faith in her but not nearly as angry as she should have been.

"Why are you telling me this?" Catra finally asked.

Micah stopped in the middle of the hallway and glanced up and down as if to make sure they were alone. "It's easier when you know people who have gone through similar things," he said softly with a significant look.

It took a second for his meaning to penetrate.

"I just wanted to let you know if you ever need to talk to anyone, I'm available, " he finished seriously. "Good night," he said before he continued on down the hallway.

A cold lump formed in her gut, and she felt like she wanted to crawl out of her skin. The offer felt like a trap. Catra would have liked to dismiss the idea out of hand, but Melog gave her another side-eye. She called out, "I'll keep that in mind," as she opened the door to her own room.

The next moment, all thoughts of Micah and Shadow Weaver went right out of Catra's head.

The room was unexpectedly dim. Wearing a white dress trimmed with gold, Adora stood at the table where they ate, lighting dark-colored candles that were part of an elaborate centerpiece. A white cloth covered the table, and plates of gold were laid out with platters of food. Instead of her usual ponytail, Adora's hair was down and kept back with a little gold circlet that was reminiscent of the tiara She Ra wore. Her head snapped up as they came in. Quickly, the blonde picked up a bunch of flowers from her chair and came a few steps forward to stand right in front of Catra and held it out.

“What’s this?” Catra asked, befuddled, looking down at the bouquet Adora held. The customs around eating were always weird here, but this was new.

“These are flowers,” Adora said, smiling, her scent carrying a hint of anxiety.

“Yes. Those are flowers,” Catra agreed slowly as she crossed her arms over her chest and cocked an eyebrow. “Aaand, what are they *for* ?”

“For you. ” Adora giggled and brought the bouquet up, so it half hid her face and took a big whiff of them. When she seemed to realize Catra had not moved or changed her stance, she said, “I mean, I got them for you. I wanted to do something special, and Bow said this is traditional. And um… here.” The woman shoved the bouquet towards Catra, her cheeks darkening. ”Happy Valentine's Day?”

“Uh, huh,” Catra said. “So, what is a valentine, and why does it have a day?” she asked patiently, staring down at the arrangement.

The flowers *were* pretty. Some of these were familiar to Catra--they were probably plants that had to have some magical purpose since Shadow Weaver grew them. Reaching out to touch the blossoms with one finger, Catra silently named the ones she recognized: daffodils, hyacinths, forget-me-nots, and daisies. She

never admitted it to anyone, but she *liked* flowers. Shadow Weaver's garden was the only place in the Fright Zone where flowers grew on purpose, and Catra liked to hide there sometimes, lying on the warm ground under the green leaves and looking up at the sky through the blooms and soaking in the sweet scents of green growing things.

"Oh, um. It… ah, it's a holiday they have." Adora shifted around on her feet, and her voice got quieter. "It's for people who are in love. There's a whole ritual and etiquette to it. You're supposed to get your partner presents and plan a special supper." Adora giggled again, her gray eyes dancing as she looked up at Catra from under her eyelashes. "I got you these because the flowers… um… the ones that look white really *are* white, and the others are blue and yellow. Like your eyes. And they're beautiful, so they reminded me of you."

It was impossible to speak around the lump of feelings in Catra's chest. It was not fair for Adora to give her presents, arrange for special dinners, or say things like *that* and then expect her to be normal.

The anxiety in Adora's scent grew stronger. Taking Catra's momentary speechlessness as a rejection, probably. She bit her lip, and this time when she laughed, it had an unpleasant self-deprecating edge, as though she wanted to backpedal away from the show of vulnerability. "I know it's silly, and you probably don't want a bunch of flowers, but you know how Glimmer is. When she says things, it seems like a good idea, but now I'm thinking about it, I'll just…."

The magicat lifted her eyes from the bloom she'd been touching and grabbed her wife's wrist before she could take the flowers back. Adora was biting her lip again, and Catra would not let her wife think for a *second* that the gesture was unwanted. "These are gorgeous," she said, her voice a husky growl. Gently, Catra took the flowers from Adora. "Thank you." Purring, she stood on her toes to brush their lips together.

“You-you like them?” Adora whispered, her face lighting up. “Really?” She brought her hand up to Catra’s cheek and then pulled back in confusion when she felt wetness there. “Catra? You okay?”

“Um. I…“ The magicat cleared her throat. “Just… I guess candles make my eyes water.”

Delicately, Adora used her thumb to wipe the moisture away. “Oh. Okay.” Her other hand wrapped around Catra’s waist. The shorter woman used to resent that Adora had a size advantage over her, but now all she could think of was how very safe she felt in Adora’s arms. The last few weeks had been so scary, and nothing felt better than this. She searched for a way to tell her.

“You could just say it,” Melog chirped helpfully.

Yeah, right, because talking about feelings was so easy. But for Adora, she would try. So Catra tucked an errant strand of hair behind Adora’s ear, enjoying the little gasp her wife gave when Catra dragged one claw over her jawline from ear to chin. “This is wonderful. Thank you.”

That was the right thing to say; Adora’s eyes glowed blue with She Ra’s magic, and her smile was radiant. Abashed by the intensity of Adora’s regard, Catra looked for a distraction.

“So, what are we eating?” Catra said as she wiped her eyes with the heel of her free hand and stepped away. The few inches felt like a great chasm for a minute, but Adora turned with her so she could keep her arm around Catra’s waist and led her to the table.

“Is this a feast for the gods of the Archer’s house?” Melog asked, looking the table over. The decorations and many of the foods were cut in the shape of the symbol Bow wore on his chest.

Catra’s mouth quirked up as she passed the question to Adora. “Is this a party for Arrow Boy’s house gods or something?”

Adora frowned, and Catra did not blame her. Gods were not things that were encouraged in the Horde. Jerking her head at the translucent cat beside her, Catra said, "Melog wants to know."

"No, it's just... I hadn't thought about it, but it might be. He said it was their family crest and Bow… well… is Bow. I mean, he and his dads enjoy a good love story better than anything." She grinned at Melog. "So, I guess? Maybe?"

Melog purred and shook their head, amused. "Granddaughter," they said, "I will leave you for now. Enjoy your night."

"Where are you going?" Catra asked them curiously.

"I think I will look for the Sorcerer. This is not a night for those who mourn to be alone." The door opened for them and closed as they left.

Adora fussed with the flowers, taking them back from Catra and putting them into a jar of water that was waiting for them. She took the covers from the serving dishes and started putting different things onto their plates.

The food looked like Entrapta ordered it. Everything on the table was either small to begin with, or cut up small. Strawberries and chunks of other fruit that Catra did not recognize were dipped in chocolate and arranged artfully on one platter. Meat and cheeses that were cut up into sizes for picking up with fingers rested on a wooden board with a loaf of bread. On another platter, gray fleshy things sat inside little convex rocks on a bed of crushed ice.

"I think you'll really like these!" Adora handed her some of the rocks on a small plate.

Sniffing carefully, Catra agreed. They smelled like the ocean, and she had yet to find something that came from the ocean she did not like.

A soaring sensation in Catra's chest wanted to bubble out of her as laughter, but she did not want Adora to misunderstand, so she sat on it, but she could not push down her grin or her purr.

Adora's cheeks darkened. "You're laughing at me," she accused as she took in the look on Catra's face.

"I'm not, I promise," Catra assured. "It's just that this is really nice." She ducked her head shyly. "I kind of really like flowers," she mumbled. "You didn't have to, and I don't have anything for you."

"It's okay. Not like you knew it was a thing." The soft smile on Adora's face made Catra look away.

"So, you said there was some kind of ritual to this?" asked Catra.

Adora picked up one of the little rocks with one hand and used a little spoon to put some sauce on the gray thing. "Well, none of it is really mandatory, but couples have special dinners like this, and then they… do things together."

"Things?" Catra raised an eyebrow as she examined the gelatinous blob on its rock. She saw then that it wasn't a rock but some kind of shell. People ate these in the coastal towns, but she only ever saw them eaten straight out of the water, not presented like this. "What kind of things?"

Adora's blush got darker, and she shrugged. "Oh. You know. Whatever." As if to deflect Catra's attention, she took her spoon, scooped more sauce onto her shellfish, then brought it to her mouth and sucked it out of its shell.

Likewise, Catra brought the oyster to her mouth and threw it back as Adora had. It had an odd squishy consistency. She was tempted to spit the thing out for a moment, but then she chewed on it, and a sweet-salty, pleasantly fishy flavor filled her mouth. Oh, yes, she definitely liked these. She chewed again and crunched something.

“Ow. Fuck!” she swore, fishing the thing out of her mouth and swallowing the soft meat. It was an off-white sphere the size of one of her teeth. “What’s this?” she asked, surprised. “Do they not check these things for rocks?”

“Oooh! It’s not a rock. It’s a pearl!” Adora reached out to examine it, and Catra handed it to her. “The oysters make them. In Salineas, people use them for jewelry. You should keep it and get someone to make it into a necklace.”

Adora put the pearl back into Catra’s open palm and smiled at her, but Catra felt shy and wound up. Adora had clearly put some effort into making the night special.

Excitement and trepidation coursed through Catra. Excitement because her hot wife was sitting across from her, giving her moon eyes and sucking another oyster down. Trepidation because although they had been together since Prime was defeated and they’d been Official for some weeks now, between one thing and another, they had not gotten to do more than some serious making out.

Carefully, she placed the pearl next to the flowers on the table. “I can’t believe you turn up your nose at a mouse, but you’ll eat these,” she groused, trying to calm herself down. She would not let Prime ruin this. She absolutely would not.

Adora began to roll her eyes. Then she stopped mid-roll. “Wait,” she said, in the voice of someone who had just had an epiphany. “Those times you left mice for me?”

Catra ducked her head, embarrassed and annoyed that Adora would bring up the mouse thing now. “Yeah?”

“You really did want me to eat those.” Adora sounded as though she had just solved a major mystery.

It was Catra”s turn to roll her eyes. “Uh, yeah.” She paused to focus on putting some of that sauce on her oyster and then went on quietly. “It always seemed like what Shadow Weaver gave us

wasn't enough for you." She hunched her shoulders. "Lots of people ate foraged game. I didn't know most people cooked it at the time. Rogelio and I just always seemed to be able to eat them as-is. They made Kyle sick as shit, though, so Lonnie was too scared to try them."

The blonde's eyes shimmered in the candlelight when Catra chanced a look at her. "I-I didn't know you *could* eat animals until I left the Horde." Another thing seemed to occur to Adora. "Is that why you and Rogelio always had extra rations to share?"

Catra nodded. "Three or four mice made a decent meal for me. Rogelio usually needed six or seven."

For a few minutes, they did not speak, but their eyes kept meeting as they slurped the gray flesh from the oysters, careful to make sure there weren't any more pearls.

"They sent up some wine," Adora said after her fourth or fifth oyster. "Do you want some?"

"Sure." Catra thought she could use some Crimson Waste courage, as Scorpia liked to call it. "But only if you promise not to drink so much you make yourself sick."

"Okay. I promise" Adora poured the sparkling liquid into each of their glasses with a little smile. Then blonde picked up another oyster, sucked the meat into her mouth with a schlorp, and unselfconsciously licked some of the sauce from her finger.

She caught Catra staring at her. "What?" Adora tilted her head quizzically as she licked her finger and thumb.

"Nothing." Catra's voice was a little high-pitched. She tried to think of a non-obscene way to explain what she was thinking and failed miserably.

Somehow, Adora picked up on what was happening in Catra's head. Her smile turned a trifle wicked; Picking up another oyster,

much more slowly than before, she licked the sweet flesh from its shell.

Oh. Oh, wow.

The act of watching Adora eat should not be putting filthy thoughts into Catra's head, but the way those lips pursed as if for a kiss when she inhaled the shellfish into her mouth made Catra's mouth water, but not for the food. That tongue could be doing other things than licking out an oyster shell. Those fingers…

That line of thought was interrupted when Adora picked up one of the bits of cheese and scooted closer to Catra. "Have you tried these?" she asked.

Catra shook her head. She liked cheese, but she had yet to try this kind.

"One of the rituals is that people feed each other." Adora held out the morsel at mouth level, and Catra chuckled because that really was silly. Silly could be fun, though. Deciding to play along, she carefully took the bite with her teeth and then closed her lips on Adora's fingers, sucking them into her mouth, just to be a brat. She was not expecting the jolt of heat that passed through her at the sensation of Adora's fingers against her lips.

It seemed something similar happened to Adora. She gasped as though surprised, and fresh pheromones spiked in the air.

Whatever covered a lot of ground, Catra realized.

Strains of dance music floated through the open windows. Apparently, a small group of musicians was playing in one of the gardens. An unaccustomed longing moved through Catra's heart. "Can you hear that?"

"Yes. I guess Valentine's dances are really popular."

Making up her mind, the wine went down Catra's throat in a few gulps, and she put her glass down. Before she could overthink,

she stood up, holding out her hand. “Dance with me?” she asked, a little breathlessly.

“Did you want to go downstairs? We can if you want.” Adora looked willing to go with *whatever* Catra wanted.

“No, dummy.” Catra felt her ears go back a little, and her cheeks heated. “Since we can both hear it, we could dance here.”

Adroa stared at Catra’s hand for a second before she smiled and took it. Catra decided that it was the only smile she ever wanted to see on Adora’s face again.

The music was for the same kind of dance they’d shared at Princess prom. Since there were no other dancers to consider, they never had to change partners. They moved together and then apart. Sometimes they got the steps wrong, and they spun and dipped far faster than the music called for, giggling as they tripped over each other.

After two songs, the musicians began to play a slow melody, and Catra expected them to go and sit down again.

“Catra?” Adora’s voice was low and throaty. “We don’t have to stop. Would you like to slow dance?”

“How do I do that?” The couple of dances Scorpia had shown Catra were all fast.

“It’s easy.” The blonde tugged at Catra’s hands, putting one on each hip and then putting her own arms around Catra’s neck until they pressed together and Catra could tuck her head into Adora’s shoulder. “And then you just kind of sway to the music.”

The fabric of Adora’s dress and Catra’s shirt was an insubstantial barrier to the sensation of their bodies pressed together.

“They let you do this in public here?” With a shift of her hips, Catra pressed her pelvis into Adora’s and dropped her hands to

run them over Adora’s ass. “Maybe I would have switched sides sooner if you told me about that.”

In response, Adora slid her hands under Catra’s shirt. “You’re not supposed to make out on the dance floor.”

“Oh, well. Good thing it's just us, then.” Catra hooked her hand around the back of Adora’s neck and tugged her into a kiss.

Adora opened her mouth and moaned when Catra swiped her tongue over her lip. The music stopped long before they pulled apart.

“Adora?” Catra asked when they finally came up for air. They had been doing this since the War ended, but Catra wanted more.

“Yeah?” Was it Catra's imagination, or did Adora's voice sound hopeful?

“Do you want to…? I mean, we haven’t, and I…“ There was no need to finish her sentences. Adora instantly understood.

“I’d like to, but we don’t need to,” Adora replied. “If you need more time….”

Unable to meet Adora’s eyes, Catra pressed her forehead against Adora’s shoulder. “I, um, I want to,” she whispered.

"Are you sure, though? I mean…" Adora swayed them a little faster, not quite in time with the music. The pheromones of anxiety competed with those of lust.

Catra looked up. In the darkened room, her wife's eyes glinted gold where the candlelight was reflected by her wide pupils. "I’m okay. I just feel like….” Catra couldn’t go on. She didn’t know how to say that she wanted to feel Adora's skin against her fur and lick the salt from her skin. She wanted to kiss her way down her wife’s stomach until she felt Adora’s blonde thatch against her cheek. She wanted to dip between her thighs and bury herself. “I want to try. Can we try, at least? If… if you want to?"

“I would love that.” As if she could not believe that she had permission, Adora held the hem of Catra’s shirt. "In that case… Can I take this off?"

This show of nerves settled Catra enormously. Prime's fake Adora had been swift and sure. No fumbles or false steps. She always knew exactly what she was doing and was never wrong-footed.

Real Adora snorted when she laughed. She tripped over her words when she was anxious. Real Adora was a sweet dork who worked herself into the ground and could not take care of herself for five minutes. And now, real Adora was petting through the fluff on Catra’s belly and then pulling the shirt over her head. The exploratory touch made the magicat shiver. It was warm, kind, and curious. Precisely the sort of touch Catra craved right now. She wasn’t wearing a bra, and those hands crawled up toward her bare breasts.

“Can I?” Adora whispered.

“Please?” Catra whispered back. A longing to have Adora’s bare skin against her fur had her smoothing her hands over Adora’s hips. “If you’re going to do that, can I take this off?”

The scent of desire became stronger and the anxiety was fading. Adora nodded eagerly, bouncing a little on the balls of her feet.

Catra reached around to Adora’s back and pulled the zipper of the dress down, careful not to snag the fine fabric with her claws. She pushed it off of those broad shoulders so that it pooled around Adora’s feet. She leaned forward to nip the side of Adora’s neck.

The blonde ran her palms over Catra’s breasts, and then she brushed over a nipple with her thumb.

Oh, that was like… Catra could not think what it was like. The heat between her legs hijacked any higher thought she had left. Her eyes fell shut, and she angled her chin, baring her throat. Adora kissed down her neck while she gently pinched Catra’s

nipple. The move went straight to Catra's cunt; the magicat panted, and a trill emerged spontaneously from her throat.

And then, out of nowhere, Catra's breathing sped up, and she froze. The hand under Catra's shirt, feeling the change, moved gently, smoothing the fur on her sides. "Are you okay?"

The magicat gulped and nodded, reminding herself that fake Adora *never* asked anything like that.

Adora pulled back, her eyes wide and suddenly intense. It was such a one-eighty that, for an instant, Catra searched for flashes of green light. Before Catra could spiral, anxiety spiked in Adora's scent, and a frown formed between the blonde's eyebrows, and she stared into the magicat's eyes. "What's the matter?" Adora cupped her cheek. "Hey, we can stop. I won't be hurt if you want to go to bed to just cuddle some more."

"No, I don't want to stop. I had a bad minute. That's all. Can we get in bed? I'm getting cold." Catra was only wearing her pants at the moment.

"Okay. yeah." Adora shucked her slip and was down to the lacy underwear that she wore under formal stuff. She walked to the table, blew out the candles, then returned to the bed and nervously wrung her hands together. "Should we… Would it be okay if I… I mean, if it's not okay, I can…."

Catra shook her head and smiled (not that Adora could see it). "What are you trying to ask? Just spit it out."

"It's just… I'm just… scared, I guess?" She looked shyly out from under her eyelashes. "Well, maybe not scared, but I'm nervous. I wanted to get into bed naked with you, but I was worried that you'd think that was weird."

"I am one hundred percent behind that plan," Catra said, feeling more confident. Worried, shy Adora was another thing Prime could never imitate. The magicat shed her pants on the side of the bed and crawled under the covers with nothing on.

It felt strange. In the Horde, they didn't have special sleeping clothes but making yourself vulnerable by sleeping naked was not something anyone would imagine, so they kept their underwear on, at least. Here it was safe, and it felt impossibly decadent.

They lay down so that they were facing each other. It was like a thousand other nights. Only tonight, they were naked, with only desire and their fears between them.

"So, what are you scared of?" The magicat asked since they both knew what scared her.

Pursing her lips as though building up her courage, Adora asked. "Have you… have you ever done this with anyone?"

"Voluntarily?' Catra could not help saying.

Adora winced but nodded.

"No." Catra breathed out a long sigh. "Scorpia probably would have if I asked, but I knew she had a bad case of feelings. It wouldn't have been fair. I had some morals." Unable to talk about this and look Adora in the eye, she rubbed her chin in the sheets, feeling the satisfying tingle in her scent glands. "How about you?"

"No," Adora said, clearly embarrassed.

Abruptly Catra stopped scent-marking the sheets and rolled up onto her elbow to stare down at the other woman. "Seriously? Not even Sparkles?" Catra would have assumed She Ra would have a ton of people pursuing her.

"Seriously." Adora shook her head. "I've kissed and cuddled with a few people, but I could never relax enough to really do more. I just couldn't seem to connect with anyone." She closed her eyes. "You've been through so much, and I'm afraid of screwing up and hurting you again. Then I remembered what you said about sometimes it's me that scares you, and then I started worrying about how I could avoid doing anything like fake Adora, and then

I got scared that maybe that would make me act more like fake Adora… " She was cut off when Catra swooped in to kiss her.

"I love you so much," Catra whispered when she pulled back a little. The glorious giddy bubbles were back in her chest, and she smiled at her beautiful idiot, who looked up at her with concern. "I was talking to Melog about it," she explained, hoping Adora would get it. "They said maybe I should just look for the things you do that Prime couldn't fake."

Adora still looked doubtful, so Catra took her hand and brought it to her lips. "I don't need you to try to figure out how to be perfect for me. It… He…" she felt her mouth twist in an effort to get through this without crying. "It's usually just for a second that I get confused, and things get scary. Then you'll laugh, or you'll stub your toe and swear or something like that, and I know where I am again."

"What can I do?" Adora asked in her I-am-taking-notes voice.

"Relax a little. Please?" Catra said, "we'll figure it out together." She lay back down on her side so she could trail one claw down Adora's neck, gratified to watch her shiver. "If-if I start to get scared, just stop for a minute, okay? Maybe just check in with me? And then we can figure it out from there?"

"How will I know?" Adora asked.

"Huh?"

"How will I know if you get scared? I might not realize you're in trouble until it's too late."

That had not occurred to Catra. "I… don't know. I guess I could just tell you."

"I've been reading a lot of books Muriel recommended," Adora said. "The trouble with that is that it's like when you're sparring. You need to be able to call off the bout with just a word rather than explain what's going on. "

That made sense. “You want me to call a time-out?” Catra asked.

“Or use some other word, but it means that just like with a fight, everything stops, so it needs to be a word we don’t ever use otherwise.”

Catra thought for a moment and then said, very softly, “Prime.” It would be very easy to say the word if she got trapped in one of her nightmares, and Adora would understand instantly.

“Okay.”

“So, you still want to?” Catra asked.

The smile on Adora’s face and her eager nod was quite visible to Catra’s sight. Her ardor had cooled a little, but she shuffled close enough to feel Adora’s warmth on her fur, and the blonde reached for her.

Their make-out sessions had given them some idea of what they liked, but to feel Adora’s naked breast beneath her fingers was a whole different level for Catra. She leaned in and nibbled down Adora’s neck. The scent of their shared desire was thick now and only made Catra hotter.

Putting her hands between them, Adora resumed the exploration she had begun in the other room. She massaged Catra’s tits and then gently pinched a nipple. Catra stopped nibbling down Adora’s neck, and she mewled.

“Can you lie down?” Adora whispered. “I just want to love you. Will you let me?”

“Yeah. Okay.” She leaned back in the pillows, and Adora rose up on her knees.

“I want to…. “

They were never going to have time for sex if Adora kept this nonsense up. “ *Yes*, Adora,” Catra growled. “Whatever you want to

do, just do it." She was going to lose her mind if she kept stopping every two minutes.

"Seriously? Anything?" Adora asked, voice low and smug. Her chuckle made Catra wonder what she just signed up for. "Lean back then."

Catra did as she was told, and Adora straddled her hips. To be held down like this was a little challenging, but then Adora leaned forward and drew her into a kiss, being careful to keep her weight on her knees and one forearm. Catra's eyes closed as she relaxed into the kiss. Adora's free hand wandered down to her hip and then the outside of her thigh. The sense of being surrounded by her wife was delicious, and she wanted more.

"Adora?" Catra whined as the sweet-smelling blonde pulled back. She opened her eyes to see the other woman staring at her with a little smile. "What are you doing?"

No verbal answer was forthcoming. Instead, Adora's smile grew wider. She moved off of Catra's hips to the side and took Catra's nipple in her mouth. She swirled her tongue over it and echoed the movement with her hand on the other.

The sound that Catra made was almost a sob. Adora stopped. That was completely unacceptable.

"I didn't hurt you, did I? Are they still sore?"

"It's okay. I'm okay. Just, please," she panted, "I need… just keep going."

That evil grin was fast becoming familiar. "Does my kitten like that?" Adora whispered.

Any thought Catra had of being cool in this encounter went right out the window. The only reply she could make was an embarrassingly needy trill.

"Oooh. I think she does."

For a moment, Catra stilled. She felt out of control. Some part of her brain wanted to pull away. This felt too risky, too dangerous, and something terrible was going to happen.

"Shhhh. Just relax. I'm here." Adora petted through the fur on her belly soothingly for a second. It was something she had always done when they were kids. The gesture had the desired effect of quieting the frightened voice in her head. "I just want to make you feel good," she said, and then, not taking her eyes away from Catra's face, she licked her fingers and thumb. It was the same sensual gesture she had used while eating. Then she reached out to continue stroking Catra's breast with her wet fingers. The magicat's eyes shut, and Adora's mouth descended on her other breast.

Watching Adora eat again without getting hot and bothered was going to be impossible, Catra decided with some distant, sane brain cell. The rest of her was caught up in the sensation. She thought she might be able to get off with just this. That felt astonishing- she rarely thought about her breasts. They weren't big enough to be a nuisance like Lonnie or Adora's, and she had never even considered playing with them when she masturbated. However, Adora was apparently into tits. Their cuddles and makeout sessions always featured Adora nuzzling and caressing them copiously, but given how sore they had been, her wife had apparently been holding herself back.

The thought was confirmed when Adora paused long enough to ask, "Are they still sore?"

"No. And I give you about a hundred years to stop doing that," Catra gasped.

Adora chuckled around the flesh in her mouth, the vibration making Catra writhe. The hand that had been playing with her chest began to roam back to her stomach, reaching her naval. It hesitated as if to give Catra time to object, and then it kept going until it reach the fluffier fur that led to her crotch, where it again

paused, flattening and resting the palm against her pubic bone, seemingly waiting for permission again.

A wild frustration grabbed Catra by the throat. "Keep going," she growled, not even sure what Adora intended, but only knowing that she needed it, whatever it was.

Those long fingers moved from her pubic bone to caress the inside of her thigh, and the warm, wet mouth left her nipple. Catra whined and writhed with the loss of contact, but she understood. They had not yet gone this far, even over Catra's clothes-- the first time Adora had tried, Catra had a minor panic attack.

But tonight was different. The hand squeezed her thigh, and Catra opened her eyes to see Adora's tender smile, checking in with her.

Deliberately, Catra took Adora's hand and pulled it a little further north, towards her center. There was a curious little hitch in Adora's expression, and another whiff of anxiety joined the swirl of lust in the air. "Please?" Catra almost begged, warmed, and reassured by the consideration but was absolutely certain that if Adora did not keep going, Catra was probably going to spontaneously combust.

"You mean like this?" Adora's hand trailed up her thigh, ruffling her fur, and Catra opened her legs. For a second, Adora held her vulva, pressing against it so that Catra instinctively ground down, chasing the pressure and friction. One finger tentatively dipped past her labia into her slick folds.

Yes. Oh, yes. Just like that. The only thing Catra could utter out loud was another trill, but this one was deeper and needier.

"You look so beautiful like this," Adora whispered into Catra's ear as the magicat fisted the sheets next to her hips and threw her head back with a moan. The hand left her crotch, and Catra would

have wept with frustration, but then the hand was stroking her breast again, rubbing the slick onto her nipple.

“F-fuck,” Catra stuttered, her brain short-circuiting. “Oh, fuck.”

“That is the plan,” Adora said smugly as she bent to take the nipple back into her mouth, licking and sucking Catra’s lubrication from it. Then she moved her hand back down to the thick warmth of Catra’s pubic hair and petted through it. More confidently, this time, she pressed against her labia, letting Catra rock against her to get a little relief, but it only made the magicat feel more desperate and feral.

“Please?” It seemed that Catra’s entire vocabulary had been reduced to helpless entreaties and curses. The only other sounds she was capable of making were the trills and mews that Adora seemed to delight in pulling out of her. She lifted her hips from the bed a little and wrapped one arm around Adora’s neck, and nuzzled into her hair at the top of her head.

The sensation of teeth biting the tenderest part of her chest made Catra cry out and gasp. At the same time, two fingers dipped into her touch her entrance as Adora explored. “Do you touch yourself here?” she asked.

Catra assumed that was a rhetorical question, but she went along with it anyway. “Yes,” she gasped.

“Do you think of me when you do?” The fingers came forward to find Catra’s clitoris.

“Yes,” Catra admitted, writhing.

“That is so hot. You are such a good kitten.” Seemingly as a reward, one finger rubbed the side of Catra’s clit, the touch light and cautious.

The touch and the words brought brand new desperation to Catra’s moans. Her cunt felt achingly empty.

“Can you take more?” Adora checked.

“Please!” Catra could take *so much* more. She wanted to be filled up, and she wanted some hard friction.

“Like this?” Long fingers slipped inside her, but they just stayed still. “Tell me how you like it,” Adora suddenly snapped as though questioning a prisoner.

That thought set off a wave of absolutely obscene images in Catra’s brain that only added to her fever. She wanted to feel Adora’s strength. She wanted to belong to her. “Oh. Please. I need more… I need you. I need to feel you. Please, please,” she panted. “I need it.”

“Tell me what you need.” Never before had Adora sounded so sinister or sexy. “I’ll give it to you, but you have to ask with words.” She rocked her fingers a little as if to show Catra what she could have.

Catra tried to press down on those fingers, but Adora kept them stubbornly still. Writhing, trying to get herself to say the words in her brain, she kept her eyes closed so she could concentrate on gasping out, “I-I want you to fuck me hard,” she whimpered. It seemed okay to admit that. However, there was something else she wanted that felt too weird to say.

But Adora knew her too well and nuzzled against Catra’s ear. “You are holding back on me,” she growled with mock menace. “I don’t want you to do that. I want to know.”

That reduced Catra to inarticulate moans, and then Adora rocked her fingers enough to show her what she was missing. “Tell me," she demanded.

“I want you to suck on my tit while you do it,” Catra babbled. “I want to feel your teeth.”

“Good kitten. Thank you for telling me.” Wet heat enveloped her nipple again, along with the sharp sensation of teeth, and the

fingers began to move. Catra rolled her hips up to meet every thrust, growling and moaning.

There was fumbling as Adora tried to change the angle of her thrusts, but it was awkward because of the way she was latched onto Catra's chest. She seemed to give up and lifted her head long enough to say, "Touch yourself. I want you to stroke your clitoris. I want to see you come," she ordered. "Do it now."

Too far gone to even play at refusal, Catra slipped her hand down to her erect clit and found she was completely soaked. She would not be shocked to discover that she was dripping onto the bed at this point.

The hand in her cunt pulled out, and Catra whined, wanting it back but too strung out to say anything beyond that. Then Adora smoothed the slippery stuff onto the other tit and latched onto it, licking and nibbling as if it was the most wonderful thing she had ever tasted. At last, she began thrusting into Catra again.

For a moment, all Catra could hear was her own ragged breathing. All she could smell was their combined arousal. She rubbed faster at her clit and felt all her muscles begin to tense up.

Suddenly the fingers in her cunt seemed larger, but Catra could not think why, and it did not matter because it was still so good.

"I want you to come for me now. I want to see it." Adora ordered almost sternly.

And that was the push Catra needed. Her whole body locked up, and she could feel her vaginal muscles roll down in waves over those large fingers. Her vision whited out as the peak swept over her.

"Catra? " Adora's worried voice said as Catra came back to herself. "Are you okay? You went all limp."

Catra nodded. She was okay. Better than okay. "Give me a minute," she gasped, curling into Adora's strong arms, purring.

“That was so good,” she mumbled before Adora could misinterpret. “I have never come that hard before.”

“You are so beautiful when you come,” Adora told her.

The only answer Catra had to that was an abashed trill.

“Are you sleepy?” asked Adora.

Catra was, but she also knew that etiquette demanded she give Adora as good as she got. “Kind of,” she whispered.

“You sleep then.”

“What about you?” mumbled Catra, already succumbing.

“You can owe me,” Adora said placidly. “We’ll just have to continue this tomorrow.

Catra could do that.

“I love you so much” were the last words she heard as she slipped into slumber.

End

Chapter End Notes

I finally finished this one!

Now I can start working on "Fighting Sleep" again.

Hope everyone enjoyed it!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!